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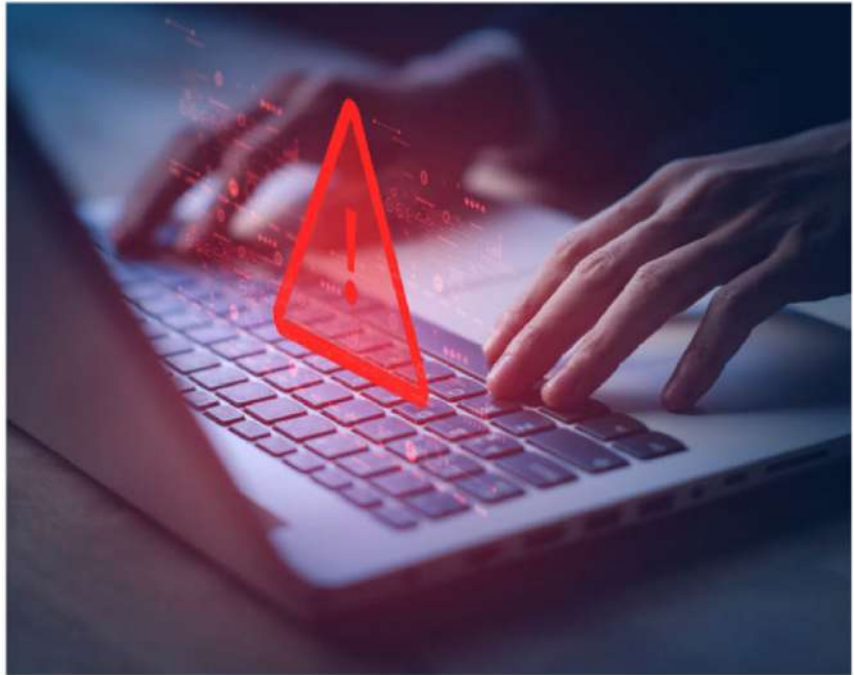


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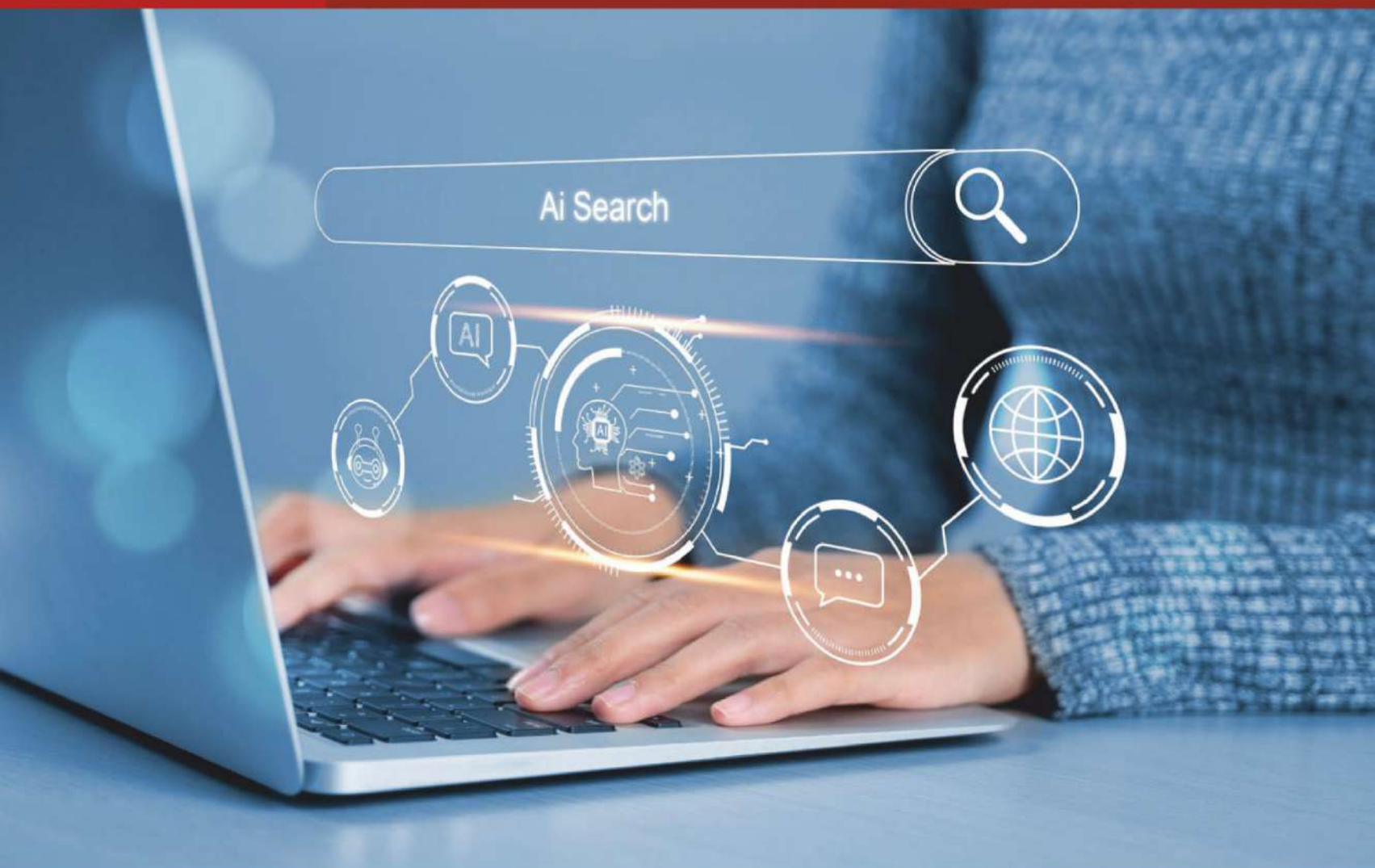
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Google brings AI-powered search to all U.S. users

Times are getting tougher for your favorite websites. **BY MARK HACHMAN**

Whether you embrace it or not, AI is shaping the future of Google Search. Google is bringing AI Mode to Google Search for every U.S. user.

Google in May 2024 launched AI Overviews (fave.co/3KKfHZ3), which aims to answer your question before showing the traditional list of links. AI Mode is the next

step: From what Google has shown, the list of links will disappear entirely, replaced by tiny link icons that link back to the information Google is slurping up.

Google's Liz Reid, a Google vice president and head of Google Search, said that AI Overviews totals 1.5 billion users and will be expanded to over 200 countries. At the beginning of May, Google migrated AI

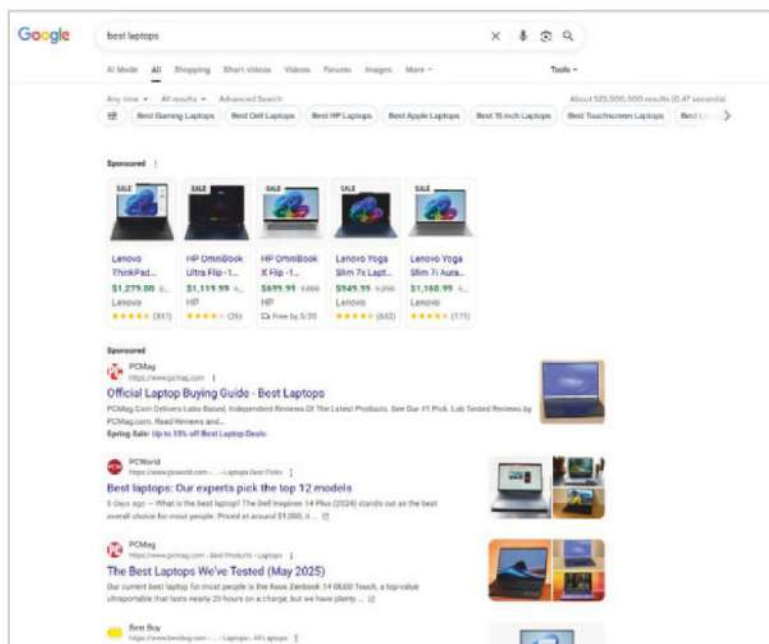
Mode out of its Labs environment (fave.co/4n5TSFI) into a small subset of users in the real world and has apparently replaced the “I’m feeling lucky” button (fave.co/4jN3O3x) with an AI search button as well.

It’s not clear whether AI Mode will be the default search for all U.S. users, or whether Google will allow users to express a preference or preserve the choices they’ve made before. Traditional search doesn’t look like it will go away, but it will be relegated to a different tab, in much the same way a search for Images requires you to shift to another search tab within Google. Reid said it’s bringing AI Mode to AI overviews, too.

(After Google I/O’s initial keynote concluded, Google pushed out AI Mode to Google Search, but it defaulted to a traditional list of links, at least from my perspective. A screenshot is further below.)

“We use what we call a query fan-out technique,” Reid said, in describing how AI Mode works. “And this basically takes your question and it breaks it up into different subtopics, and then we search on each of those different search topics that allows us to go way deeper in the web and find that really hyper-relevant, incredibly specific content that might be great with you.”

Google said that it’s upgrading the version of Gemini that powers its AI Mode to



Google Search, at least for now, defaults to a traditional list of links, but AI Mode appears as well.

a more advanced version and bringing the technology to mobile, too. Deep Search will be more like the Deep Research mode in Gemini, where, behind the scenes, Gemini will issue dozens of separate searches and then aggregate the results. Google’s AI Mode may even generate custom graphs to present information from search and finance questions, Reid said.

Agentic search is coming to AI Mode, too. What Google has previously called Project Mariner can be used to research the cheapest seats for a specific game. AI Mode will then start digging through various shopping sites and point you to the cheapest seats. Finally, the Project Astra technology Google showed off last year is being added to Gemini Live so that it can “see” through

your smartphone's camera and then talk through any problems you might have. You can also add data from Gmail, Google Drive, and so on to your searches.

"We're going to be pulling all of that in," Reid said. "You're going to always be in control. So it's your choice to opt in to doing this in the first place, but you can connect and disconnect it at any time going forward."

BAD NEWS FOR TECH PUBLISHERS

It's impossible to entirely disconnect what Google is doing or how it will affect major media—meaning that it's difficult to remain entirely objective. Put simply, Google's AI overviews and AI Mode pass off third-party news, opinions, roundups, and data as (almost) Google's own, links or not. Major publishers are beginning to sound alarm bells (fave.co/4kZEIor), and even Google itself is worried about losing money from Google Search ads (fave.co/4mVr562).

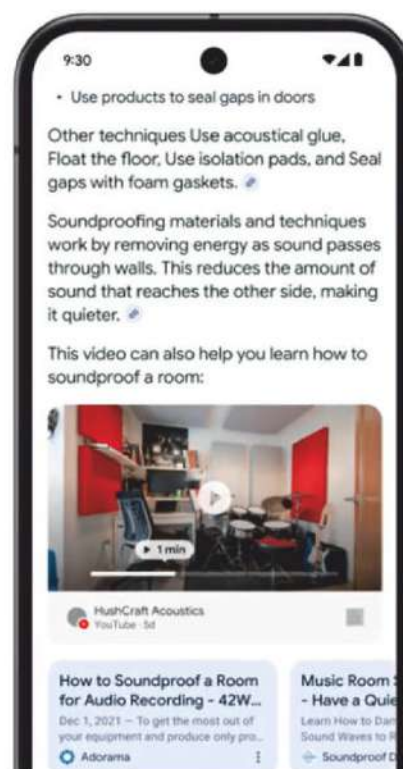
Will users click through to the sites where an AI Mode summary originates? Search data says no, though Google disagrees.

"What we've seen with AI overviews is that pages with AI overviews get higher-quality clicks to websites," Reid said. "And you might ask, what does that really mean? And what it means is people spend more time on those websites. They're not going to those sites and immediately figuring out it's not

what they want and bouncing back. They're really digging in to the content there, and that's our goal with AI Mode as well."

Google seems like it's under pressure from Wall Street, which seems to be wondering if Google will fall behind Anthropic and OpenAI, both of which use AI to replace traditional search results. Microsoft, too, has an AI-powered replacement for Bing Search (fave.co/4n4knLo) waiting in the wings, called Copilot Search. But Google remains the Web's top search engine, and it apparently aims to stay that way.

"The way you can think about that is AI mode is not just this AI-powered experience end to end, but it also is a glimpse of what's to come in search overall," Reid said. Great. 🔥



Google's AI Overviews in action. Links are either presented as tiny icons or buried at the very bottom of the summary.

The Asus ROG Xbox Ally is ashamed of Windows

"This is an Xbox," declare both Microsoft and Asus. But the fact that it's running Windows is a little obfuscated by both the promo material and the device itself.

BY MICHAEL CRIDER



playALLYourgames, proclaims the first bit of marketing copy for the ROG Xbox Ally (fave.co/43YmgAg), the third-gen Asus handheld PC that's also borrowing Microsoft's Xbox brand. "This is an Xbox," declares the very next line. The design even gets a new, dedicated Xbox button right on its face.

But between the bombastic branding (fave.co/3FAeVyX) and the lack of the familiar bottom taskbar on any of the promotional images for this redesigned gaming gadget, it's hard to tell that this is, in fact, a Windows-powered gaming PC. Asus and Microsoft seem far more interested in talking about a revamped full-screen interface for the dedicated Xbox app and the accompanying

Game Bar than the underlying operating system that lets you play all your games.

It's the defining feature of most handheld PCs versus Valve's Linux-powered Steam Deck, which only just got its second official companion under the SteamOS umbrella (the Lenovo Legion Go S, fave.co/4jkwTnV). Windows enables the ROG Xbox Ally—and all the handheld PCs that came after the Steam Deck—to play a wider gamut of games. The most notable among them are some of the most popular, including online multiplayer games that require proprietary anti-cheat software not available on Linux.

HANDHELD WINDOWS GAMING PC WOES

The fact that Windows 11 is hidden behind layers of optimized user interface might seem a little strange—unless, of course, you've actually used one of these Windows-powered handhelds (fave.co/4e098PS). A common—hell, practically universal—complaint is that Windows 11 just isn't built for a screen this small, or an interface that leans more on a game controller than a mouse or touchscreen.

Windows 11 is also far heavier in terms of system load than SteamOS, causing

lower performance in games and faster battery drain. That's why many users have tried rolling their own versions of SteamOS onto devices like the Ally, and why they're excited that Valve is extending SteamOS support to other handhelds. Microsoft seems to have taken notice, as you'll see later in this article.

It's not as if Microsoft or Asus are completely hiding the fact that the ROG Xbox Ally runs Windows. Its ability to run all Windows-powered games is a touted feature. But even the name of the device, leaning on a console legacy that's been notably distinct from Windows for most of its three-decade run, seems like it's ashamed to admit that it's a computer. You can, indeed, run Outlook on the ROG Xbox Ally, but you might make its RGB lights blush with embarrassment if you tried.



The ROG Xbox Ally's ability to run all Windows-powered games is a touted feature.

THE XBOX HAS SEEN BETTER DAYS...

It's an odd situation, exacerbated by an extremely fluid and dynamic gaming market. Technically, PC gaming has never been hotter or more accessible versus consoles. Even if you're running a 10-year-old clunker of a laptop, there are literally tens of thousands of games you can grab on Steam and enjoy, most of them relatively inexpensive.

The Steam Deck itself is proof that you don't need a screaming gaming PC to dive into the space, as it's making do with a relatively light laptop chip and no discrete GPU. And the Xbox brand, at least when restricted to its console namesake, isn't looking so hot. The Xbox One got its boxy butt handed to it by the PS4 and the Switch, and the confusing and fragmented Xbox Series X/S hasn't reversed course at all (fave.co/441ZcA).



Microsoft's Xbox X and S sales are struggling against Sony's PlayStation and Nintendo's Switch.

It's bad enough that some analysts have been wondering if Microsoft is even going to bother with a fifth generation of Xbox console hardware. (The scuttlebutt right now is yes, it's still coming: fave.co/3FRjKns.)

...BUT XBOX ISN'T JUST THE XBOX ANYMORE

The box sitting next to your TV is no longer all Xbox has to offer. Microsoft has spent hundreds of billions of dollars beefing up both its stable of game developers and publishers, and the Xbox Game Pass as a platform. *Everything* is now an Xbox, with phones, tablets, laptops, and smart TVs getting access to the biggest new games from Microsoft and its partners, either locally or via streaming. All it takes is yet another monthly subscription...but one that makes a damn good pitch for value, especially as new games stretch to \$70 and \$80 a pop.

Oh, yeah, Microsoft is on the \$80 game train now. That was a less welcome surprise in its June Xbox showcase (fave.co/3FYwoB3), where the ROG Xbox Ally was officially revealed. The fact that its primary gaming product is now a \$20-per-month subscription is probably just a coincidence.

But I digress. Even if the Xbox hardware has become something of an albatross around Microsoft's neck, the Xbox *brand* and *service* and its associated games are still very much in play. In that sense, and in the context of Microsoft's ambitions to bring games to every possible screen in your life, the Xbox label on the Ally handheld makes sense.

No, it's not the portable Xbox some fans have been waiting for since the days of the Duke...but in practical terms, it might as well be. It doesn't run the even-more-locked-down OS powering the Xbox, but it plays basically every Xbox game that's currently relevant, and a pretty good chunk of the console classics via streaming or a few bucks on Steam.

WINDOWS 11 GOES GAMER MODE

Scratch the surface of the new Xbox Ally and you'll see it's running Windows, which comes with as many problems as it solves (or more). Now that we have the Legion Go S, we can run head-to-head tests on identical handhelds running official builds of Windows 11 and SteamOS—and SteamOS is better by a considerable margin (fave.co/43EiLab), even if you don't care about longer battery life or a



The full-screen Xbox app interface is an attempt to adapt some of the work Valve has put into SteamOS.

smoother interface. (And on a device that's built on easy, fast access to games, you probably do.)

So what's the solution if you're Microsoft? Or, indeed, any of its hardware partners who want to sell Windows-powered handhelds? For the better part of a year, we've been hearing about how Windows is going to get better on these low-power, gaming-focused gadgets (fave.co/3HDBumX). The full-screen Xbox app interface is a big step, which is clearly trying to adapt some of the work Valve has put into SteamOS. And it's not going to be exclusive to the ROG Xbox Ally, as Microsoft has already said it'll be available to other handheld gaming PCs in 2026, shortly after the Asus launch.

A fresh user interface is good news for anyone who dreads having to edit .ini files

on a 7-inch touchscreen. The second part of the equation is slimming down Windows itself. According to Microsoft Vice President Jason Beaumont, the ROG Xbox Ally is essentially running a slimmed-down version of Windows 11 when it boots into that Xbox interface.

Windows 11 Home is still there, waiting just beneath the gaming veneer. But a lot of the gears that keep Windows compatible with software that was written 30 years ago are kept dormant until you switch to the regular desktop mode. “When the player boots into the full-screen experience, there is a whole bunch of Windows stuff that doesn’t get loaded,” Beaumont told The Verge ([fave.co/3HBIFx3](https://www.theverge.com/3HBIFx3)). “We’re not loading the desktop wallpaper, the taskbar, or a bunch of processes that are really designed around productivity scenarios for Windows.”

“Player,” not “user,” I notice. And even though Xbox-branded software and the Xbox Game Pass service will be front and center in the interface, it’ll automatically populate your game library with titles from Steam, Epic, and other digital storefronts. This aggregated omnibus of local and streaming games will be the new standard for the Xbox app, on desktops and handhelds. And according to Beaumont, other Windows-powered handheld PCs will get the slimmed-down, gaming-focused launcher mode in 2026, too.

HANDHELD PC GAMING IN FOCUS

That *might* be enough to make Windows-powered handhelds stand out against the Steam Deck, which is outselling them by an order of magnitude the last time I checked ([fave.co/426zyen](https://www.fave.co/426zyen)). The fact these devices are getting access to much newer chips, from both AMD and Intel, is also worth considering. As wonderfully efficient as the Steam Deck is, newer AAA titles can tax it or sometimes even defeat it. That’s only going to become more apparent as the three-year-old Valve device shows its age and doesn’t appear poised for a significant update anytime soon.

Both Asus and Microsoft are leaning far more on the Xbox part of the ROG Xbox Ally than the gaming PC part, even though the latter is the bedrock of its hardware and software. But its success, and perhaps the continued viability of Windows in the handheld space, will still depend on how Microsoft adapts Windows to this burgeoning form factor.

One thing I’m hoping to see, which I haven’t yet seen any evidence for, is full-power gaming laptops that run SteamOS ([fave.co/4gUsAxX](https://www.fave.co/4gUsAxX)) out of the box. Now I’m wondering if a slimmed-down Windows 11, shifted into a leaner and more efficient “Xbox mode,” might be just as exciting. Maybe that Xbox logo could start appearing on Asus ROG laptops, too. Hey, it’d make a cooler keyboard button than Copilot. 



Chrome will offer to replace your worst passwords with just one click soon

Google is rolling out a new feature in Chrome that'll automatically replace your bad passwords with new, strong ones. **BY LAURA PIPPIG AND JOEL LEE**

At Google I/O 2025 in May, we saw some pretty exciting innovations. In addition to a new AI search in Google (see page 7) and the ability to try on clothes virtually before you buy them (fave.co/3HRdFba), one improvement stands out

for how it protects users who might be using inadequate passwords.

It isn't too difficult to come up with a strong password (fave.co/4dXnDDU), but you need a unique password for every single account if you want to be truly safe on the web. One way to offload that burden is to use

a password manager (fave.co/3IRkfRz) that stores your unique login credentials and enters them for you, relieving you of the need to memorize anything.

Google Chrome already has a built-in password manager (fave.co/4ndgVhw) that can detect weak passwords as well as compromised passwords that have been leaked in data breaches. Going forward, when it detects them, it'll offer to replace those passwords with new ones with just one click.

As Google explains in a developer blog post (fave.co/3TkQVCV):

"When Chrome detects a compromised password during sign in, Google Password Manager prompts the user with an option to fix it automatically.

"On supported websites, Chrome can generate a strong replacement and update the password for the user automatically.

"This reduces friction and helps users to keep their account secure, without hunting through account settings or abandoning the process partway."

WHEN WILL THIS BE POSSIBLE?

According to Google, the new feature will be rolled out gradually for all Chrome users over the course of 2025. The key detail in Google's statement, however, is that it'll only work on supported websites.

Exactly which sites support the feature isn't explained in detail. Presumably, they'll

be frequently used sites that require a login (social networks, streaming services, Amazon, and so on). And even if it doesn't work everywhere, it's still a practical innovation for those who don't want to—or can't—take care of their passwords themselves.

ONLY WITH EXPLICIT CONSENT

The developers emphasize that Chrome can't change anything without your consent. With every automatic password change, regardless of whether it's due to a weak or leaked password, you'll receive a prompt in the browser and can accept (or reject) the change. This is intended to keep you in control of your passwords at all times and prevent you from losing track of frequent changes.

Chrome's password manager can already detect weak and compromised credentials by comparing your encrypted usernames and passwords against its own database of known-to-be-compromised login data. That alone is pretty helpful, but recognizing bad passwords and instantly changing them for you? That's a game-changer, especially since you don't have to memorize the new passwords. They're stored in the password manager and can be retrieved on demand.

Note, however, that Google isn't the only company to offer such a service in its password manager. But in this case, the feature is completely free. The only issue is that it'll only work for certain websites. 

HP's new Snapdragon-powered OLED laptops start at \$799

The OmniBook 5 comes in 14-inch and 16-inch varieties, with pedestrian looks and specs but a price that'll turn heads. They arrive in the US in July. **BY MICHAEL CRIDER**



Arm-based Windows laptops running Qualcomm Snapdragon processors are all the rage, at least if you hear it from Microsoft or its manufacturing partners. But they aren't exactly affordable, or even a good value compared to Intel or AMD (fave.co/3FK7Rjh). But the newest mid-range offerings from HP will start at \$800, paired with 16GB of RAM. That's a number that makes my eyebrows pop up.

The OmniBook 5 14 (ugh, not great names, folks) is getting that impressive base price, offering an 8-core Snapdragon X Plus

processor, 16GB of RAM, and a rather paltry 256GB of storage in that introductory \$799 price. Upgrade options include a faster Snapdragon X (sans Plus) processor, 32GB of RAM, and up to 1TB of storage, though we don't yet know how much those will run you. You get a 14-inch 1920×1200 OLED panel standard, nice, but you'll have to shell out for a touchscreen upgrade. Frankly, I like that setup—there are a lot of people who want OLED, and a lot who don't necessarily need to get fingerprints on a screen, especially in a conventional clamshell form factor.



The newest midrange offerings from HP will start at \$800, paired with 16GB of RAM.

An IR camera for Windows Hello (fave.co/3ImacXy) is also standard, as is a 59-watt-hour battery with 65-watt charging via USB-C. Speaking of which, you get two of those, supporting a maximum external resolution of 5K. There's also one USB-A port and a headphone jack, but no mention of a full-sized HDMI port or any card reader.

With rather low-key white-and-gray looks, an aluminum and plastic chassis, and a weight of just under three pounds, the OmniBook 5 14 isn't going to turn any heads. But if it's offering a good value, especially if some of those upgrades aren't too steep, it doesn't need to.

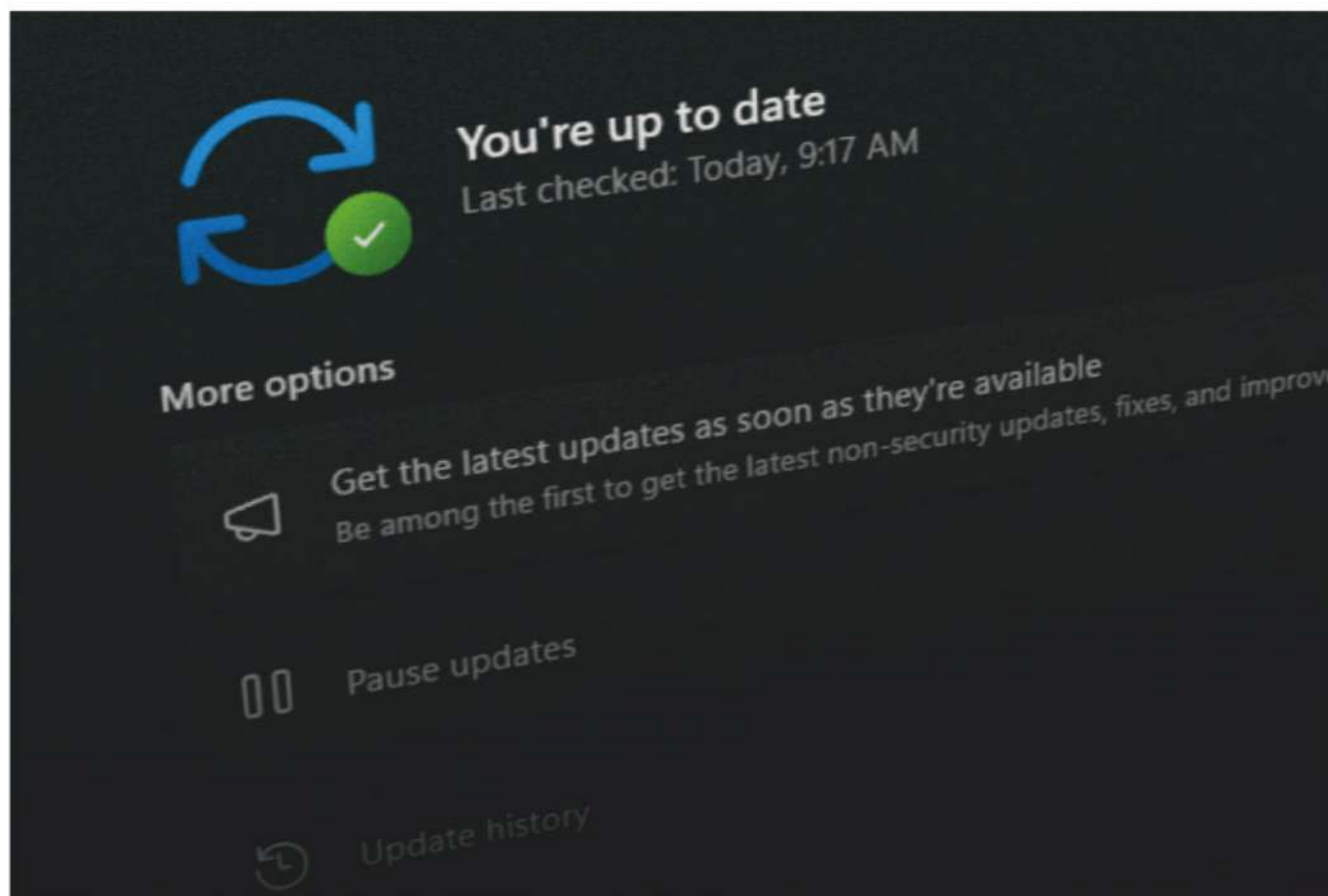
Looking for a little more screen real estate? Then the Omnibook 5 16—oh, my god, these names—offers a lot of the same capability with a 16-inch screen upgrade. It has almost identical specs, including the same screen resolution, battery, ports, and keyboard. But the good news is that it starts at just \$849—fifty bucks for that bigger screen isn't bad at all, even if the other extras are lacking.

According to HP's announcement materials, both of these laptops will hit U.S. shelves in July. Expect to see the 14-inch laptop on shelves at all the big stores, including Amazon,

Best Buy, MicroCenter, and Costco. They look like good value picks to me, especially if you can wait a bit for a sale. And those Snapdragon processors should offer great battery life. 🔋



The Omnibook 5 16 also offers a lot of the same capability with a 16-inch screen upgrade.



Microsoft wants all app and driver updates to go through Windows Update

The new unified Windows Update orchestration platform aims to be your one-stop shop for all software updates. **BY MICHAEL CRIDER**

When it comes to phones, most software is updated through a unified process. With an iPhone, you get all your operating system updates from Apple and all your individual app updates from the App Store. Android phones are similar, if

slightly more fragmented. Now what if Windows worked in the same way, centralizing all your software needs and updating everything in one spot? Microsoft wants that.

Microsoft product manager Angie Chen announced the new Windows Update

orchestration platform (a classic Microsoft name if ever I heard one, fave.co/4jHQ7Tr) via the IT Pro blog (fave.co/4mY3u4R).

There's a lot of technical jargon on the page, but it boils down to this: Developers will be able to join the platform to deliver software updates for just about anything from within Windows—from the tiniest programs to the most crucial drivers to giant packages like Adobe Creative Suite—all going through Windows Update.

Users would obviously benefit from a more seamless and streamlined update system, one that's (again) very much inspired by the way mobile operating systems work. Developers would be able to more reliably deliver updates without having to wait for users to launch their apps locally and check with a ping (or make yet another annoying

"launch with Windows" thingy gobbling up your RAM in the taskbar). Microsoft's orchestrator system will scan the updates for safety and distribute them, installing them at an ideal time when the user's system isn't under load. Other benefits include a unified update log, centralized update notifications, and "automatic future enhancements."

It isn't perfect, as you might expect given Microsoft's previous attempts to unify software systems like the Microsoft Store. There's already a contingency in place for apps that really do require a full system reboot before launching again after updating, which frankly sounds exhausting. But I'm someone who's mostly been handling my own downloads for 30-plus years, so I may not be entirely neutral here. Notably, there's no indication in the blog post that conventional

software downloads and isolated updates will be phased out.

The program is in the extreme early stages right now, as there's not even a dedicated page for the onboarding process. If you're a developer and you want in, you'll need to reach out via email to unifiedorchestrator@service.microsoft.com. 



Users will benefit from a more streamlined update system.

Nvidia's GeForce Now app transformed my Steam Deck. I'm never going back

Nvidia's native GeForce Now app offers transformative improvements to the Steam Deck's biggest limitations. **BY BRAD CHACOS**



Valve's beloved Steam Deck is a delightful little device that makes PC gaming possible anywhere, but it suffers from some significant limitations. The Deck's custom AMD Ryzen "Aerith" processor requires severe graphical sacrifices to hit playable frame rates in intense games—if you can run them at all. When you're playing, you'll blow through the battery in just a few hours. And while non-Steam games can be added to the Deck, it requires wonky technical

workarounds that normie gamers probably won't bother to troubleshoot.

Enter Nvidia's new GeForce Now native app for the Steam Deck (fave.co/4n43v7q), available now. If your internet signal is strong, and you pay for a premium GeForce Now subscription (fave.co/3CbTcjz) with advanced prowess and features, Nvidia's app transforms the Steam Deck from a delightful device into an utterly magical one.

How magical? Consider that *Doom: The Dark Ages* has been called a "nightmare" on

the Steam Deck (fave.co/3ZYURNq). Even with every graphics option turned to low, playing through the sparsely populated tutorial section results in frame rates in the low- to mid-20s—it not only looks ugly, it feels atrocious, like the Doom Slayer is a container ship you're trying to steer while blackout drunk. Hard pass.

Then I flipped over to it on GeForce Now's new Steam Deck app, using an early build (and GFN Ultimate subscription) provided by Nvidia. *Oh. My. God.* Suddenly, everything was beautiful and *smooth*, with the Doom Slayer ripping and tearing through demonic hordes like the finely tuned weapon he is. Even with graphics settings set to the strenuous Nightmare level and rays being traced everywhere, performance ran locked at the 60fps maximum that GFN offers on the Deck.

GeForce Now made an unplayable game deliciously perky. But that's not the only

benefit: With my Steam Deck's battery life lingering around 86 percent, the system's performance overlay estimated I'd get around 1 hour and 44 minutes of play time before juice ran out. Streaming the game over GFN doesn't tap into the Steam Deck's resources nearly as heavily, and the performance overlay said *exactly the same scene with exactly the same battery level* would deliver over 7 hours of playtime.

Wowza. Now *that's* transformative—though Nvidia only officially claims battery-life improvements of “up to 50 percent” over native Steam Deck performance.

AMAZING PERFORMANCE AND BATTERY LIFE

And Doom: The Dark Ages isn't the only example. I also fired up *Witcher 3* and *Cyberpunk 2077*, a pair of CD Projekt Red's heavy hitters that come with native Steam

Deck graphics settings.

In a bustling Novigrad Square teeming with NPCs, *Witcher 3* achieved surprisingly playable frame rates—I was cruising around with Geralt to the tune of 50 to 60 fps. Not bad...though the graphics looked muddier than I'd prefer, and the battery was only expected to last around 2 hours.



***Doom: The Dark Ages* runs poorly on Steam Deck—but it streams amazingly over GeForce Now, even with Nightmare graphics settings.**

Then I booted into *Witcher 3* via GeForce Now. *What a difference.* Using the game's Ultra settings with ray tracing in full bloom, Geralt suddenly looked so much crisper and more vivid—and once again, the game played locked at 60fps on GFN Ultimate's hardware (equivalent to an RTX 4080), with a runtime estimate of over 7 hours. That's transformative!

The story remained the same in *Cyberpunk 2077*, which includes a Steam Deck graphics preset that drops visuals low enough to run at a locked 30fps. It's muddy but playable! Streaming over GeForce Now, however, lets me run the game's gorgeous RT Ultra mode at a locked 60fps while looking crisp, clean, and even more responsive. (The in-game benchmark said the Steam Deck mode ran at locked 30fps; RT Ultra over GFN ran at 86fps per the benchmark, but Nvidia's servers delivered it as a locked 60fps. Nvidia says a 90fps mode is "being evaluated for future release.")

Better yet, estimated battery life increased from 1:09 in Steam Deck mode to 4:02 via GeForce Now—all while looking and feeling so much better than native performance.



***Witcher 3* runs fine on Steam Deck natively—but look at how low-quality the visuals are in order to achieve playable performance.**

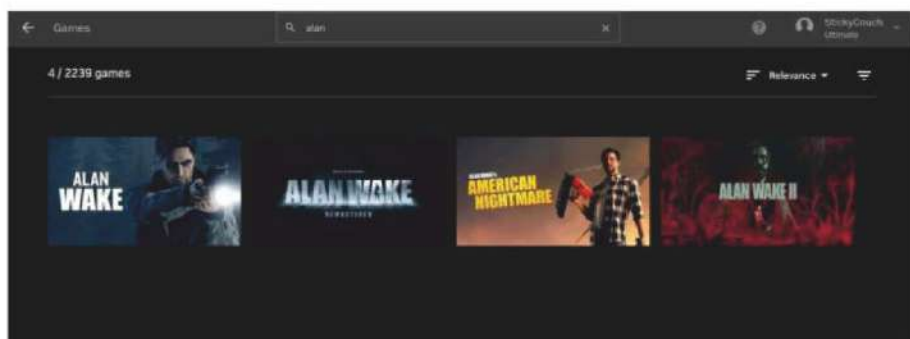
GEFORCE NOW PLAYS STEAM DECK GAMES VALVE WON'T SELL YOU

Another feather in the cap for GeForce Now's new native Steam Deck app? It lets you play games Valve won't sell you.

The Steam Deck is amazing, but it's obviously built around Valve's storefront. Installing non-Steam games on the Deck (fave.co/43Yvg8w) involves heading to the gadget's desktop mode and tweaking arcane settings, or installing third-party apps that (hopefully) automate the process a bit. It's clunky.

Not with GeForce Now.

Nvidia's service lets you link your GeForce Now account with major PC gaming storefronts—Steam, yes, but also alternatives like Ubisoft, Microsoft's Xbox Game Pass, and the Epic Games Store. Once you've done so,



You've got lots of *Alan Wake* options on GeForce Now's Steam Deck app—including the Epic-exclusive *Alan Wake 2*.

any of the 2,000-plus games supported by GFN (fave.co/4jOzXro) will easily be playable by simply searching for them in Nvidia's interface and launching the game.

Want to play *Alan Wake 2* (an Epic exclusive) on your Steam Deck with full fidelity? Yeah, the GeForce Now app can do that. Want to stream *Forza Horizon* through your Game Pass sub? Yeah, you can do that too. The GeForce Now library isn't exhaustive, but it is huge, and it adds games every week. It's an instant level-up for your Steam Deck's capabilities if you have games stashed on other PC storefronts too.

Better yet, since GFN is now a native app, it'll appear in the Recently Played section of your Steam Deck's homescreen—making it dead simple to leap back into games you've streamed via Nvidia's servers.

DETAILS YOU NEED TO KNOW

Of course, you need to be a GeForce Now subscriber to take advantage of the new

Steam Deck native app. The app supports all tiers, including the ad-supported free tier, but paying for higher tiers unlocks ad-free streaming, RTX capabilities, higher resolutions, ultrawide monitor support, and—if you pay for the Ultimate tier—DLSS Frame

Gen, Nvidia's latency-lowering Reflex tech, and HDR10 support that looks oh so good on the Steam Deck OLED Nvidia sent me for testing. The paid tiers offer 100 hours of gameplay a month, with 15 rollover hours.

Nvidia is currently running a GeForce Now summer sale (fave.co/3SN67sk) that knocks 40 percent off a six-month Performance plan, down to \$30 for six months. It lacks some of the features of the Ultimate tier, but should deliver a wondrous experience on your Steam Deck, even if Valve's handheld can't take advantage of its 1440p option—GFN streams at 1080p/60 undocked. If you connect a monitor to your Steam Deck, GFN can output at 1440p/120Hz, or 4K/60Hz when connected to a television.

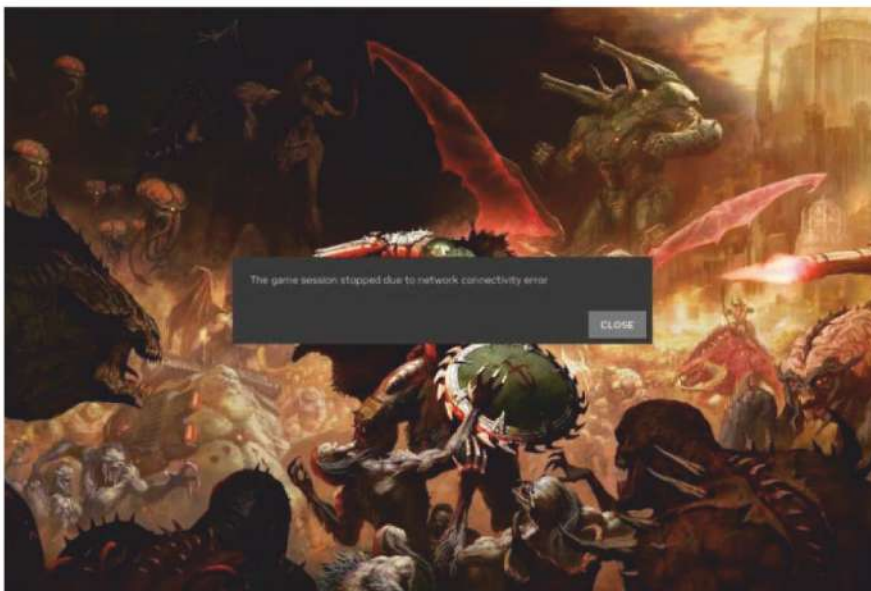
As a streaming service, GeForce Now obviously requires a strong internet connection. In tests around my apartment in a small city, it held up well over my Comcast home connection, though performance sometimes suffered playing in the furthest

reaches of my home. Your mileage may vary depending on your home network situation and whether you're tethering off a mobile connection, but in general, Nvidia's streaming service is fairly rock-solid these days.

One tidbit to be aware of: Since GeForce Now relies on active internet streaming, it's incompatible with the Steam Deck's quick resume function. If you power off your Deck mid-GeFN stream, it'll crash when the system wakes back up. I wouldn't want to rely on GFN for a morning bus commute unless your phone can power a banging Wi-Fi hotspot.

JUST PLAY IT

Bottom line, though? Nvidia's GeForce Now app (fave.co/4n43v7q) can transform your Steam Deck from a low-powered, vendor-locked console into a full-blown portable PC gaming experience, complete with no-compromises ray tracing and a sublime uplift in both visuals *and* feel. Playing *Doom: The Dark Ages* is a nightmare on the Steam Deck—but it's heavenly streaming to your Steam Deck via GeForce Now. Expanded game support and drastic battery life enhancements almost feel like cherries on top of the experience, but

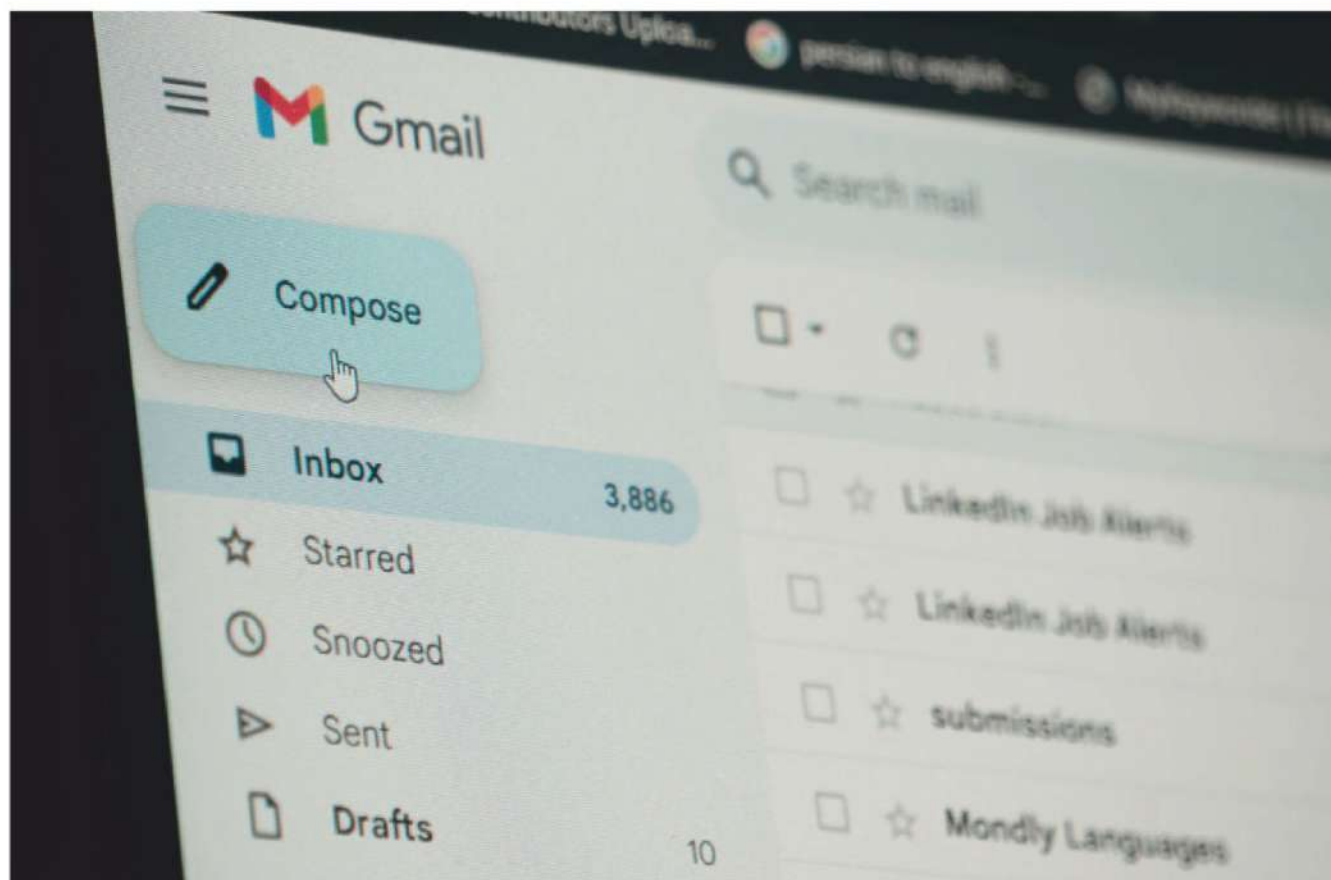


This error message pops up when you try to use quick resume with a GeForce Now streaming title.

they're just as crucial to the GFN app's Steam Deck success.

In an age when graphics card prices are soaring and the PC market shivers at damning tariffs (fave.co/4ieSHQe), Nvidia's GeForce Now app can elevate the Steam Deck from a kick-ass sidekick to your primary gaming PC. That's especially so if you dock your Deck with a mouse, keyboard, and monitor, but the wildly long battery life makes it true in handheld mode, too.

You should absolutely, positively give the GeForce Now app a download on your Steam Deck. It's a near must-have accessory if you want to play more strenuous modern games. Even if you only give the free ad-supported tier a whirl, it should provide enough *oomph* to get you through the new *Doom*—something the Deck itself isn't capable of on its own. Giddy up! 🔌



There's finally an AI feature in Gmail worth waiting for

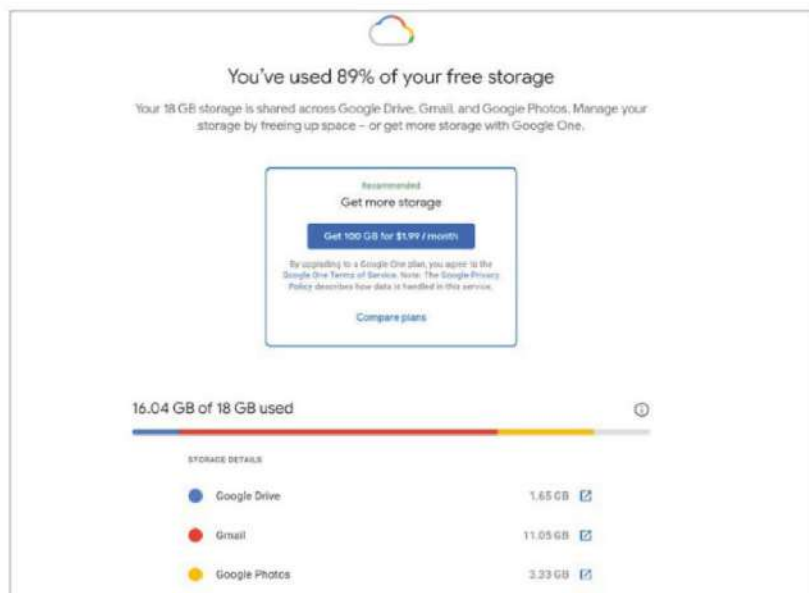
AI to clean up my Gmail inbox? Sign me up. **BY MARK HACHMAN**

Sometimes AI just feels overwhelming, like it's another thing to manage. Google, however, is announcing a couple of features within Gmail that will use AI to actually simplify your life.

At PCWorld, we've written numerous articles on ways to clean out your Gmail inbox (fave.co/3TOQKHi). There's nothing worse than seeing a notification that your cloud

storage is out of space, and trying to decide whether to take the time to clean it out (and risk losing something!) or pay more for additional space. And cleaning it out is no fun at all, either. What email should stay? What should go? Trying to decide what's important is a headache, but then trying to navigate through the Gmail interface is a pain.

That's why I'm honestly excited that Google plans to apply Gemini to the job. In a



Seeing a notification that your cloud storage is running out of space is never fun.

blog post by Yulie Kwon Kim, vice president of product at Google Workspace, Google said at its Google I/O conference that it is adding Gemini to Gmail to help clean up your inbox: "Simply tell Gemini what you want to do (e.g., 'Delete all of my unread emails from the Groomed Paw from last year') and watch as it helps you manage and declutter your inbox with a single click."

I don't think it will be as easy as all that; you'll still have to decide what stays and what goes. But Google uses a good example here, and you can simply apply tips from our previous stories about looking for and deleting emails with large attachments, and so on. Gemini should work on your Android phone (you do have an Android phone, right?) and Gmail,

so that you can probably clean up your inbox while chilling out on the couch.

Gmail is also expanding its predictive capabilities, adding personalized smart replies that use your tone, phrasing, and knowledge of your inbox. Google's demonstration of the technology offered responses of several sentences, which is always a bit risky. You'll want to monitor these.

On the other hand, Google is also trying to make it easier to

coordinate your schedule, offering suggestions for open times and sharing a booking page, if you have one. (Honestly, that's a lot of why we exchange emails these days, it seems.)

All of these features will be available next quarter—sometime in the fall, in other words. It's one of the few times I can say that I honestly can't wait. 🔌



Google plans to use Gemini to clean out your Gmail inbox.

Windows 95 and floppy disks are still crucial for modern US air travel

The FAA wants to put an end to this dreadful situation and switch to a “brand-new air traffic control system.” **BY HANS-CHRISTIAN DIRSCHERL AND JOEL LEE**



Ancient technologies like Windows XP, Commodore 64, and legacy COBOL programs are still used for all kinds of critical functions, and here's another example to add to the list. The U.S. Federal Aviation Administration still relies on Windows 95 and

floppy disks for the controls that manage air travel, though hopefully that won't be the case for too much longer.

NPR reports ([fave.co/3SOpAJe](https://www.npr.org/2025/07/24/13504541)) that the FAA wants to finally bring the U.S. aviation control system up to 21st-century standards—and that means getting rid of floppy disks.



The FAA still relies on floppy disks to manage air travel.

The legacy storage format is still used in many air traffic control towers, in computers that still run on Windows 95. In some cases, paper flight strips (fave.co/43Snr4k) are still used.

THE 1990S CONTROL AIR TRAFFIC IN THE U.S.

The lives of millions of passengers and crew members depend on software and hardware from the 1990s. Back then, Bill Clinton was president and Bill Gates was still head of Microsoft.

According to the FAA, this antiquated technology is used on about one-third of all flight control systems, and some of these systems are now starting

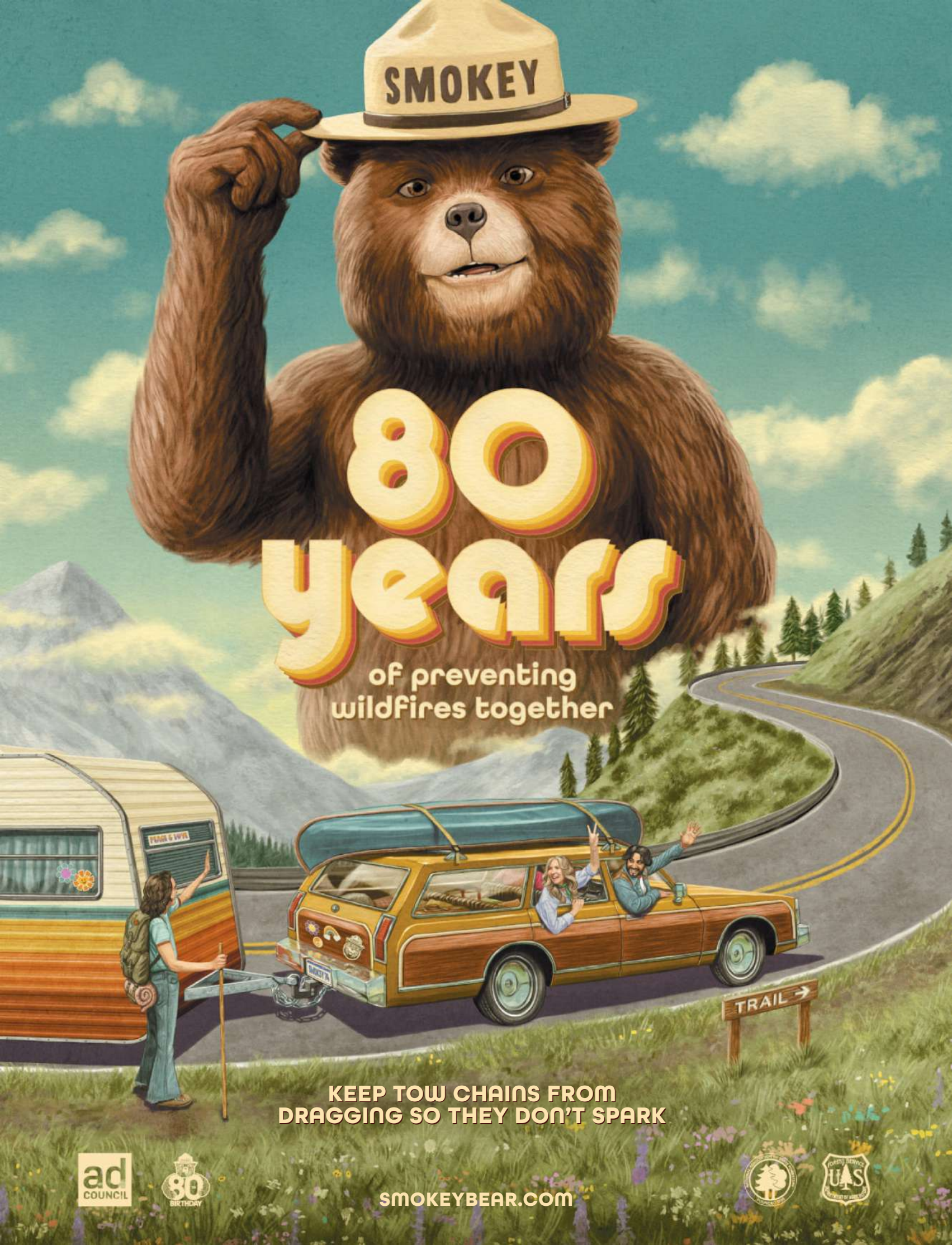
to fail. A recent example is the radar and communication failures that led to significant delays and cancellations (fave.co/43VNXtx) at Newark Liberty International Airport in New Jersey. On top of this, maintaining such old IT equipment requires a lot of money and some pretty arcane knowledge.

The U.S. Secretary of Transportation now wants to install a brand-new air traffic

control system. So far, there's been no official word on costs, but it could surpass tens of billions of dollars. The switch to a modern air traffic control system could be completed in four years if all goes well, but it does sound like a very ambitious plan. 



The FAA wants to bring U.S. aviation control systems up to 21st-century standards.



80 years

of preventing
wildfires together

KEEP TOW CHAINS FROM
DRAGGING SO THEY DON'T SPARK



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Lenovo Yoga 9i 2-in-1 Aura Edition: This OLED stunner goes all day

This convertible laptop takes Lunar Lake to its limits. **BY CHRIS HOFFMAN**



The Lenovo Yoga 9i 2-in-1 Aura Edition (fave.co/4l3dl23) is a 14-inch 2-in-1 convertible laptop with an Intel Lunar Lake processor (fave.co/402SDh2). It combines a touchscreen and a 360-degree hinge with 32GB of RAM, a beautiful OLED screen, and the long battery life Intel's Lunar Lake hardware is known for.

Unlike some other Yoga-branded laptops (fave.co/3ZwN7IL) I've reviewed in the last year, this model is a 2-in-1 convertible PC with the 360-degree hinge the Yoga name was once known for. This machine has the same CPU as the Lenovo ThinkPad X1 2-in-1 Gen 10 (fave.co/4jQ7dyu), and I reviewed them both at the same time.

The Lenovo Yoga 9i 2-in-1 is the consumer alternative to the ThinkPad X1 2-in-1, with the same CPU on the inside but a different design and a more entertainment-focused display choice. The battery life is long, the screen looks beautiful, and the machine looks and feels sleek.

SPECS

The Lenovo Yoga 9i 2-in-1 Aura Edition is an upgrade to the previous-generation Lenovo Yoga 9i (Gen 9), fave.co/4n7yOOL. This time around, the machine has a Lunar Lake CPU—specifically, the Intel Core Ultra 7 258V. That means it gets much longer battery life and can run Copilot+ PC AI features (fave.co/45SQerW) that Intel’s older NPU (fave.co/4kORFMP) just wasn’t powerful enough to run. It also has a more powerful integrated GPU that is surprisingly good for integrated graphics—plus a generous allotment of 32 GB of RAM and a 1 TB SSD.

Model: Lenovo Yoga 9i 2-in-1 Aura Edition

CPU: Intel Core Ultra 7 258V

Memory: 32 GB LPDDR5x RAM

Graphics and GPU: Intel Arc 140V

NPU: Intel AI Boost (up to 47 TOPS)

Display: 14-inch 2880×1800 OLED display with variable refresh rate up to 120Hz and HDR

Storage: 1 TB PCIe Gen 4 SSD

Webcam: 5MP 1440p webcam

Connectivity: 2× Thunderbolt 4 (USB Type-C), 1× USB Type-C (USB 20Gbps), 1× USB Type-A (USB 10Gbps), 1× combo audio jack

Networking: Wi-Fi 7, Bluetooth 5.4

Biometrics: Fingerprint reader, IR camera for facial recognition

Battery capacity: 75 Watt-hours

Dimensions: 12.44×8.66×0.63 inches

Weight: 2.91 pounds

MSRP: \$1,749 as tested

DESIGN AND BUILD QUALITY

The Lenovo Yoga 9i 2-in-1’s design feels similar to other Lenovo Yoga machines I’ve used in the past year or so. This Yoga laptop uses “Cosmic Blue,” in contrast to Lenovo’s ThinkPad line, which opts for a business look with more



The top and bottom of the laptop are made of aluminum, and the build quality is solid.

shades of gray. Combined with the rounded edges and glossy high-resolution OLED screen (fave.co/4ebdDXR), it's a sleek experience. The blue is rather dark, though. In real life, it looks a lot closer to black than you might expect, while catching light in an intriguing way.

The top and bottom are made of aluminum, and the build quality is solid—this is a proven Yoga design, and it's not Lenovo's first time putting out a machine in a chassis like this one. It looks very similar to the Lenovo Yoga 9i (Gen 9), for example. The hinge works well. The hinge also has what Lenovo calls a "rotating soundbar" built into it.

There's no flex that shouldn't be there, no undesired movement of the display as you type, or anything else you wouldn't want to see on a machine like this. The design just works like it should. At 2.91 pounds, it's a standard weight for a laptop like this one—not too heavy and not unusually light.

The built-in software is a little more cluttered than I'd like: It's got McAfee antivirus (fave.co/4cH3xfS) popping up and asking you to subscribe out of the box, for example. Consumer laptops tend to have more bundled offers than business laptops (fave.co/4dAHckZ), but it feels a little much for a \$1,749 laptop. Still, that doesn't matter at all when you can quickly uninstall it.



The Lenovo's keyboard feels good to type on.

[co/4dAHckZ](https://fave.co/4dAHckZ)), but it feels a little much for a \$1,749 laptop. Still, that doesn't matter at all when you can quickly uninstall it.

KEYBOARD, TRACKPAD, AND PEN

The keyboard feels fine to type on. Lenovo says it has "soft-landing" switches, which the company describes as having a "snappy" feel, along with 1.5mm of key travel. It's not mushy, and the switches feel good to type on for a lightweight portable laptop.

Once again, I have a criticism to make about a Yoga keyboard's layout. Lenovo has put the fingerprint reader at the bottom right corner of the laptop. Personally, my fingers naturally gravitate toward the bottom-right corner of the keyboard, anticipating the

presence of the right arrow key there, which disrupts my muscle memory! And on the ThinkPad X1 2-in-1, Lenovo put the fingerprint reader to the left of the arrow keys. So that appears to be a touch reserved for Yoga laptops alone.

Sure, you'll get used to it—and if you like this machine and plan on spending a lot of time with it, perhaps that won't be an issue for you.

The trackpad feels nice and smooth, and it's plenty large. When you click down, there's a fine click that isn't mushy. I would like to see laptops like this one include haptic trackpads (fave.co/45neimH)—that's just my personal preference—but this is a good mechanical trackpad.

Lenovo also includes a Yoga Pen, which magnetically attaches to the top of the laptop, on the lid right below the camera bump. It's

an active pen that charges via USB-C. You can use it to draw on the laptop's display, and it works well if you're looking for that kind of pen experience on a consumer laptop with a 360-degree hinge.

DISPLAY AND SPEAKERS

The Lenovo Yoga 9i 2-in-1 has an excellent 14-inch OLED display with a touchscreen. It's designed to wow—with a 2880×1800 resolution, HDR support, and the vivid colors OLED displays are known for. The screen is glossy, unlike the matte one on the business-focused ThinkPad X1 2-in-1. This machine is more interested in providing the most beautiful screen possible for media consumption, while the ThinkPad's antiglare display is more optimized for readability in various lighting conditions. It's always a trade-off when selecting a laptop.

To be clear, the screen glare is not unusual—this is just what happens in harsh lighting conditions when a laptop has a glossy OLED display.

The Lenovo Yoga 2-in-1's display tops out at a refresh rate of 120Hz, but it has a variable refresh rate, which probably helps Lenovo squeeze more battery life from this system. In fact, the most impressive thing about



Lenovo also includes a Yoga Pen, which magnetically attaches to the top of the laptop

the display is probably that Lenovo has managed to squeeze long battery life out of this system, despite a display that feels like it should be power-hungry. Intel Lunar Lake is necessary, but the variable refresh rate on the display and the larger battery built into the laptop are probably the things that complete the puzzle.

Lenovo makes a big deal of the rotating soundbar, saying it “allows the device to project audio independent of the device’s orientation.” The soundbar has two tweeters that rotate with the screen, and the laptop has two woofers on the bottom. The speaker setup sounds quite good. Listening to Steely Dan’s *Aja* on Spotify—a classic audiophile test track for speakers—the sound was clear and detailed. Swapping over to Daft Punk’s *Get Lucky* for a more electronic sound with more bass, the audio sounded punchy and fun—but obviously without the kind of bass you’d get from a good pair of headphones or external speakers.

WEBCAM, MICROPHONE, BIOMETRICS

The Lenovo Yoga 9i 2-in-1 has a 5 MP webcam with a 1440p resolution. That sounds great on paper. It looks high-quality, too, with a clear picture. In fact, it’s one of



The 14-inch OLED touchscreen display is excellent.

the better webcams I’ve seen on a laptop—even compared to the webcams on some business laptops I’ve reviewed. The quality is more than good enough for video meetings and calls.

Lenovo has also included a physical privacy shutter, so you can block the laptop by sliding a switch right above the webcam. These are always good to see.

The microphone picks up clean, clear audio and has good noise cancellation in a room with desktop PC fans whirring. To my ears, it may be one of the better microphone setups I’ve tried in a laptop recently. Given that the Yoga line primarily caters to consumers, the webcam and microphone performance is impressive.

The Lenovo Yoga 9i 2-in-1 has a fingerprint reader at the bottom-right corner of the

keyboard and an IR camera built into the camera bar above the display. You can sign in with Windows Hello (fave.co/3TsHLUV) using either your fingerprint or face. Both work well.

CONNECTIVITY

The Lenovo Yoga 9i 2-in-1 doesn't have the largest selection of ports, but I've seen worse. On the left side, you'll find a USB Type-C port (USB 20Gbps) and a USB Type-A port (USB 10Gbps.)

On the right side, you'll find two Thunderbolt 4 ports (USB 40Gbps) and a combo audio jack.

This laptop charges via USB-C, so you'll plug the charger into one of those USB Type-C ports.

Anyone looking for an HDMI out port, a microSD card reader, or a second USB Type-A port will need to look elsewhere. (For

example, the business-focused ThinkPad X1 2-in-1 has a built-in HDMI out port.) But this isn't too bad for this type of portable laptop, especially if you're prepared to use a dongle if you ever need more ports.

I'm just happy to see Lenovo included a headphone jack on this machine! I've reviewed a similarly named Lunar Lake-powered Yoga laptop without a headphone jack, the Yoga Slim 9i (fave.co/3ZwN7IL).

Thanks to Intel's Lunar Lake, this machine also comes with Wi-Fi 7 (fave.co/3rPd820) and Bluetooth 5.4 as standard. It's imperative that these features become standard for new laptops.

PERFORMANCE

The Lenovo Yoga 9i 2-in-1 delivers snappy desktop performance thanks to its Intel Core Ultra 7 258V CPU. Lunar Lake works well for day-to-day productivity applications and

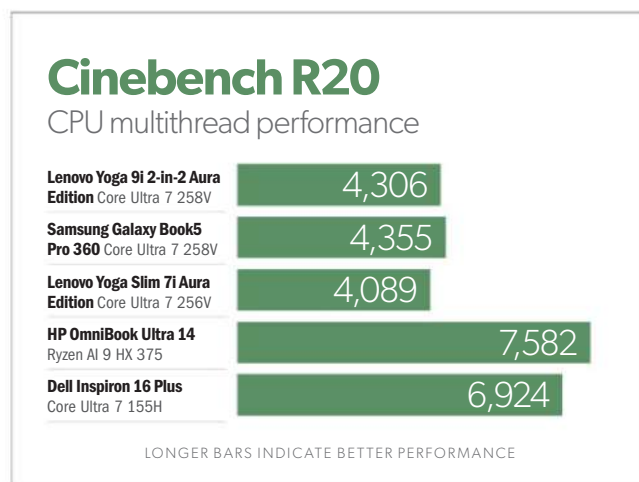
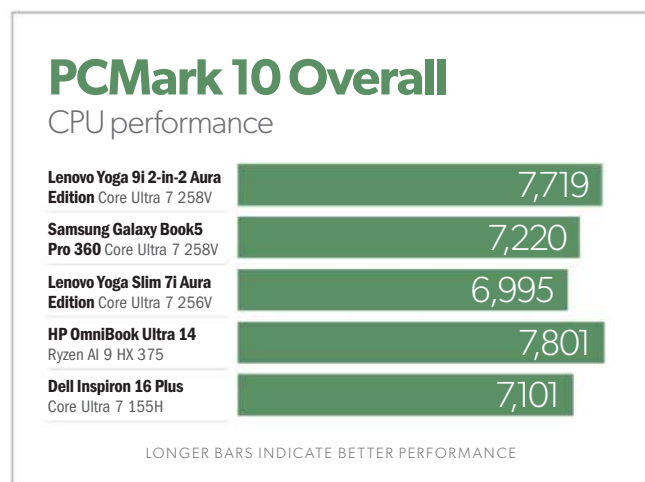
delivers extremely long battery life—plus surprisingly good graphics performance for integrated graphics hardware.

As always, though, we ran the Lenovo Yoga 9i 2-in-1 through our standard benchmarks (fave.co/4cjKcl4) to see how it performs.

First, we run PCMark 10 to get an idea of overall system performance. With an overall PCMark 10 score of 7,719, the



You won't find the largest selection of ports on offer.



Lenovo Yoga 9i 2-in-1 seems to squeeze every bit of performance it can out of Lunar Lake's hardware. We like to test laptops in their default state without tweaking them much—like a normal PC user would experience them—and I imagine recent changes to Windows 11 that put laptops into a higher-performance state automatically when they're plugged in helped this machine in the benchmarks.

Next, we run Cinebench R20. This test is a heavily multithreaded benchmark that focuses on overall CPU performance. It's a quick benchmark, so cooling under extended workloads isn't a factor. But, since it's heavily multithreaded, CPUs with more cores have a huge advantage.

With a multithreaded Cinebench R20 score of 4,306, Intel's Lunar Lake hardware shows its biggest weakness here. With fewer CPU cores, it's not just substantially slower at multithreaded CPU workloads than AMD's Ryzen AI 300 (fave.co/3MtBrJH) series

hardware, which also has an NPU and can run Copilot+ PC AI features. It's also substantially slower than Intel's own previous-generation Meteor Lake chips (fave.co/3PUqbHl). Lunar Lake does provide longer battery life than its competitors, but it comes at a cost.

This isn't representative of real-world productivity application usage, which is good—but it will be an issue for multithreaded CPU-heavy workloads.

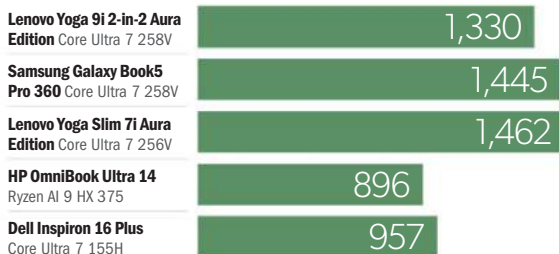
We also run an encode with Handbrake. This test is another heavily multithreaded benchmark, but it runs over an extended period. It demands the laptop's cooling kick in, and many laptops will throttle and slow down under load.

The Lenovo Yoga 9i completed the encode process in an average of 1,414 minutes, which is about 23 and a half minutes. Again, multithreaded CPU performance is a weakness here.

Next, we run a graphical benchmark. This isn't a gaming laptop, but it's still good to

Handbrake 0.9.9 Encode

Seconds



SHORTER BARS INDICATE BETTER PERFORMANCE

check how the GPU performs. We run 3DMark Time Spy, a graphical benchmark that focuses on GPU performance.

With a 3DMark Time Spy score of 4,716, Lunar Lake delivers great graphics performance for integrated graphics—second only to laptops with discrete Nvidia or AMD graphics hardware.

Overall, this machine delivers solid performance. This laptop showcases Lunar Lake at its peak performance. It also struggles with Lunar Lake's lower-than-ideal

multithreaded performance, as Intel included fewer cores on Lunar Lake than on the last-generation Meteor Lake hardware. That's only a concern if you have workloads that need sustained multithreaded performance, but it's an important thing to consider on a \$1,749 laptop.

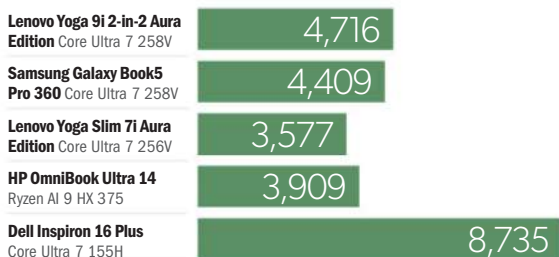
BATTERY LIFE

The Lenovo Yoga 9i 2-in-1 combined a substantial 75 watt-hour battery with long-lasting Lunar Lake hardware, so we'd hope it would have long battery life. And it does—it's very impressive.

To benchmark the battery life, we play a 4K copy of *Tears of Steel* on repeat on Windows 11 with airplane mode enabled until the laptop suspends itself. We set the screen to 250 nits of brightness for our battery benchmarks, and it's worth noting that the Lenovo Yoga 9i 2-in-1's OLED display has a bit of an advantage, as OLED screens use less power to display the black bars around the

3DMark Time Spy

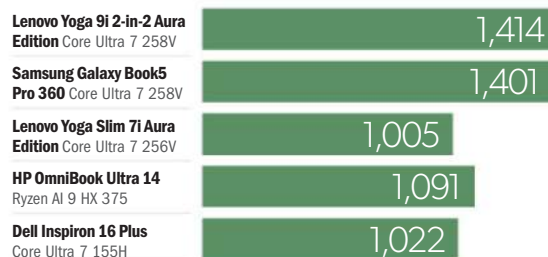
GPU performance



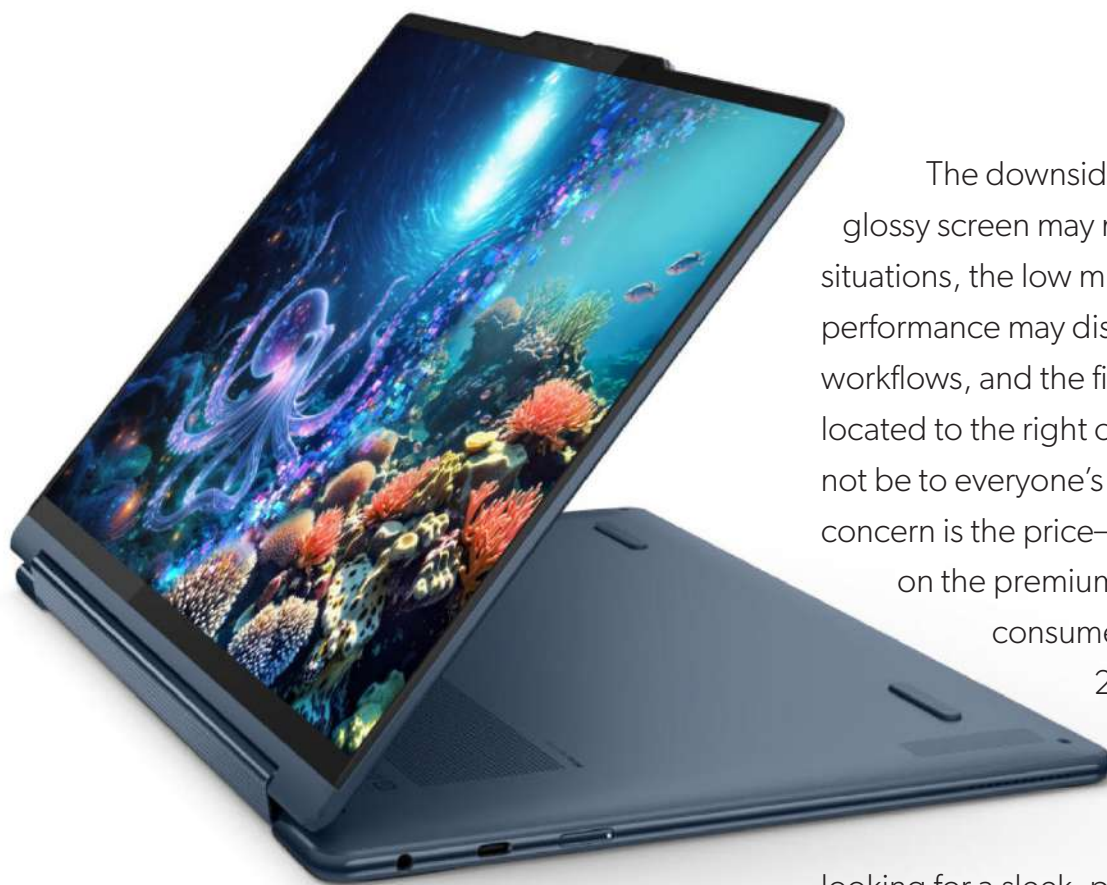
LONGER BARS INDICATE BETTER PERFORMANCE

Battery Life

Minutes



LONGER BARS INDICATE BETTER PERFORMANCE



The Yoga 9i is a high-quality 2-in-1 laptop.

video. This is a best-case scenario for any laptop since local video playback is so efficient, and real battery life in day-to-day use is always going to be less than this.

The Yoga 9i lasted for 1,414 minutes before suspending itself—that's 23 and a half hours. The OLED display almost certainly uses more power, but the choice of a variable refresh rate for the display and the larger battery help this machine achieve extremely long battery life.

BOTTOM LINE

The Lenovo Yoga 9i 2-in-1 Aura Edition is a sleek machine with a beautiful display and long battery life. The 2-in-1 experience is great. It's as nice as it looks in the photos.

The downsides are evident: The glossy screen may not be ideal in certain situations, the low multithreaded CPU performance may disrupt some people's workflows, and the fingerprint reader located to the right of the arrow keys may not be to everyone's liking. But the main concern is the price—at \$1,749, this is a little on the premium-priced side for a consumer laptop. Still, it is a 2-in-1, and a high-quality one at that.

This is a wonderful laptop for people looking for a sleek, portable 2-in-1 with a vivid display and long battery life. If those are your priorities—and the price seems reasonable to you—this machine is great. 🔌

Lenovo Yoga 9i 2-in-1 Aura Edition



PROS

- Long battery life (almost 24 hours in our test).
- Beautiful OLED screen.
- Great webcam.

CONS

- Lunar Lake's multithreaded performance isn't ideal for some workloads.
- Glossy screen can be difficult to read in harsh lighting conditions.
- A little expensive.

BOTTOM LINE

The Lenovo Yoga 9i 2-in-1 Aura Edition is a sleek 14-inch Lunar Lake laptop with a beautiful display and extreme battery life. It's a nice machine, and it would be easy to recommend more widely if it was less expensive.

From \$1,749

Microsoft Surface Pro (2025): Big upgrade in a small package

Finally, a compact Windows tablet with quality. Ultrabook fast, AI smart, versatile, and fanless. **BY MATTIAS INGHE**



Microsoft once pushed tablets as the future of Windows, but the world didn't bite. Now the company mostly plays it safe with traditional laptops and mouse-friendly interfaces, and yet it keeps making Surface devices. The latest is the Microsoft Surface

Pro (fave.co/4e1NFWN), more often called the Surface Pro 12 or Surface Pro 2025.

This compact tablet runs on a Snapdragon X Plus chip and is built for casual browsing and office work. It's not high-end, but it delivers a solid, fanless experience Windows tablets have long struggled to provide. And



The Surface Pro delivers a solid, fanless experience Windows tablets have long struggled to provide.

with Qualcomm's Hexagon NPU, it's got impressively snappy AI, too.

QUIET AND COMFORTABLY COOL

So it's completely silent cooling, and I don't even think it ever gets annoyingly hot to hold the tablet—a little disturbingly lukewarm, but nothing unpleasant. It throttles with graphics performance when I run 3D graphics for long periods, but honestly, who buys a Surface to play games?

The price is \$799 for a base model with 256GB of SSD storage or you can spend a little extra (\$899) on the configuration with 512GB of SSD storage. You also get 16GB of RAM, just enough for all your regular office

work, media streaming, basic photo editing, and communication.

Most of the multitasking I try goes smoothly. I'm in a Teams video meeting with the editorial team, Googling information in a browser (this is a Bing household—sorry!), I have articles in progress open in Word, and I'm syncing up a large video file for online sharing. All this happens at the same time, without one task interfering with another.

Connection with both Wi-Fi 7 and Wi-Fi 6 is also stable and fast, which of course helps. There is no 5G or LTE version of this tablet. Then you have to go up in size and price.

SHARP DISPLAY, BUT LIMITED SPACE

What becomes an obstacle to productive multitasking is rather the small screen



The screen has a semihigh-brightness IPS panel.

area—12 inches isn't much. Even though it's high resolution, having many windows and tabs active quickly becomes cluttered. You'll have to adopt a more traditional tablet mentality and have one or two visible on the screen at the same time and have the others hidden but active behind.

The screen has a semihigh-brightness IPS panel, 2196×1464 pixel resolution, and a 60 or 90 Hz frame rate. You'll have to set it up manually; dynamic frequency is not supported. It's not full pro quality on the screen, as the gamut only goes up a little bit above sRGB level, but precalibration from Microsoft means color accuracy within the sRGB scale is high.

That, and relatively high black and contrast and wide viewing angles, enhance the quality experience. It makes watching films entertaining, even if there is no HDR support. A solid set of speakers with a detailed and rich sound for music, speech, and films also helps, at least as long as I don't turn the volume up to the ceiling, which is when it gets the loudest.

The webcam above the screen provides an acceptable 1080p image without noise and with even, neutral colors. Pale contrast and almost-but-not-quite-blurred detail drag down the impression. There's no need to be embarrassed in the video meeting, especially thanks to good microphones and AI-backed noise filters, but there could be more punch in the image.

On the back sits a simple 10-megapixel camera that takes decent pictures in daylight, but don't expect miracles. Its jumpy autofocus can especially cause problems for both filming and things like AR applications.

COMPACT DESIGN WITH MINIMAL DRAWBACKS

With a 12-inch screen and 3:2 aspect ratio, the tablet is noticeably compact and short in width. Its pleasantly rounded corners and edges make Surface Pro excellently grip-friendly, with its matte aluminum back that is said to be made from 100 percent recycled aluminum. The foldable back support is sturdy.

Setting up the Surface Pro as a small digital photo frame or film screen is very practical. But it's essentially a Windows computer, so you'll need a keyboard and mouse controller. And if you want to make full use of the touchscreen, you'll need a pen as well.



The Surface and the accessories you might need, except a charger.



It's all neatly organized.

You can buy the matching Slim Pen separately or in a bundle with the keyboard for a total of \$249.99 (fave.co/44f6iT). It's built for the Surface Pro, with a slot on the back where the pen can snap on with a magnet and charge.

Everything plugs in and works right away. I don't have to fuss with manual pairing or calibration. The precision is excellent from the start. The quality of the keyboard is also uncompromising. It doesn't even feel like the keys are crammed together, despite its short width.

JUST TWO USB PORTS, NOTHING MORE

If you prefer to connect your own mouse and keyboard and perhaps a larger screen, all that is possible with a suitable USB-C dock. The disc's two ports support everything you need to plug in a USB-C dock and charge the battery with it. Chargers are not included.

Microsoft doesn't reveal how big the battery is, but battery life is good, from 3 to 10 hours of active use with the screen brightness cranked all the way up, and up to 21 hours of frugal use. If I'm working with generative AI, either Microsoft's own features in the Copilot

Plus suite or third-party software, or challenging the graphics card with a lot of 3D rendering, I end up on the lower end of that.

If I'm just surfing the web, checking email, and running simple Excel calculations, the



With the right accessories, you get a compact, competent laptop that also doubles as a touchscreen tablet with pen support.

Surface Pro handles it much better, and that's what most people really do with their computers anyway. For those tasks, it's as capable as any small, ultralight laptop. It may not be quite as fast, but it's definitely fast enough.

With the right accessories, you get a compact, competent laptop that also doubles as a touchscreen tablet with pen support. It's perfect for streaming movies on the couch. Is it enough to revive the Windows tablet concept? Maybe, maybe not. But for fans of the form factor, it's a great device.

SPECIFICATIONS

Product name: Surface Pro 2025

Tested: May 2025

Manufacturer: Microsoft

Processor: Qualcomm Snapdragon X Plus, 8 Oryon 3.4 GHz

NPU: Hexagon, 45 tops

Graphics: Intel Arc 130V

Memory: 16 GB lppdr5x

Storage: 256 GB/512 GB SSD

Monitors: 12 inch glossy IPS, 2196×1464 pixels, 90 Hz, approx 400 cd/m²

Webcam: 10 megapixel rear, 1080p webcam with IR front

Connections: 2× USB-C 3 Gen 2 with DisplayPort, keyboard docking

Wireless: Wi-Fi 7, Bluetooth 5.4

Operating system: Windows 11 Home

Other: Optional keyboard, pen, and charger

Sound level: Fanless

Battery: 1 hour, 45 minutes (high load, full brightness, 90 Hz) to approximately 19 hours (low load, low brightness, 60 Hz)

Size: 27.4×19×0.78 cm

Weight: 686 grams

PERFORMANCE

Cinebench 2024, multi-core CPU:

550 points

Cinebench 2024, single core CPU:

107 points

Geekbench 6, multi-core CPU:

11,241 points

Geekbench 6, single core CPU:

2,403 points

Geekbench 6, gpu: 13,834 points

Disk, read: Up to 3,870.85 MB/s

Disk, write: Up to 3,413.79 MB/s. 

Microsoft Surface Pro (2025)



PROS

- Compact and well-built.
- Good office performance.
- All Copilot Plus features available.

CONS

- Narrow screen to work on.
- No HDR support.
- No charger included.

BOTTOM LINE

The new little Surface Pro straddles the line between a portable tablet and a compact Windows laptop (with an optional keyboard). It's like the old, underpowered Surface Go—but actually good! I wish it had an OLED screen with HDR, but otherwise it exceeds expectations.

From \$949



Lenovo ThinkPad X1 2-in-1: The longest-lasting laptop I've tested

It's more expensive than the average laptop, but it delivers. **BY CHRIS HOFFMAN**



The Lenovo ThinkPad X1 2-in-1 Gen 10 Aura Edition (fave.co/3HEhVeg) is a 14-inch business laptop that combines Intel's Lunar Lake CPUs with a proven ThinkPad convertible design. This is a

high-quality business laptop (fave.co/4dAHckZ) for people who want a snappy desktop experience in a 2-in-1 form factor with a pen. It's optimized for getting things done.

While it may be a bit pricey, it's typical of business laptops. If this machine fits your

budget and you prize battery life and portability, it's difficult to argue with what Lenovo has put together here.

SPECS

Lenovo offers the 14-inch ThinkPad X1 2-in-1 Gen 10 in various configurations, and all of them are branded as the Aura Edition. The base model starts at \$2,125 and includes an Intel Core Ultra 5 226V processor, 16 GB of RAM, 512 GB of SSD storage, and Intel Arc graphics.

At the time of writing, the model we reviewed costs \$2,336 and features an Intel Core Ultra 7 258V processor, 32GB of RAM, a 1 TB SSD, and faster Intel Arc 140V graphics, along with an upgrade to Windows 11 Pro. (The model I got my hands on only had 512 GB of storage but was otherwise equivalent to that version—Lenovo offers a “Build Your PC” tool so you can customize the hardware when you order.)

These machines come with various Intel Lunar Lake processors, and we know what to expect from Lunar Lake by now (fave.co/402SDh2): The Intel laptop boasts an incredibly long battery life, an NPU for AI tasks capable of running Copilot+ PC features, and a surprisingly strong graphics performance for integrated graphics. However, the big downside with Lunar Lake is the low multithreaded computing performance due to the fewer cores. They deliver snappy desktop performance, but these chips are



This solid 14-inch laptop is made of metal.

better for office work and portability than they are for heavy compute workloads, as we always see in our standard benchmarks. But the laptop is a portable, productivity-focused machine—not a blazing-fast workstation with maximum battery-draining CPU power.

Model: Lenovo ThinkPad X1 2-in-1 Gen 10 Aura Edition

CPU: Intel Core Ultra 7 258V

Memory: 32GB LPDDR5X

Graphics and GPU: Intel Arc 140V

NPU: Intel AI Boost

Display: 14-inch 1920×1200 IPS display with 60Hz refresh rate and 500 nits of brightness

Storage: 512 GB PCIe Gen4 SSD

Webcam: 1080p webcam

Connectivity: 2× Thunderbolt 4 (USB Type-C), 2× USB Type-A (USB 5Gbps), combo audio jack, HDMI 2.1 out

Networking: Wi-Fi 7, Bluetooth 5.4

Biometrics: Fingerprint reader, IR camera for facial recognition

Battery capacity: 57 Watt-hours

Dimensions: 12.31×8.57×0.64 inches

Weight: 2.97 pounds

MSRP: \$2,336 as tested

DESIGN AND BUILD QUALITY

The Lenovo ThinkPad X1 2-in-1 Gen 10 Aura Edition is a solid 14-inch laptop made of metal. As it's a convertible 2-in-1 machine, you can rotate the laptop's hinge 360 degrees to lay it flat. The hinge feels great, as it has on previous convertible ThinkPads I've used. Lenovo includes a pen to complement the touchscreen experience.

Last year, I reviewed the previous version of the Lenovo ThinkPad X1 2-in-1 ([fave.co/460nKMW](https://www.fave.co/460nKMW)), and this model closely resembles that machine from the exterior. It's a gray metal design with the classic red ThinkPad nub in the middle and a bar at the top of the screen where the webcam sits.

At just under 3 pounds, it's fairly light but isn't the absolute lightest laptop—2-in-1 machines tend to be a bit heavier than the absolute lightest options out there. The weight is actually rather nice—it feels like a solid but not too heavy piece of metal.

KEYBOARD, TRACKPAD, AND PEN

The Lenovo ThinkPad X1 2-in-1 has a high-quality keyboard—ThinkPads are known for that. It may not be quite as snappy as more expensive high-end ThinkPads like the ThinkPad X1 Carbon ([fave.co/3WGAEK](https://www.fave.co/3WGAEK)), but it feels great to type on. There's no mushy feeling as you press the keys. The layout works well, and you can activate multiple levels of white keyboard backlighting.

The trackpad feels great to slide your finger over, and you'll feel a pleasing thunk when you press down on it to click. The surface is nice and smooth, and the physical buttons are nice to see—most laptops don't come with a physical right-click button on the trackpad! I do prefer haptic touchpads, but the action on this still feels satisfying.



The ThinkPad X1 2-in-1 has a high-quality keyboard.

If I had to nitpick, I would point out that the inclusion of the physical buttons reduces the size of the trackpad's surface compared to what it could be—individuals who desire a larger trackpad and do not intend to use the physical buttons may prefer the trackpad on a different machine.

As a 2-in-1 machine, this device includes a Lenovo Yoga Pen. It's an active pen with a customizable shortcut button, and it works well for sketching on the screen. You can input text with handwriting, draw, sketch, sign documents, or whatever else you want to do.

The classic red ThinkPad TrackPoint nub is here in the middle, too, and you can use it to control the mouse cursor. That's good to see, considering that Lenovo has started removing the TrackPoint from certain ThinkPad-branded laptops (fave.co/3HFpIII).

People like me might be one reason why—I was never a big TrackPoint user, so I don't find myself using it on these machines. But the TrackPoint has a devoted audience of people who love it—and, if nothing else, it gives the ThinkPad's keyboard a unique aesthetic I do love. So yes, I do want to see the TrackPoint stay on ThinkPad keyboards—even if I don't personally use it much.

DISPLAY AND SPEAKERS

The Lenovo ThinkPad X1 2-in-1 Aura Edition has a 14-inch 1920×1200 IPS display with a



The 14-inch 1920×1200 IPS display looks great.

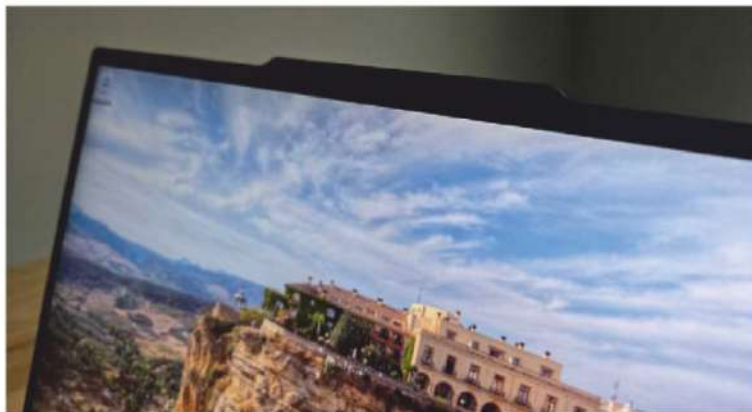
60Hz refresh rate, 500 nits of brightness, and a touch screen. Lenovo calls this a “low power” display in its specs list, and that low power usage isn't just a marketing promise—it absolutely shows in the machine's long battery life, as we'll see in the results of our battery life benchmark below. (You can also get this machine with a 2880×1800 display with HDR and a variable refresh rate up to 120Hz. That sounds nice, but the higher-end display will eat into the machine's battery life.)

The display looks great. Lenovo says it has an antireflective coating, and I can tell—it works really well. You don't see the kind of extreme reflections you often do on a laptop with a glossy display when it's in bright lighting. It's a good-looking display with a decent amount of brightness, but it's focused on real-world usage and long battery life. There are no issues with this choice—it's an appropriate option for this device.

The ThinkPad X1's speakers are a lot better than you might expect from a 2-in-1 14-inch laptop focused on portability. They can get surprisingly loud while maintaining clear audio quality, and the sound is fuller than I might have thought—they even have more bass than I expected. (That said, a machine like this one can never deliver the kind of bass you'd get from a pair of headphones or external speakers.)

WEBCAM, MICROPHONE, BIOMETRICS

The Lenovo ThinkPad X1 2-in-1 Gen 10 has a 1080p webcam with a physical privacy shutter at the top of the machine, which is always nice to see. The image quality is quite good—the quality you're more likely to find in a business machine than the average consumer laptop, as it should be on a productivity-focused business machine where the webcam might be used in quite a few video calls.



The ThinkPad X1 2-in-1 Gen 10 has a 1080p webcam with a physical privacy shutter at the top of the machine.

The microphone setup delivers solid audio quality and noise cancellation. Although it is not a studio-quality external microphone, this laptop's microphone significantly outperforms the average laptop microphone for voice and video calls.

This ThinkPad has a fingerprint reader to the left of the arrow keys on the keyboard, and you can rest your finger on it to authenticate with Windows Hello (fave.co/3TsHLUV) and sign in. It also has an IR camera for facial recognition, and they both work well.

CONNECTIVITY

The Lenovo ThinkPad X1 2-in-1 Aura Edition includes a solid selection of ports. On the left side, you've got two Thunderbolt 4 (USB Type-C ports) and a USB Type-A port. On the right side, this machine has a second USB Type-A port, an HDMI 2.1 out port, and a combo audio jack for headphones. That's about what you'd want from this laptop—

although people who want a built-in SD card reader won't find it here. As always, you could get a dongle.

My biggest nitpick: This machine charges over USB Type-C. It would be nice to see a USB Type-C port on each side of the laptop so you can plug in either side to charge it.

Thanks to Lunar Lake, this machine also supports the latest wireless standards: Wi-Fi 7 (fave.co/3rPd820)

PCMark 10 Overall

CPU performance

Lenovo ThinkPad 2-in-1 Aura Edition Core Ultra 7 258V	7,626
Samsung Galaxy Book5 Pro 360 Core Ultra 7 258V	7,220
Lenovo Yoga Slim 7i Aura Edition Core Ultra 7 256V	6,995
HP OmniBook Ultra 14 Ryzen AI 9 HX 375	7,801
Dell Inspiron 16 Plus Core Ultra 7 155H	7,101

LONGER BARS INDICATE BETTER PERFORMANCE

Cinebench R20

CPU multithreaded performance

Lenovo ThinkPad 2-in-1 Aura Edition Core Ultra 7 258V	3,913
Samsung Galaxy Book5 Pro 360 Core Ultra 7 258V	4,355
Lenovo Yoga Slim 7i Aura Edition Core Ultra 7 256V	4,089
HP OmniBook Ultra 14 Ryzen AI 9 HX 375	7,582
Dell Inspiron 16 Plus Core Ultra 7 155H	6,924

LONGER BARS INDICATE BETTER PERFORMANCE

and Bluetooth 5.4 both come standard on this machine. As usual, Intel's wireless hardware works well.

PERFORMANCE

The Lenovo ThinkPad X1 2-in-1 delivers snappy desktop performance. With a Lunar Lake CPU (specifically the Intel Core Ultra 7 258V in our review unit), this machine performs well in day-to-day desktop apps like web browsers and office applications.

As always, we ran the ThinkPad X1 2-in-1 Gen 10 through our standard benchmarks (fave.co/4cjKcl4) to see how it performs.

First, we run PCMark 10 to get an idea of overall system performance. The Lenovo ThinkPad X1 2-in-1 delivered an overall PCMark score of 7,626, which is a respectable score for this hardware.

Next, we run Cinebench R20. This is a heavily multithreaded benchmark that focuses on overall CPU performance. It's a quick benchmark, so cooling under extended

workloads isn't a factor. But, since it's heavily multithreaded, CPUs with more cores have a huge advantage.

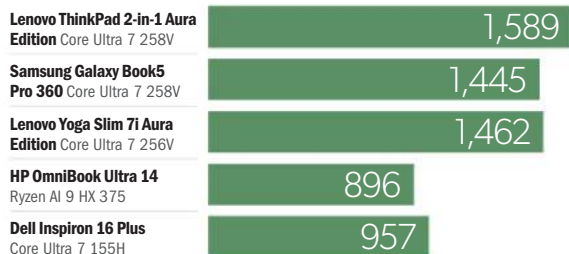
There are no surprises here—with a Cinebench R20 multithreaded score of 3,913, this machine struggles along with other Lunar Lake-powered systems on this type of benchmark. When it comes to multithreaded compute tasks, Intel's Lunar Lake CPUs have fewer cores and come in well behind other systems with more cores, like the AMD Ryzen AI 300 series (fave.co/3MtBrJH).

We also ran an encoder with Handbrake. This is another heavily multithreaded benchmark, but it runs over an extended period. This test demands the laptop's cooling kick in, and many laptops will throttle and slow down under load.

The ThinkPad X1 completed the encode process in 1,589 seconds, which is a bit over 26 minutes. Benchmarks like this aren't representative of normal desktop performance, which doesn't demand this

Handbrake 0.9.9 Encode

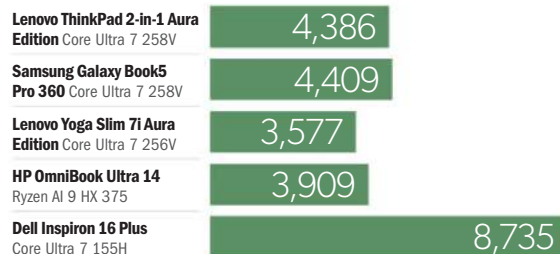
Seconds



SHORTER BARS INDICATE BETTER PERFORMANCE

3DMark Time Spy

GPU performance



LONGER BARS INDICATE BETTER PERFORMANCE

level of sustained multithreaded compute performance, but it may be an issue for some professional workflows that require this sort of thing.

Next, we run a graphical benchmark. This isn't a gaming laptop (fave.co/4dEHNiK), but it's still good to check how the GPU performs—especially since the Intel Arc graphics in Lunar Lake are surprisingly good for integrated graphics. We run 3DMark Time Spy, a graphical benchmark that focuses on GPU performance.

With a 3DMark Time Spy score of 4,386, this machine delivers the surprisingly good graphical performance we'd expect to see from Lunar Lake hardware but is still far behind gaming PCs and workstations with more power-hungry GPUs.

Overall, the Lenovo ThinkPad X1 2-in-1 delivers good Lunar Lake performance: The Lenovo ThinkPad X1 2-in-1 offers a swift desktop experience and impressive graphics performance, albeit subpar multithreaded

performance. However, the complete picture becomes clear when considering the battery life.

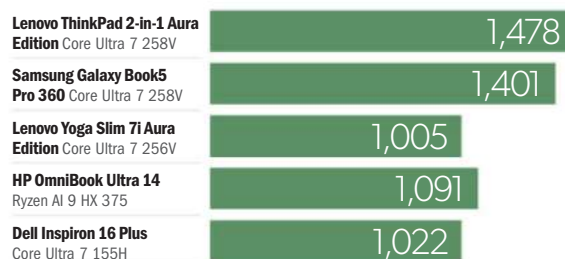
BATTERY LIFE

The Lenovo ThinkPad X1 2-in-1 Gen 10 includes a 57 watt-hour battery, which is a little on the small side in terms of hardware. That's one reason why I was absolutely floored by the battery life in our benchmark.

To benchmark the battery life, we play a 4K copy of *Tears of Steel* on repeat on

Battery Life

Minutes



LONGER BARS INDICATE BETTER PERFORMANCE

Windows 11 with airplane mode enabled until the laptop suspends itself. We set the screen to 250 nits of brightness for our battery benchmark. This amount of time is a best-case scenario for any laptop since local video playback is so efficient, and real battery life in day-to-day use is always going to be less than this.

The ThinkPad X1 2-in-1 lasted for an average of 1,478 minutes before suspending itself. That's over 24 hours of battery life—and closer to 25 hours than 24 hours.

That shocked me a little bit considering the size of the battery, but obviously Lenovo has made some smart decisions here—aside from the efficient Lunar Lake hardware, I bet that low-power display is helping a lot, too. And although real-world battery life will be substantially shorter if you're actually using the machine rather than just looping a video in airplane mode, this is still extremely impressive.

(For context, last year's ThinkPad X1 2-in-1 machine lasted 1,055 minutes—or 17 and a half hours—in our benchmark. This represents a significant improvement compared to the previous year.)

BOTTOM LINE

The Lenovo ThinkPad X1 2-in-1 Gen 10 is a solid business machine. You're getting great build quality, extreme battery life, a 2-in-1 experience with a pen, and a future-proof machine that supports everything from Wi-Fi 7 to Windows 11's Copilot+ PC AI features.

It's a little expensive, but business machines tend to have higher-end pricing. And I like this machine more than I expected to, honestly: Even the selection of the low-power display and its nice anti-reflective coating are decisions you'll really appreciate if you're looking for this kind of PC. Yes, a glossy 4K display is more impressive at first glance. But battery life and readability in direct sunlight and brighter rooms are more important for getting work done.

If that all sounds good, this may be the machine for you. But I really do wish Lunar Lake had better multithreaded CPU performance—if you need that for your workflow, that will be one reason you might look for a more power-hungry laptop. Still, you won't get this kind of battery life if you do go looking for a beefier CPU. 

Lenovo ThinkPad X1 2-in-1 Gen 10 Aura Edition



PROS

- Over 24 hours of battery life (in our standard test).
- Solid build quality.
- Snappy desktop performance.

CONS

- On the expensive side.
- Lunar Lake's low multithreaded performance is an issue for some workflows.

BOTTOM LINE

The Lenovo ThinkPad X1 2-in-1 Gen 10 Aura Edition is a business laptop that combines long battery life and good desktop performance with a convenient 2-in-1 experience. If you're looking for this type of machine, the only real downside is the price.

From \$2,336

Razer Blade 16 (2025): Sleek and light but lags in performance

Temper your expectations. **BY MARK KNAPP**



The 2025 Razer Blade 16 continues the shaky tradition of packing some top-of-the-line PC gaming hardware into a laptop chassis that can almost be considered thin and light. For a 16-inch laptop, the Razer

Blade 16 impresses at well under 5 pounds and under 0.7 inches thick, and yet it's still rocking a solid aluminum design, a fantastic display, and more ports than you'd expect.

There are always some downsides to this formula, as the new Blade 16 ranges in price

from \$2,399 to \$4,499 as tested here in a high-end configuration and yet lags behind some cheaper competitors where performance is concerned.

It's that awkward balance of performance, price, and design that sees the Blade 16 struggle with value. Those who want the most performance can get it from something like the Lenovo Legion Pro 7i 16 Gen 10 (fave.co/4kZY0od) instead. But where slimness, weight, and battery life for a gaming laptop are concerned, this new Blade 16 still has something to offer.

SPECS AND FEATURES

Model number: RZ09-05289EN9-R3U1

CPU: AMD Ryzen AI 9 HX 370

Memory: 32GB LPDDR5

Graphics/GPU: Nvidia RTX 5090
(175-watt TGP)

Display: 16-inch 2560×1600 240Hz OLED

Storage: 2TB PCIe Gen4 SSD

Webcam: 1080p + IR

Connectivity: 2× USB 4 with DisplayPort 1.4 (from iGPU only) and 100W PD input, 3× USB-A 3.2 Gen 2, 1× HDMI 2.1, 1× SDcard reader, 1× 3.5mm combo audio

Networking: Wi-Fi 7, Bluetooth 5.4

Biometrics: Windows Hello facial recognition

Battery capacity: 90 watt-hours

Dimensions: 13.98×9.86×0.69 inches

Weight: 4.65 pounds

MSRP: \$4,499 as tested (\$2,399 base)

At the time of testing, the 2025 Razer Blade 16 started out at \$2,799 to get you a configuration with an AMD Ryzen AI 9 365 CPU, 32GB of memory, 1TB of storage, and an RTX 5070 8GB GPU. Since then, Razer has introduced an even lower configuration for \$2,399 that drops to an RTX 5060 and 16GB of memory.

Razer allows some different customization options but links many of them with other adjustments. So even though you have the option to select a different GPU up to the RTX 5090, can swap for a Ryzen AI 9 HX 370, and can increase storage to 4TB and memory to 64GB, you may not get to mix and match these elements as you please.

For instance, the Ryzen AI 9 HX 370 is tied to the RTX 5090. If you want one, you're also getting the other. Some of the other adjustments are perplexing. For example, if you choose 64GB of memory, you must also select 4TB of storage unless you opt for an RTX 5080. If you want 2TB of storage, you have to select at least an RTX 5080.

If you want 4TB of storage, you have to get a max-spec system. Just about every option you select in the configuration tool will change other options, making it a mad game of guess-and-check to see if you can get the specific configuration you want. On the bright side, the high-speed OLED display comes standard on all models.



This laptop is a hunk of deep black aluminum with tightly rounded corners and edges and almost perfectly flat surfaces.

DESIGN AND BUILD QUALITY

The 2025 Razer Blade 16 maintains the minimalist, understated design that has been a hallmark of Razer's laptops. It's truly a hunk of deep black aluminum with very tightly rounded corners and edges and almost perfectly flat surfaces. The big tells that it's a gaming laptop are the illuminated three-snake Razer logo on the lid and the per-key RGB keyboard.

While prior models we've tested have had only slight flex in the chassis, the 2025 model has some more noticeable bending in the display and flex on the keyboard deck. It's still quite firm, and I've never been concerned while holding the laptop up at one corner.

The difference is perhaps stemming from how much is packed into this model. The 2024 Razer Blade 16 measured in at 5.4 pounds and 0.87 inches thick, but this model

has trimmed that way down to just 4.65 pounds and 0.69 inches thick. While both models feature the highest-end mobile GPU available to them at the time (and both at 175 watts), this new model uses a lower-wattage CPU than the Intel Core i9-14900HX found in the 2024.

Therefore, it may have gotten away with lighter cooling. As thin as the Blade 16

manages to be for the most part, there is a raised area on the underside to provide more room for the motherboard and cooling components.

While the prior model had impressively thin bezels around the display, the 2025 unit mostly does as well; the bezel below the screen is considerably thicker. The all-black design helps it blend in at least. The display sits on a firm, wide, smooth-moving hinge that stretches most of the width of the laptop. It only has a little wiggle to it, and it opens easily using a single hand.

The surface of the laptop is largely occupied by the keyboard, which has been slightly expanded to include an extra column of shortcut keys along the right edge. Rather than go for a number pad, which would have been squished anyway, the Razer Blade 16 has a pair of speaker grilles at each side of the keyboard. The grilles are the same height as

the keyboard, though they're only packing a pair of tweeters inside. A second set of speakers sits on the underside of the laptop.

The system pulls air in through grilles on the bottom of the laptop and vents it out of a heatsink fin stack at the back. That fin stack is not only quite small but also only has a small amount of clearance between it and the display hinge. Moving as much heat as this system can produce makes for fans that are a little noisy while running at full blast, but they're not shrill or annoying. They blow with more of a calm, breezy tone to them.

Altogether, the Blade 16 2025 is an impressively built machine, considering its size and weight alongside the fact that it's packing in an RTX 5090. But the tight confines certainly raise concerns about the performance potential.

KEYBOARD, TRACKPAD

The Razer Blade's keyboard is a mixed bag. On the one hand, Razer has stabilized its keycaps somewhat well, and they have a clean, poppy travel. Unfortunately, Razer has gone the route of the Dell XPS line of late, opting for keycaps that are flat and perfectly square. There's at least a bit more space between keys to provide a little tactile sense of where one key ends and the next begins, but I still find it hard to type away with my fingers centered.



The keyboard has full, per-key RGB backlighting that's highly customizable in Razer's software.

As a result, I find I hang up after a typo and take just enough time to correct my position that I can't sustain a typing speed much above 100 words per minute in Monkeytype. If I'm lucky and don't make (or notice) my mistakes, I can hit 110 to 115 words per minute, but I didn't feel comfortable going beyond that.

The keyboard's layout is a little curious. Razer took advantage of the laptop's extra space, but only slightly. It added a single extra column at the right edge of the keyboard with a few shortcut keys. This may be handy for those that use them, but it makes finding the Delete and arrow keys just a little more tedious. Razer also had an opportunity to use full-size arrow keys without needing to shrink the right Shift key too much but didn't take advantage of that extra space.

And this being a Razer machine, the keyboard naturally has full, per-key RGB backlighting that's highly customizable in

Razer's software. While the RGB lighting illuminates all of the primary legends on the keycaps, it doesn't do so for any of the secondary legends. And for the function row, that means you'll only get the F1-F12 legends lit up and not the helpful shortcuts tied to them.

Razer's trackpad is properly huge. It takes up almost all of the space available to it on the vertical axis, leaving just a narrow strip above and below. It's also almost as wide as the alphanumeric keys on the keyboard. This is great for mousing around the system, as I almost never have to deal with repositioning my finger.

I have run into a couple small hiccups with multi-finger gestures and even more with very frequent palm rejection failures, with the trackpad registering unintended touches that are hard to avoid due to its size. But overall, its size is a benefit. The trackpad has a short and firm physical click. It's pleasing to the touch, though it takes just enough force that I find I often fail to get it on the first attempt.

DISPLAY, AUDIO

The Blade 16 offers an excellent display. It's exceedingly sharp with a 2560×1600 resolution on a 16-inch panel, and that can spin up to 240Hz for ultra-fast motion. Combine that with the fact that it's

an OLED panel, and you get not only the speed of the refresh but also the quick pixel response time. The display could hit 411 nits of full-screen brightness, plenty for most environments except bright outdoors.

Razer claims this is an anti-glare display. And it is, to a degree. I can clearly see reflections in it, so don't expect a matte quality. But outside, in the daylight, the glare is slightly subdued. The display's brightness combines with pitch blacks for infinite contrast, and the screen can deliver 100 percent coverage of the DCI-P3 color space alongside a high degree of color accuracy (average dE1976 of 0.69 and max dE1976 of 1.44).

The speakers can get pretty loud, but at maximum volume, they're overbearing and distort some, especially with strong bass, and they produce a bit of resonance in the



The Blade 16 has an excellent display.

laptop chassis. At lower volumes, they put out pretty clean and clear sound with bright treble and pronounced mids. Bass is a little weak, but not entirely absent, as it can be on many laptops.

WEBCAM, MICROPHONE, BIOMETRICS

You'll get a serviceable webcam and microphone setup on the Blade 16. In good lighting conditions, the camera captures a decently sharp picture and avoids too much noise or poor exposure. If you're just trying to rely on overhead lights, though, the picture will end up a fair bit grainier.

The mics have somewhat unusual processing, even in a quiet room. This makes for a loud and present voice but has minor artifacts. The flip side of that processing is that background noise is almost obliterated. Even with a fan running at full speed underneath the desk I had the laptop on, the mics captured only my voice. Even more wild, I began snapping my fingers and clapping while I spoke into the mics, and they completely neutralized the snapping and clapping—good if you want to be sure your voice is captured, but not so good if you want someone to hear you clapping.

While the Blade 16

certainly has space for a fingerprint scanner, it doesn't include one. The webcam does work with Windows Hello for quick facial recognition, though.

CONNECTIVITY

At first glance, the 2025 Razer Blade 16 might appear to have the same ports as its predecessor, albeit with a slight shift to their positioning (the SD card reader is now closer to other ports on the right side). But this model has upgraded ports. While its predecessor had a single Thunderbolt 4 port, the new Blade 16 has two USB4 ports. It keeps one on each side (a plus for flexibility), and they both support DisplayPort 1.4 and can receive 100 watts of PD charging in case you don't want to bring the 1.77-pound charging brick with you everywhere.

The laptop still has three USB 3.2 Gen 2 ports—two on the left and one on the right—as well as a 3.5mm combo jack, HDMI 2.1



Razer has upgraded the Razer 16's port selection.

port, and full-size SD card reader. There's a Kensington security lock slot as well.

Interestingly, the USB-C ports may support DisplayPort, but only for video signals coming from the CPU's integrated GPU. Since you'll want to game on the discrete GPU, you'll have to use the HDMI port to get the most out of the system's performance.

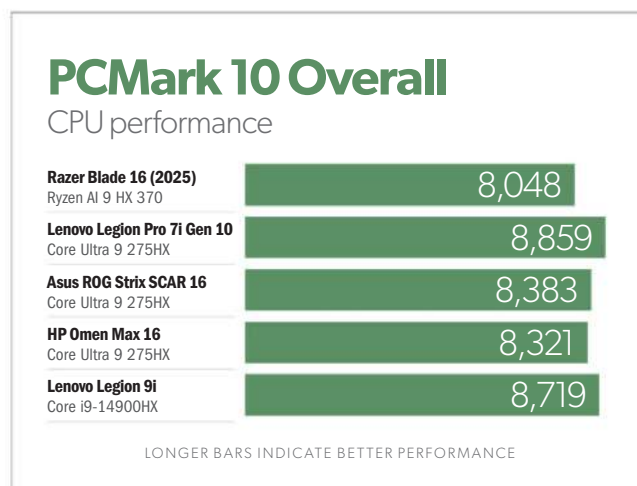
For wireless connections, the Blade 16 still supports Wi-Fi 7 and Bluetooth 5.4, and both have proven reliable in my testing.

PERFORMANCE

This test unit of the Razer Blade 16 is geared up to be an extreme performer. But the chassis thinness doesn't allow the same sort of heat management you might expect from big and beefy gaming laptops. So even though you're getting some of the most premium internals you can for a laptop, you shouldn't necessarily expect them to outpace rivals.

While we haven't yet tested other RTX 5090-powered laptops, the Razer Blade 16 shows itself only worthy of competing with RTX 5080-powered laptops anyway. On many fronts, it struggles to contend with the \$3,599 Lenovo Legion Pro 7i Gen 10, \$3,299 Asus ROG Strix SCAR 16 (G635LW), \$3,769 HP Omen Max 16, and \$4,059 Lenovo Legion 9i (Gen 9).

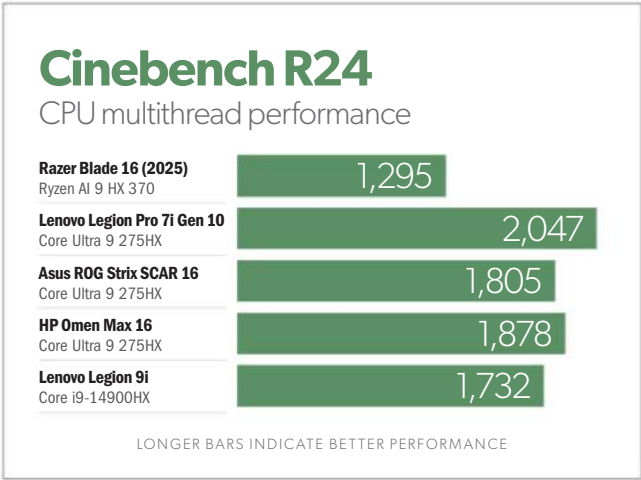
The Razer Blade 16 is a potent machine. Scores upward of 8,000 points in PCMark 10 don't come easily, but the Blade 16 managed



it well. This holistic benchmark provides an idea of how well the system can handle all sorts of common workloads, and this kind of score leaves little doubt that the Blade 16 can keep up with much of what the average user will throw at it. That said, Razer is trailing the pack here. And as we dig into more targeted performance tests, it'll become clear why.

In practice, the Blade 16 does manage everyday use well. But this can see the system handing off display management between the dGPU and iGPU, and it's not seamless. It may be quick, but it tends to happen right in the middle of me doing something, so I frequently feel the momentary freeze of the display as it switches over.

The Razer Blade 16 may sport a high-end CPU, but it's not leading the pack by any measure. Across Cinebench R15, R20, R23, and R24, the Razer Blade 16 and its AMD Ryzen AI 9 HX 370 CPU (which has a 4+8 core configuration) lag behind the Intel Core Ultra 9 275HX (which has an 8+16 core



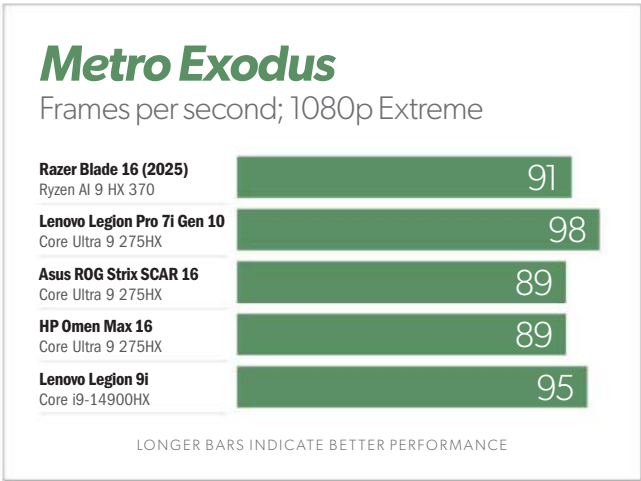
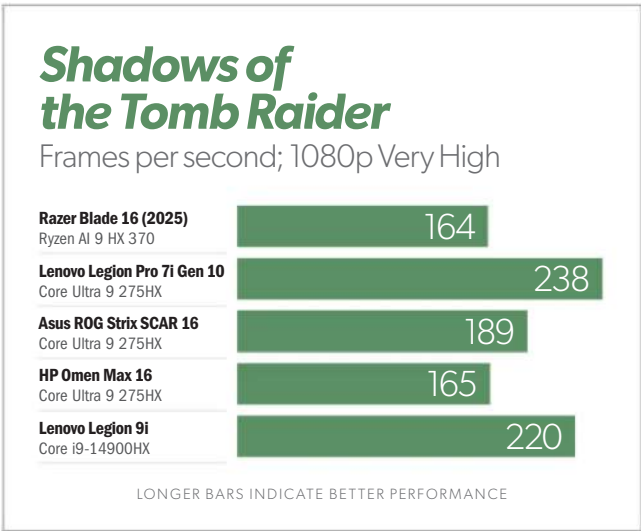
configuration) found in three of these other laptops. Across the board, it falls short in single-core and multi-core performance. Only against the Legion 9i’s Core i9-14900HX does the Blade 16 score any wins, and even there it’s only in single-core performance.

This isn’t to say the Blade 16 is a weak system, but if you’re looking for the most raw power, these other systems generally have it beat. And sure enough, this raw CPU grunt bears out in Handbrake as well, where the

Razer Blade 16 takes more than 50 percent longer to complete its encoding tasks next to the Intel Lunar Lake–equipped laptops and even falls over a minute behind the Lenovo Legion 9i Gen 9 with its older (though no slouch) Intel Core i9-14900HX.

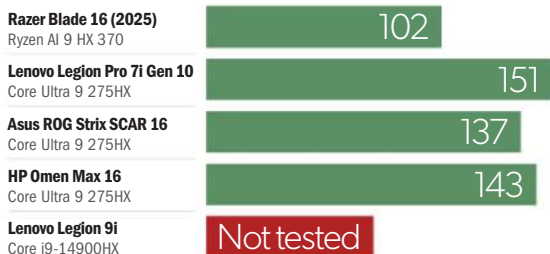
That CPU deficit comes back to bite the Razer Blade 16 again when it comes to less-demanding 1080p gaming. In *Shadow of the Tomb Raider*, the Blade was largely bound by its CPU, so even though it was the only system in this pack with an RTX 5090, it performed at the back of the pack. It was so CPU-bound, in fact, that bumping the resolution from 1080p to 1440p saw performance drop only to an average of 161 FPS.

Unfortunately, even as more weight is put on the GPU, the Razer Blade 16 doesn’t manage to speed away from the competition. *Metro Exodus* remains quite demanding even at 1080p. Here, the Razer Blade 16 is offering undeniably excellent performance, but it’s simply no more excellent than the other



Cyberpunk 2077

Frames per second; 1080p Ultra



LONGER BARS INDICATE BETTER PERFORMANCE

systems here, and the Lenovo Legion Pro 7i Gen 10's performance is good for an almost 8 percent lead.

Ray tracing appears to be a big equalizer for these systems. Running *Cyberpunk 2077* at its Ultra preset without any ray-tracing effects, the Blade 16 again falls way behind. But with the RT Overdrive preset, all of the systems drop to within a frame or two of 40 FPS (except the Legion 9i, which was not tested with *Cyberpunk 2077*).

3DMark's Port Royale benchmark further

shows this equalizing effect. Where the Blade 16 had been trailing in other tests, it's back in the game when heavy ray-tracing effects are called for. It gets a minor lead over the ROG Strix Scar 16 and HP Omen Max 16, but it's an incredibly marginal improvement over the RTX 4090 seen in the Lenovo Legion 9i. But more crucially, the Blade 16 still lags behind the Legion Pro 7i Gen 10 and its RTX 5080.

BATTERY LIFE

To the Razer Blade 16's credit, it at least does a good job managing its battery. Some gaming laptops struggle to wrangle their discrete GPUs when operating on battery power, and that can see them rip right through their battery. In my testing, the Blade 16 generally managed to disable the GPU and lean on the iGPU when it was away from its charger. That paid off in our battery test, running a local 4K video with the display set between 250 and 260 nits and the system in airplane mode, where the Blade 16 managed

3DMark Time Spy

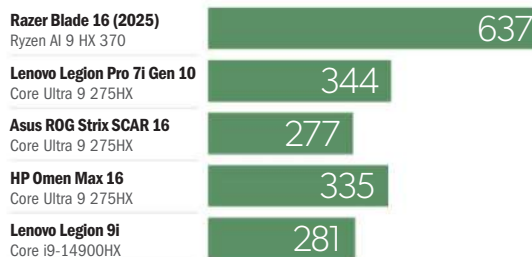
GPU performance



LONGER BARS INDICATE BETTER PERFORMANCE

Battery Life

Minutes



LONGER BARS INDICATE BETTER PERFORMANCE

to run for a bit over 10 and a half hours.

That performance saw the Razer Blade 16 almost double the run times of its competition here. Only two of these other machines managed to break 5 hours, and neither exceeded 6 hours. The Blade 16 even managed to hold up well in everyday use, generally making it through most of the day. On at least one occasion, I noticed the discrete GPU remaining active on battery power, but I was able to manually end applications that were using it, and then it deactivated.

Despite having some of the most extreme-performance hardware you can find for a laptop today, I found the Razer Blade 16 frequently holding me up while I was trying to do simple things in Windows when operating on battery power. It frequently stalled out as I tried to get into various settings menus, and casually browsing with videos running would occasionally see the video sputter or have the display freeze entirely (a not uncommon experience on laptop iGPUs).

BOTTOM LINE

Every time I've tested a high-end Razer Blade, I've seen it sacrifice performance in its pursuit of a slimmer, lighter design. That's true again here, putting it at odds with the kind of high-performance parts you can configure the 2025 Blade 16 to include. The Blade 16's RTX 5090 falling behind other systems running RTX 5080 and RTX 4090 GPUs is a bad look, especially when the Blade 16 hits such a lofty

price to provide that RTX 5090. For those seeking extreme performance, the Blade 16 just doesn't stand out as sensible.

The lower-tier models of the Blade 16 may actually be where it begins to make sense. The Legion Pro 7i 16 Gen 10 that has harried the Blade 16 so thoroughly through our benchmarking suite has a base price of \$2,849 and comes with an RTX 5070 Ti. The Blade 16, meanwhile, comes with an RTX 5070 for \$2,799 (though the CPU also drops to a slightly slower Ryzen AI 9 365 CPU), or you can bump it to \$2,999 to get an RTX 5070 Ti. With closer-matched internals and prices, the Blade's slimmer design, lower weight, and longer battery life can help buoy its value next to the Lenovo system. And with any luck, the Blade 16's thermal and power designs may be better able to cope with the lower-tier internals to actually run them at their full potential. 🔌

Razer Blade 16 (2025)



PROS

- Impressively svelte for a 16-inch gaming laptop.
- Surprisingly good battery life.
- Gorgeous display.

CONS

- Huge trackpad fumbles palm rejection.
- More sluggish on battery power.
- Trails cheaper competitors at every turn.

BOTTOM LINE

The Razer Blade 16 is sleek but sacrifices performance, with its RTX 5090 model often trailing RTX 5080 laptops despite a higher price. Lower-end configurations may offer better value.

From \$2,399



Dell Plus 14 2-in-1: A versatile, inexpensive touchscreen machine

The Dell Plus 14 2-in-1 isn't exciting, but it's a well-rounded budget 2-in-1 that offers good bang for your buck. **BY MATTHEW S. SMITH**

If you haven't heard, Dell dropped a bombshell earlier this year. It announced the company has done away with its well-known Inspiron, XPS, and Precision brands and instead opted for an entirely new hierarchy.

At the bottom of this hierarchy, you'll find laptops like the Dell 14 Plus 2-in-1. Last year, this would've been called a Dell Inspiron 14 2-in-1, and despite the change in name, it still fills its role of providing an affordable entry point into computing.

SPECIFICATIONS

The Dell 14 Plus 2-in-1 that PC World received for testing is an entry-level AMD configuration with an AMD Ryzen AI 5 340 processor at its heart. Dell offers many different Ryzen AI processors, as well as Intel models, but this is among the least powerful configurations available.

CPU: AMD Ryzen AI 5 340 (6 cores, up to 4.8GHz)

Memory: 16GB LPDDR5x

Graphics/GPU: AMD Radeon 840M

NPU: AMD 50 TOPs

Display: 14-inch 1920×1200 60Hz WVA 300-nits touchscreen

Storage: 512GB M.2 PCIe 4.0 NVMe solid state drive

Webcam: 1080p 30fps camera

Connectivity: 2×

USB-C 3.2 Gen 2 with Power Delivery and DisplayPort, 1× USB-A 3.2 Gen 1, 1× HDMI 1.4, 3.5mm audio jack

Networking: Wi-Fi 7, Bluetooth 5.4

Biometrics: Fingerprint reader

Battery capacity: 64 watt-hours

Dimensions: 12.36 inch×8.9 in×0.65 in

Weight: 3.51 pounds

Operating System: Windows 11 Home

Price: \$849.99 MSRP/\$599.99 at time of testing (Best Buy)

That's reflected in the price. Although it technically carries an MSRP of \$849.99 on Dell.com, which feels a bit steep, it currently sells on Best Buy for \$599.99, which is among the lowest prices you can expect for a Windows laptop that has the most recent generation of AMD or Intel processor inside. While this is a sale price, the laptop was listed just a couple weeks ago—so I'd expect this "sale" to occur frequently.

Despite its low sale price, the laptop doesn't cut corners too closely. It still provides 16GB of RAM and a 512GB solid-state drive.

You can expect to pay higher prices if you do decide to go with a Plus 14 2-in-1 from Dell's website. However, some of the models



The Dell Plus 14 2-in-1 is a good option for shoppers looking to snag a do-it-all Windows device on a tight budget.

available on Dell.com offer a 1TB solid-state drive, and there's also an option for a 2560×1600 resolution display on the Intel variant, which is an upgrade over the entry-level model's 1920×1200 display.

DESIGN AND BUILD QUALITY

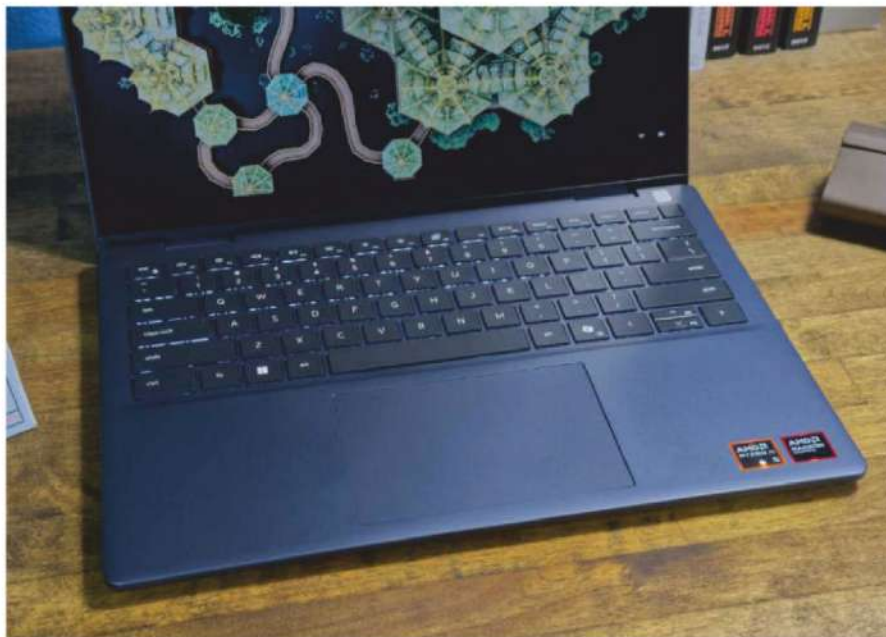
Budget Windows 2-in-1s aren't exactly known for their riveting or dramatic design, and the Dell 14 Plus 2-in-1 is

no exception. It's a simple, slim 14-inch machine that measures no greater than 0.65 inches thick, available in a silver or navy-blue colorway, neither of which is remarkable.

With that said, it's a well-executed laptop when it comes to build quality. Opening the laptop lid reveals a bit of display flex, but not enough to raise any concerns. It's a similar story with the lower chassis, which does slightly creak if handled roughly but doesn't visibly flex unless truly abused.

I also like the materials used. I felt the plastics on the lower chassis had a nice texture to them and didn't try to fake a metallic finish. The rear of the display panel, meanwhile, seems to be made of aluminum and offers a premium feel.

Of course, as the name indicates, the Dell 14 Plus 2-in-1 is a 2-in-1 device with a



The keyboard ranks among this laptop's best traits.

touchscreen, and the hinge allows the display to be rotated back 360 degrees for use like a tablet. It's too large and heavy to be comfortably used as a tablet for any length of time, but the option is useful if you want to take notes or draw. Dell doesn't include an Active Pen with the 2-in-1, but one is available for about \$40 (fave.co/43KUBEg). Owners can also rotate the display partway back to use the keyboard like a kickstand, which can be handy if you want to use the laptop to watch Netflix or YouTube.

KEYBOARD, TRACKPAD

The Dell 14 Plus 2-in-1's keyboard ranks among its best traits. The keys have good travel and a definitive tactile feel with a subtle, clicky bottoming action. I found the keyboard comfortable to use for long typing sessions.

The comfort is aided by a good amount of palm rest space below the bottom of the keyboard. Keyboard backlighting is standard, and it does what it says on the tin.

The touchpad is less remarkable but also competent. It measures about 4.5 inches wide and about 3 inches deep. The touchpad felt responsive in my testing and handled multi-touch gestures well. However, some competitors—most notably Asus (fave.co/441Nczf)—offer budget models with larger touchpads.

Of course, since this is a 2-in-1 with a touchscreen, it's possible to use the touchscreen instead of the touchpad. I personally prefer having the option to touch the screen over not having that option, if it doesn't add too much to the price, and the Dell 14 Plus 2-in-1 is certainly affordable.

DISPLAY, AUDIO

Most Dell 14 Plus 2-in-1 configurations have a WVA-LCD touchscreen display with a resolution of 1920×1200 and a refresh rate of 60 Hz. A 2560×1600 upgrade is available on some models from Dell.com, but PC World did not receive that display to test.



The 14-inch display's 1920×1200 resolution is quite sharp.

Display quality is passable. On the plus side, the 14-inch display's 1920×1200 resolution is quite sharp. However, the display is only rated for 300 nits of brightness, and on top of that it has a glossy coating that shows quite a bit of glare. That is a recipe for problems if you intend to use the laptop in a bright room or outdoors.

Color performance is also mediocre. The display looks reasonably saturated and vibrant on its own, but if compared to an OLED display (which can be found on some price-competitive laptops, like the Lenovo IdeaPad 5x, fave.co/4ldOhep, and Asus Zenbook 14, fave.co/3SjDWSm), the difference is night and day in OLED's favor. The same is true for contrast, since OLED displays have an effectively infinite contrast ratio that results in a deeper, more immersive image.

To put it simply, the display is not among the Dell 14 Plus 2-in-1's strong points, and it's the one feature that cuts strongly against a recommendation. If you want a budget laptop with a great display, this isn't it.

Audio quality is better, though still mixed. The speakers deliver good volume and clarity, especially with dialogue, which is more than can be said for many budget laptops. Throw a bit of bass at them, however, and distortion can result. Even the laptop chassis itself can vibrate, creating an annoying rattle. The speakers are good for podcasts and video calls, but not for games or music.

WEBCAM, MICROPHONE, BIOMETRICS

The Dell 14 Plus 2-in-1 comes with a 1080p webcam and a dual-array microphone, both of which are common specifications for modern Windows laptops. The webcam is sharp, and the microphone picks up good audio quality with great noise rejection, especially if AI noise rejection features are enabled. The camera includes a physical privacy shutter, which is always nice to see.

The one slightly unusual specification for the price point is the inclusion of a fingerprint reader on the power button in the upper left

corner of the keyboard. It works well in most situations, although a bit of grime or moisture on your finger can fool it. So don't try to log in after taking a swig of Mountain Dew.

CONNECTIVITY

Dell has a reputation for leaning on modern connectivity, and the 14 Plus 2-in-1 is no exception.

It provides two USB-C ports, both of which offer power delivery and DisplayPort video connectivity, and both of which can be used to power the laptop with the included USB-C power adapter. They are joined by one USB-A port, an HDMI 1.4 port, and a 3.5mm audio jack.

Although I could nitpick about the lack of a second USB-A port, which means you'll need an adapter if you happen to want to connect a wired keyboard and mouse, this



Dell has a reputation for leaning on modern connectivity, and the 14 Plus 2-in-1 is no exception.

type of connectivity is typical for a modern Windows laptop.

When it comes to wireless connectivity, the laptop supports Wi-Fi 7 and Bluetooth 5.4, which are the latest versions of the respective wireless standards. Although this is common for modern Windows laptops, at this price point you might end up looking at some older models from the 2024 or 2023 model years, and it’s likely they would not have Wi-Fi 7 or Bluetooth 5.4. Keep that in mind if wireless performance matters to you.

PERFORMANCE

The Dell 14 Plus 2-in-1 that PC World received for testing was an entry-level model with an AMD Ryzen AI 5 340 processor. This APU has a 6-core CPU and AMD Radeon 840M graphics. As you might expect, the entry-level CPU and integrated GPU result in modest overall performance.

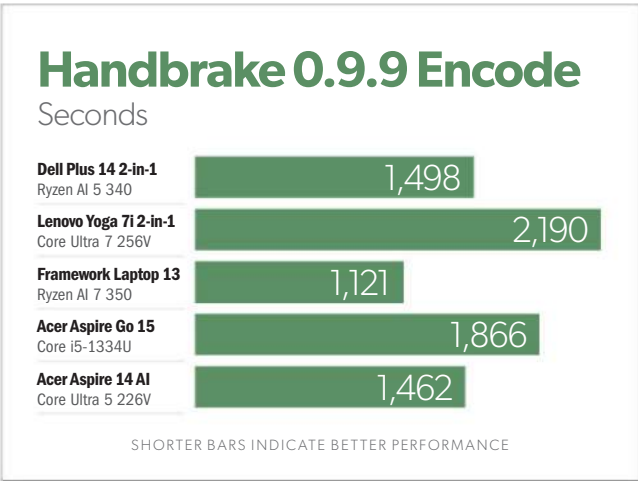
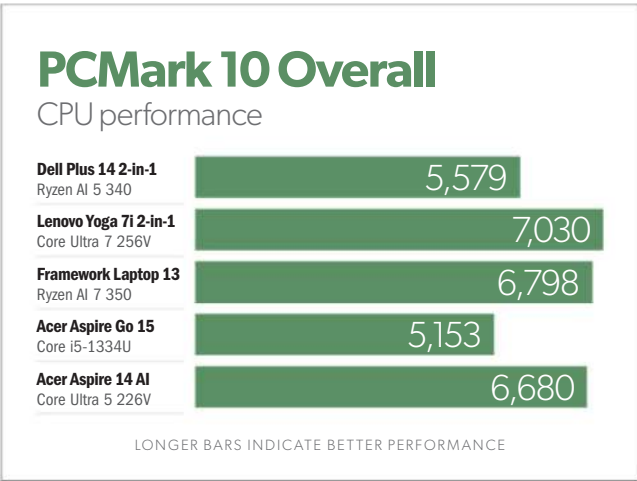
PCMark 10, a holistic system benchmark, didn’t put the Dell 14 Plus 2-in-1 off to the best

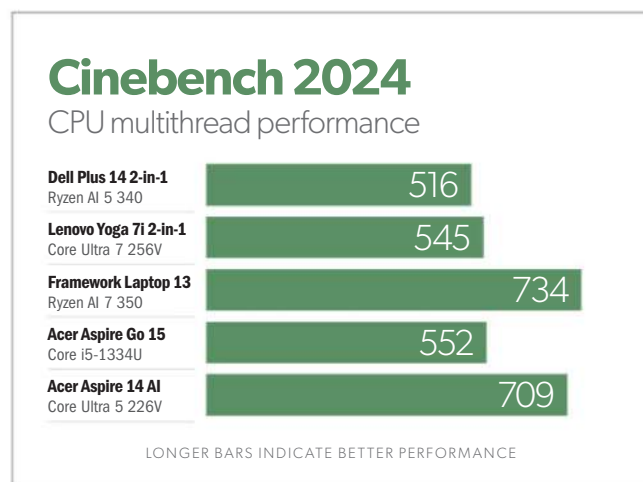
start. While the score of 5,579 isn’t bad for a budget laptop, it’s also a long way from what systems equipped with Ryzen AI 7/9 or Intel Core Ultra Series 2 processors tend to achieve. The AMD Radeon 840M, which is relatively less capable than many IGP’s today, doesn’t help matters.

Handbrake, a heavily multi-threaded long-duration benchmark, is a bit more favorable. The Dell 14 Plus 2-in-1 churned through a transcode of a two-hour-long movie in 1,498 seconds using purely the CPU cores (i.e. without special encoding features enabled). That’s not a bad result for the price, and it places the Ryzen AI 5 340 in a similar league to the Intel Core Ultra 5 226V.

The Ryzen AI 5 340 delivers a respectable but hardly earth-shattering multi-core score of 7,993 in Cinebench R23. Although a long way from the top, this is again a decent result.

The main issue here, I think, is the lack of cores. Six isn’t a lot in 2025, and Cinebench R23 does tend to make good use of available

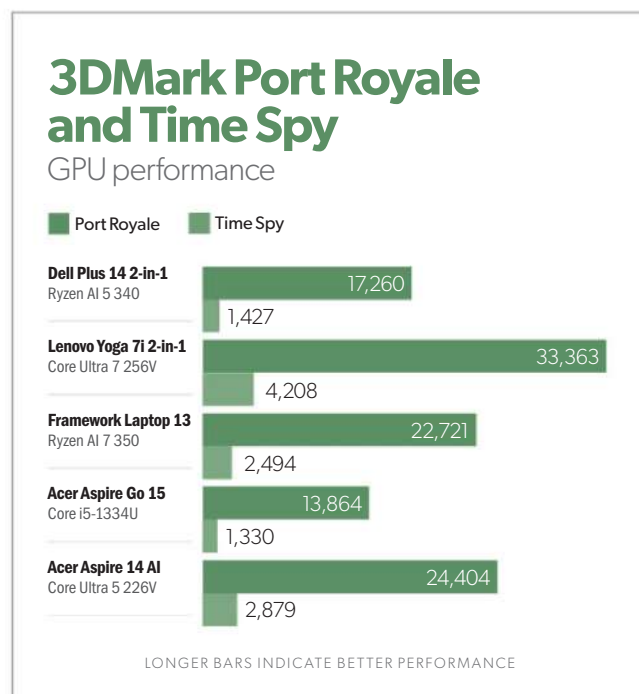




cores, whatever they might be. The Ryzen AI 5 340's Cinebench R23 single-core score was 1,828, which is basically the same as the other processors listed in the graph above (they score between 1,700 to 1,900). This indicates the cores that are available are speedy.

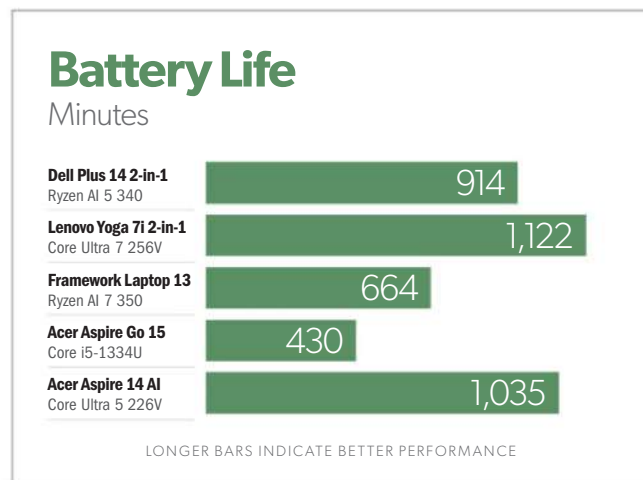
As mentioned earlier, the AMD Ryzen AI 5 has AMD Radeon 840M graphics, which is much less capable than the more widely known and well-regarded AMD Radeon 880M and AMD Radeon 890M. Specifically, the Radeon 840M has just four graphics cores, a big cut from the 880M (12) and 890M (16).

3DMark Time Spy shows the result with a score of just 1,427. That's much lower than an AMD Radeon 880M or 890M, as well as Intel's Arc 140V or even 130V graphics. These solutions tend to score 3,000 to 4,000, as the graphs show. To be fair, you do often need to pay a bit more for them—and laptops with the Intel Core Ultra 7 256V are available for just a couple hundred dollars more.



That's not to say the Dell Plus 14 2-in-1 is hopeless when it comes to graphics and gaming. The 2-in-1 could comfortably play *Grim Dawn*, an action-RPG released in 2016, at 1080p and medium detail. If you want to play *Diablo 4*, though, you're out of luck. It can technically launch and play, but in my experience no amount of fiddling with the settings made it an enjoyable experience.

The Dell Plus 14 2-in-1's overall performance is about what you should expect for the price. It's worth mentioning, however, that Dell provides 16GB of RAM and 512GB of solid-state storage. It's not uncommon for price-competitive 2-in-1s to only provide 8GB of RAM or 256GB of storage, both of which are a significant downgrade. These upgrades don't necessarily improve benchmark



performance, but do make the Dell 14 Plus 2-in-1 more usable day-to-day and over time.

BATTERY LIFE AND PORTABILITY

A 64-watt-hour battery powers the Dell 14 Plus 2-in-1. That's an average size for a laptop in this category, and while the AMD Ryzen AI 5 340 is miserly when it's not under heavy load, it does struggle to compete with the latest Intel and Qualcomm hardware.

I measured a tad over 15 hours of battery life in PC World's standard battery test, which loops a 4K file of the short film *Tears of Steel*. If 15 hours sounds like a lot, I agree. However, as the graph shows, a lot of modern laptops can achieve 18 to 22 hours on this test.

The test result matched my subjective experience. I spent some of my time with the Dell Plus 14 2-in-1 traveling, and I found it could easily endure a day of mixed web browsing and writing, with occasional breaks,

with 40 percent of the battery (or more) left once I arrived at a destination.

I think the Dell 14 Plus 2-in-1's battery life is fine, and certainly more than a typical user is likely to need. Still, it appears that AMD's Ryzen AI 340 is behind Qualcomm's Snapdragon X Plus and Intel's Core Ultra Series 2 where battery life is concerned.

BOTTOM LINE

The Dell Plus 14 2-in-1 is a good option for shoppers looking to snag a do-it-all Windows device on a tight budget. It offers versatile design, a nice keyboard, and well-rounded specifications while avoiding a major downside that would take it out of contention. It's particularly alluring when on sale for \$599 at Best Buy, which is less than many comparable Windows 2-in-1s and laptops. While I would prefer to see a better display or a slightly larger touchpad, I enjoyed my time with the 2-in-1. 🔌

Dell Plus 14 2-in-1



PROS

- Robust design with 2-in-1 versatility.
- Enjoyable keyboard.
- Good battery life.

CONS

- Design doesn't look appealing at first glance.
- Display could be brighter and more vibrant.
- CPU, GPU performance doesn't stand out.

BOTTOM LINE

The Dell Plus 14 2-in-1 isn't exciting, but it's a well-rounded budget 2-in-1 that offers good bang for your buck.

\$849

Alienware 16 Area-51: Performance from another planet

Now this is a gaming laptop. **BY CHRIS HOFFMAN**



The Alienware 16 Area-51 (fave.co/448jbcn) is a high-end gaming laptop with a high-end Intel Core Ultra 9 275HX CPU and Nvidia RTX 5080 graphics, which were both just recently released. It's a beautiful machine with premium touches like a mechanical keyboard. While it's no budget gaming

laptop (fave.co/44jP4EE), it's competitively priced compared to other laptops with similar hardware—and Alienware's version may just be a better package.

SPECIFICATIONS

The Alienware 16 Area-51 is a 16-inch gaming laptop that combines a 24-core Intel Core Ultra 9 275HX CPU along with an Nvidia RTX

50-series GPU. Our review model had an RTX 5080 GPU, but you can also get this machine with an RTX 5070 Ti or 5090 GPU. While the model we reviewed retails for \$3,349, the base model starts at \$2,999.

That Intel Core Ultra 9 275HX is worth highlighting! This Core Ultra (Series 2) processor is based on the Arrow Lake architecture and is screaming fast. In our benchmarks, this machine topped out the charts. However, it has a slow neural processing unit (NPU) and doesn't meet the bar for Windows 11's Copilot+ PC AI features (fave.co/3HJVbJN), if those matter to you. (Unless this is something you know you care about, I wouldn't worry about it—especially since Microsoft is signaling [fave.co/43M0jWu] it may one day roll out these

features more widely. But they aren't here at launch, and that may matter to some people.)

Model number: Alienware 16 Area-51 AW30

CPU: Intel Core Ultra 9 275HX

Memory: 32GB DDR5 RAM

Graphics/GPU: Nvidia GeForce RTX 5080

NPU: Intel AI Boost (up to 13 TOPS)

Display: 16-inch 3200×1800 IPS display with 240Hz refresh rate

Storage: 1 TB SSD

Webcam: 8MP 3840×2160 camera

Connectivity: 2× Thunderbolt 5 (USB Type-C), 3× USB Type-A 3.2 Gen 1 (5 Gbps), 1× HDMI 2.1, 1× combo audio jack, 1× SD card slot

Networking: Wi-Fi 7, Bluetooth 5.4

Biometrics: IR camera for Windows Hello

Battery capacity: 96

Watt-hours

Dimensions:

14.37×11.41×1.12 inches

Weight: 7.49 pounds

MSRP: \$3,349 as tested



The laptop looks like it's about to blast the thrusters and head to outer space.

DESIGN AND BUILD QUALITY

The Alienware laptops I've reviewed have had solid build quality, and this laptop is no exception. The "Liquid Teal" color has a lid that looks a lot like forest green in some lighting. Dell describes it as "a



On the bottom, there's a "thermal bump" with gorilla glass that lets you look inside the bottom of the machine.

dark iridescent finish on the anodized aluminum [that] gives the system a dynamic sheen." At about seven and a half pounds, it's no thin-and-light laptop, but it is very reasonable for a machine this powerful.

With a glowing Alienware logo on the lid, a light bar on the bump at the back, and black used throughout the rest of the machine—including on the keyboard tray and lid, so you aren't looking at that Liquid Teal all the time—this is very much an Alienware design. I like the look and how the color stands out. It doesn't look like just another gaming laptop, but you'll have to

decide whether it's the right look for you. I know not everyone is looking for this type of color scheme, and there's a reason why so many gaming laptops are a traditional black or a sharp and clean white.

On the bottom, there's a "thermal bump" with gorilla glass that isn't just about airflow intake: It lets you look inside the bottom of the machine. This is the kind of high-end touch you'll find on this machine. It does look cool!

The anodized aluminum finish does pick up fingerprints a little more than I'd like—something you'll see in a few of the photos. That's not unusual, but since we're talking high-end touches, it's worth taking note of.



The 16 Area-51 has an excellent keyboard.

KEYBOARD AND TRACKPAD

The Alienware 16 Area-51's keyboard is absolutely excellent. Our review unit had a Cherry MX ultralow-profile mechanical keyboard. A mechanical keyboard in a laptop is almost unheard of—I think the only time I've ever used a mechanical keyboard built into a laptop was when I reviewed another Alienware machine. It's definitely a tiny bit louder than the usual nonmechanical keyboards, but it's fairly quiet.

There's not much room to complain, although I will say that many gamers would probably prefer that the Copilot key (fave.co/49QnG1u) wasn't so large. Located just to the left of the arrow keys, it's bound to get in the way. Sure, it seems laptops must have a Copilot key these days—but why does the key have to be so wide? Luckily, you can disable it or remap it to another function.

The laptop's keyboard also has per-key backlighting you can customize. Even the touchpad is an RGB touchpad that lights up when you touch it—and shortly after, so it's not on all the time. The touchpad itself feels great to use, with a smooth surface, a crisp mechanical clicking action, and a good position below the keyboard.

DISPLAY AND SPEAKERS

The Alienware 16 Area-51 has a 16-inch IPS display with a QHD+ resolution (that's 3200×1800) along with a fast 240Hz refresh rate, 3ms response time, Nvidia G-Sync, and 500 nits of brightness.

On paper, these are great specs—and they look great in real life, too. It's an awesome display that makes games look great, and the fast refresh rate and response time are part of what makes it feel so good. Combined with the speedy hardware, this laptop delivered excellent performance in *Doom: The Dark Ages*, rendering high detail settings at a high frame rate.

The downsides are the same ones you see on paper. There's no support for HDR in games here, and the resolution comes short



This is an awesome display that makes games look great.

of 4K. This isn't an OLED—some people will prefer the more vivid colors of an OLED display, even if it comes with a lower refresh rate or lower response time. But if you aren't itching for HDR or an OLED display, I think you'll be happy with this display.

The speakers are also unusually good for a laptop. Many gaming laptops—even expensive ones—cut corners on the speakers. Audio sounded great and punchy in games like *Doom: The Dark Ages*. Music was unusually good for a laptop, but I'll be honest: When it came to the clarity of the instruments in Steely Dan's *Aja* and the bass in Daft Punk's *Get Lucky*, the speakers didn't wow as much as the other components on this laptop. The experience is always best with a good pair of headphones or external speakers—no surprise there.

WEBCAM, MICROPHONE, BIOMETRICS

The Alienware 16 Area-51's 8MP 3840×2160 camera sounds impressive on paper. And it looks fine in the real world, but it doesn't absolutely wow. Look at a good external webcam. This is more than good enough for online meetings and video chats. But, this being a gaming



The Alienware has a solid collection of connectivity options.

laptop, I'd plan to get an external webcam if you plan to do much streaming.

There's no physical camera privacy shutter, which I know many people like to see.

The microphone setup also just sounds fine to me—it can pick up clear enough audio, but you won't be getting the kind of crisp, high-quality audio you would with an external microphone. It's fine, but you'll always have a better gaming experience with external audio.

When it comes to biometrics, this machine has an IR camera for Windows Hello (fave.co/3TsHLUV) so you can sign in with your face. As usual on Windows 11 laptops, it worked well. There's no fingerprint reader here, however.

CONNECTIVITY

The Alienware 16 Area-51 has a solid collection of connectivity options. On the left

side, you've got a combo audio jack as well as a full-size SD card reader.

You'll find most of the ports on the back, which is where I prefer to see them, as it gets them out of the way of your mouse and minimizes annoying cable clutter on your desk.

On the back of the machine, you'll find two Thunderbolt 5 (USB Type-C) ports, three USB Type-A ports, an HDMI 2.1 port, and a place to plug in the power adapter. Thunderbolt 5 has been missing in action (fave.co/4ke3BHp), so it's impressive to see it at all—although configurations with an RTX 5070 and below get those ports in Thunderbolt 4 form. While it's always nice to see higher-end hardware, it likely won't make a difference in the real world.

On the other hand, that's it. If you were looking for an Ethernet port, for example, you'll have to add it via a dongle.

Wireless connectivity is good now that Intel's hardware has caught up—this laptop supports the latest Wi-Fi 7 (fave.co/3rPd820) and Bluetooth 5.4 wireless standards, and I had no problems with the Wi-Fi.

PERFORMANCE

The Alienware 16 Area-51 delivered screaming-good gaming performance, and I was tearing through demons in the just-released *Doom: The Dark Ages* on the highest "Ultra Nightmare" settings with smooth performance. Dell has a lot to say about the "cryo-tech cooling technology" and this

PCMark 10 Overall

CPU performance



LONGER BARS INDICATE BETTER PERFORMANCE

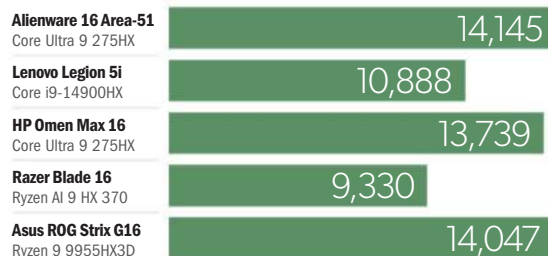
laptop's increased airflow, quieter fans, and all-around improved cooling performance. While gaming, the cooling worked well, with the keyboard staying reasonably cool and the machine blasting most of the hot air straight out of the back where it won't bother you.

As always, though, we ran the Alienware 16 Area-51 through our standard benchmarks (fave.co/4cjKcl4) to see how it performs.

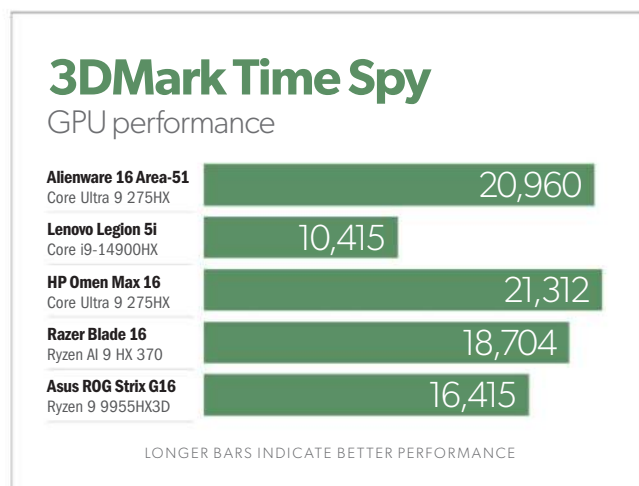
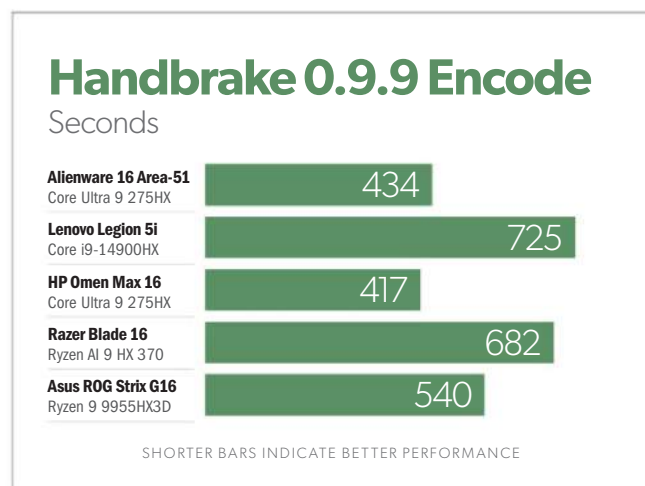
First, we run PCMark 10 to get an idea of overall system performance. With an overall

Cinebench R20

CPU multithread performance



LONGER BARS INDICATE BETTER PERFORMANCE



PCMark 10 score of 8,768, this Alienware machine beat other recent gaming laptops we tested with Nvidia RTX 50-series GPUs. It noticeably outpaced the HP Omen Max 16, despite both machines having the same CPU.

Next, we run Cinebench R20. This is a heavily multithreaded benchmark that focuses on overall CPU performance. It's a quick benchmark, so cooling under extended workloads isn't a factor. But, since it's heavily multithreaded, CPUs with more cores have a huge advantage.

With a Cinebench R20 multi-threaded score of 14,145, the Alienware 16 Area-51 topped out the charts once again, narrowly scraping ahead of the Asus ROG Strix G16 and its AMD Ryzen 9 9955HX3D. (To be fair, the results are basically within the margin of error here.)

We also run an encode with Handbrake. This is another heavily multithreaded benchmark, but it runs over an extended period. This demands that the laptop's

cooling kick in, and many laptops will throttle and slow down under load.

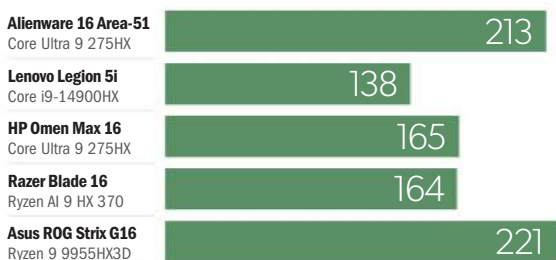
The Alienware 16 Area-51 completed the encode process in an average of 434 seconds, which is just over seven minutes. The only other machine even within spitting distance was the HP Omen Max 16 (fave.co/4e12eK6), which has the same CPU. (HP's machine was ahead here for some reason, but we can put it down to the margin of error.) The results show just how powerful Intel's 24-core Intel Core Ultra 9 275HX CPU is for multithreaded performance. This thing is a beast.

Next, getting to gaming performance, we start with a standard graphical benchmark. We run 3DMark Time Spy, a graphical benchmark that focuses on GPU performance.

With a 3DMark Time Spy score of 20960, the Alienware 16 Area-51 delivered high performance—coming second to the HP Omen Max 16. Both have the same Nvidia

Shadow of the Tomb Raider

Frames per second; 1080p Highest



LONGER BARS INDICATE BETTER PERFORMANCE

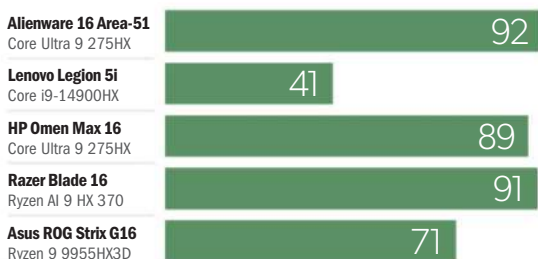
RTX 5080 GPU. Again, this may be the margin of error, or the HP Omen Max 16's cooling may be a bit more effective.

Both machines beat the Razer Blade 16 despite that machine having a faster RTX 5090 GPU. That machine lags in performance ([fave.co/4kCL6gc](https://www.fave.co/4kCL6gc)), sacrificing it for a sleeker design. This shows how important benchmarks are instead of just on-paper specs!

After that, we run the benchmarks built into some standard games. First, we use the

Metro Exodus

Frames per second; 1080p Extreme, no RT



LONGER BARS INDICATE BETTER PERFORMANCE

benchmark in *Shadow of the Tomb Raider* to test all the gaming laptops we review. It's an older game, but it's a great way to compare graphical performance across different PCs.

With an average FPS of 213, the Alienware 16 Area-51 delivered high-end performance and left many similar systems in the dust.

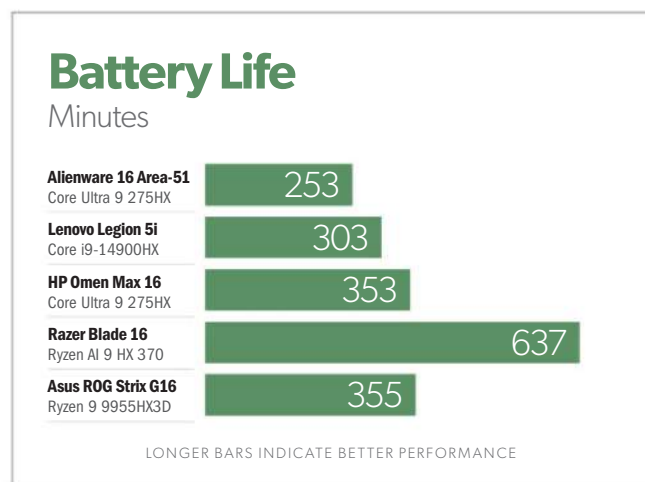
Finally, we run the benchmark in *Metro Exodus*. This is a more demanding game, and we set the benchmark to 1080p resolution at the extreme detail setting.

With an average FPS of 92 in this high-end *Metro Exodus* benchmark, the Alienware 16 Area-51 topped all its competitors—even the Razer Blade with its RTX 5090 GPU couldn't outpace it, which just goes to show the downsides of packing such powerful hardware into such a thin machine.

Overall, the Alienware 16 Area-51 is an absolute monster that squeezes an incredible amount of performance out of its high-end Intel CPU and Nvidia GPU. There's not much room to improve here—outside of splurging for an upgrade to an RTX 5090 GPU in this machine or getting a desktop gaming PC instead!

BATTERY LIFE

The Alienware 16 Area-51 is a gaming laptop designed for maximum performance, not for long battery life. However, Dell has put a huge 96 watt-hour battery in this machine—it couldn't be much larger or the U.S.



Transportation Security Administration wouldn't allow it on an airplane.

To benchmark the battery life, we play a 4K copy of *Tears of Steel* on repeat on Windows 11 with airplane mode enabled at 250 nits screen brightness until the laptop suspends itself. This is a best-case scenario for any laptop since local video playback is so efficient, and real battery life in day-to-day use is always going to be less than this.

The Alienware 16 Area-51 ran for an average of 253 minutes before suspending itself—that's just over four hours. It's lower than some of its competitors, though not by much. And that doesn't really matter if you're looking for a beefy gaming laptop to use while plugged into an outlet.

In other words, you can use this laptop away from an outlet for a few hours in a pinch, but you won't want to. Also, it's worth mentioning that, for serious gaming performance, you need to have the laptop plugged into an outlet anyway.

BOTTOM LINE

The Alienware 16 Area-51 is an amazing 16-inch gaming laptop. Yes, it's a good amount of money—but it's competitively priced with other high-end gaming laptops with similar hardware, and you also get an amazing package. I love having a mechanical keyboard in a laptop.

If you're looking for a capable PC with the latest high-end hardware and this fits your budget, you'll be happy with this machine. It's excellent.

But not everything is for everyone! Be sure to consider what type of display you want—if you want an OLED screen, the HP Omen Max 16 may be a better pick. That greenish Liquid Teal may give some people pause, too—I like the look, but I imagine it's not everyone's style. It'd be nice if Dell offered multiple color options for this laptop. 🔌

Alienware 16 Area-51



PROS

- High GPU and CPU performance.
- Competitive price for the hardware.
- Mechanical keyboard.

CONS

- No HDR for games.
- Copilot key is rather large.
- Liquid Teal color scheme may not please everyone.

BOTTOM LINE

The Alienware 16 Area-51 delivers serious gaming performance in an excellent package, complete with a mechanical keyboard and other high-end touches. It's competitively priced for the hardware, too.

\$3,349

THE 15 MOST DANGEROUS PLACES ON THE INTERNET





DON'T WANT TO CATCH MALWARE
OR GET HACKED BY CYBERCRIMINALS?
TAKE EXTRA CARE WHEN VISITING
THESE SITES—OR JUST AVOID THEM
ALTOGETHER. **BY JON MARTINDALE**

The internet might be more sanitized than it was in decades past, but it's still plenty dangerous. You've been warned that the web is a security

minefield—that it's easy to get in trouble. You can do everything right and still be taken by a malware infection, a phishing scam, or an invasion of online privacy. We want to help.

Here are some of the most dangerous threats on the internet and what you can do to stay out of harm's way. Not all web dangers are created equal, though. Indeed, some threats will actively come looking for you while others you may never see if you don't seek them out. Let our threat level indicator (shown right) be your guide:

THREAT LEVELS

BLUE | Perfectly Safe

This is the land of unicorns and fairies and candy raindrops, where nothing bad could ever happen. All joking aside, you'll never run across such a site on the internet.

GREEN | Slightly Dangerous

You'll get into trouble if you look for it, but your risk of being infected by malware or unknowingly having your privacy compromised is fairly low.

YELLOW | Moderately Dangerous

Tread carefully in these areas. Clicking on the wrong thing could get you into trouble.

ORANGE | Very Dangerous

Threats to your online safety and privacy abound. It's best to avoid these places entirely, but if you must go there, just assume that everyone's out to get you.

RED | Danger

Will Robinson! You'll almost certainly get nailed if you visit these places.

to further misinformation that reinforces the faux story that caught your interest, and it'll tell the algorithms to keep pushing more of that kind of content that interests you, sending you down the wrong path.

How to stay safe: While cutting out social media altogether is the best answer, it just isn't practical for most of us. You can protect yourself against social media misinformation by actively analyzing all stories, images, and links you come across. If it seems designed to provoke an emotional response in you, pause and reconsider. Double-check all stories with trusted third-party sources. And lastly, think about leaving certain social media sites that are inundated with misinformation and move toward

ones that are better moderated and more open (fave.co/3FTUtm).

THREAT 1: MISINFORMATION

GREEN

WHERE IT HAPPENS:

Social media

You know this one already, but we're all as susceptible as ever. As social media algorithms continue to curate content, create bubbles, and spur echo chambers, they've become better at pushing misinformation in stories and images that seem like they *could* be true—and that's often all it takes. Once you've clicked through, you'll be susceptible

THREAT 2: DEEPPAKES AND AI SCAMS

YELLOW

WHERE IT HAPPENS: Just about everywhere

This one's tricky because you're just as likely to find deepfakes and AI scams in your email inbox as you will on social media, on YouTube, and ads all across the internet. The dangers are equally varied. A deepfake (which is a video or audio that's been digitally

altered to appear as someone else) can damage someone's reputation, lead you to believe misinformation, or incite you to feel negatively towards certain groups, countries, or organizations. Meanwhile, AI scams can catch you off guard and hack your data or steal your personal information.

How to stay safe:

Deepfakes and AI scams are by nature hard to spot, which is why you need to develop a healthy skepticism toward everything on the internet. Remember that disinformation campaigns, hackers, and bad actors are all trying to prey on you in some way. Always question any video or audio that seems alarming or sensational.



When scanning a QR code in public, make sure it isn't a sticker.

does, it's because the fake site's owner wants you to input your login credentials so they can steal them.

Similarly, you may run into scam links on the web that replace certain mundane characters with lookalike letters, such as from the cyrillic alphabet. When you're in a rush, you may not easily spot the difference between **realsite.com** and **realsite.com**.

How to stay safe: Double-check every URL you type into a browser, and double-check every link you click on by hovering your mouse over it and looking at the URL preview at the bottom of the browser. When in doubt, it's safer to type in a URL than it is to click on a link.

THREAT 3: LOOKALIKE URLS

RED

WHERE IT HAPPENS: Your browser's address bar

With phishing scams (fave.co/3Ar3CWG) on the rise, you're likely to encounter lookalike URLs in fraudulent emails, but you're also likely to run into this if you often type URLs directly into your browser's address bar. If you mistype a popular website—for example, **goggle.com** instead of **google.com**—you could end up on a fake site that imitates the one you meant to visit. It doesn't happen all the time, but when it

THREAT 4: QR CODE SCAMS

ORANGE

WHERE IT HAPPENS:
The real world

QR code scams are particularly nefarious

because they can follow you into the real world. They're commonly found on parking meters, restaurant menus, bulletin boards, or outdoor venues that offer Wi-Fi access.

Scammers and criminals stick their own fake QR codes on top of the original ones—often with a literal sticker—and they send you to an imposter site that steals your logins, details, and/or financial information.

How to stay safe: Before scanning any QR code, double-check that it's from a legitimate organization. When scanning QR codes in public, make sure it isn't a sticker. Also, remember that QR code scams simply take you to fraudulent sites, so double-check that you've arrived on a legitimate page that doesn't have any red flags. If it seems off, close the tab.

THREAT 5: MALVERTISING

YELLOW

WHERE IT HAPPENS:
Streaming sites

Who hasn't visited ad-infested streaming sites to watch TV shows without suffering Netflix's or Disney's increasingly expensive paywalls? Doubly so for live sports! If you've ever pirated a soccer stream or boxing pay-per-view, then you know the kinds of sketchy sites I'm talking about. The risk here is that these sites are funded via ads, but most ad sellers don't want to be associated with such illegal activity—so these streaming sites have to be less scrupulous with which ads they accept, and that means their ads can contain

malware. This is known as "malvertising."

How to stay safe: Not only should you *never* give these sites your personal or financial information, you should *never* click on any of their ads. Also, make sure your antivirus software is up to date and working properly before visiting such sites. (You *are* using antivirus software, right [fave.co/3CnDHuk]? Consider using a VPN, too. These sites are illegal, after all.

THREAT 6: DANGEROUS IDEOLOGIES

YELLOW

WHERE IT HAPPENS:

Discord, Telegram,

WhatsApp, other modern communication apps with weak moderation

Modern communication apps are great for staying in touch with friends and family, but they're also hotbeds of nefarious activity. Terrorists, white supremacist groups, illegal pornographers, and militant groups have all been known to use such apps for organizing, recruiting, and spreading dangerous ideologies and unlawful material. Some groups use these apps to operate slow-burn pipelines of propaganda, disinformation, and indoctrination to radicalize susceptible people.

How to stay safe: "Just say no" is useless advice most of the time, but it's entirely apt here. You just need to avoid such groups and communities. In fact, when you see them, consider reporting them. If you're part of an online community that has devolved into



Beware accounts that promise a big return on your Bitcoin investment.

espousing dangerous, derogatory, or distasteful ideas that make you uncomfortable, steer clear and leave. Delete. Block. Report. Move on.

THREAT 7: CRYPTO SCAMS

YELLOW

WHERE IT HAPPENS:
Social media, user

comments

Cryptocurrency and blockchain technology have some legitimate uses and could still impact the future of financial institutions, but we're still in the get-rich-quick, anything-goes era—and that means scammers love using crypto to part those who don't know any better from their money. Such scams include fake celebrity accounts that promise a big return on your investment of just a few fractions of Bitcoin, and crypto wallet transfer services that try to steal your private key and/or recovery phrase.

How to stay

safe: Not your keys, not your coins. If you own cryptocurrencies, keep your keys private and never share them with anyone. Get your crypto off exchanges and into cold wallets where you are the only master of your coins. You probably aren't going to be one

of those who get rich quick, so play it safe, invest only what you can afford to lose, never panic, and keep your FOMO in check.

THREAT 8: FAKE APP STORES

ORANGE

WHERE IT HAPPENS:
APK download sites

Every so often, Google might ban a game you really want to play or an app that you depended on. When this happens, you can usually sideload those apps and games via APK download sites—but if you aren't careful, you could fall victim to fake apps that are loaded with malware. It may seem fine and proper when you launch it, but in the background it could be stealing your passwords, credit card info, etc. The locked-down nature of the Google Play Store and Apple App Store can be annoying, but part of it is done for your protection. Going outside puts you at risk.

How to stay safe: For best results, avoid sideloading apps that aren't available through official app stores. But if you simply must download an app that isn't available, make sure you 100% trust the creator of the app and make sure you *only* download the app with their official links. Meanwhile, install anti-malware on your device for an extra layer of protection, and consider backing up your device just in case you catch ransomware (fave.co/4e1mE5R) that blocks you from accessing your data.

THREAT 9: MAN-IN-THE-MIDDLE ATTACKS

GREEN

WHERE IT HAPPENS:

Public Wi-Fi

Public Wi-Fi is super convenient, but remember: If you have free access to a public Wi-Fi

network, then so do scammers and hackers. Some hackers are able to eavesdrop on public Wi-Fi and tap into your online activity. Scammers can set up imitation Wi-Fi access points that *seem* like they belong to that cafe you're in, except it's a fake. Lastly, even without any scammers or hackers involved, do you trust whoever is providing you with free Wi-Fi? Perhaps *they're* the ones spying on you and stealing your personal data as it flows through the network.

How to stay safe: Always use a reputable VPN before connecting to public Wi-Fi. The VPN will encrypt your online activity and hide what you're doing so it's useless to anyone eavesdropping. But as a rule of thumb when using public Wi-Fi, don't log in to online accounts and don't type your banking details or any other sensitive

information you wouldn't want to share publicly. Assume everything you do on public Wi-Fi is being monitored, as it may well be.



Scammers can set up imitation Wi-Fi access points that seem like they belong to that cafe you're in.

THREAT 10: SEARCH ENGINE POISONING

YELLOW

WHERE IT HAPPENS:

Search engines

Search engine optimization has ruined search engines—in more ways than one. The first

page of Google's search results is often filled with not-so-high-quality content, but I'm talking about something else: the fact that scammers and hackers can also poison the search results by pushing their malicious websites to the top of the list, via either manipulative SEO techniques or paid ad positions. You might think you're clicking on a link to a well-known and reputable brand, but it could be an imposter site that tries to steal your sensitive data or infect you with malware.

How to stay safe: It's near impossible to avoid search engines altogether, so pay extra attention before clicking on links in the search results. Avoid clicking on the paid ad links, and always double-check the URL before clicking on an organic link. If it looks off, don't click it. Lastly, make sure you're protected by antivirus software.

THREAT 11: SCAM AND MALWARE EMAILS

YELLOW

WHERE IT HAPPENS:
Your inbox

The "Nigerian prince" scam email has been the butt of jokes for decades now, but the rise of generative AI has made these scams way more effective *and* overwhelming to deal with. Scam- and malware-infested emails are trickier than ever as they now



Never click links in unsolicited emails.

incorporate personal details to surgically target individuals. This can make them much harder to spot and easier to trust, lulling you into their carefully laid traps.

How to stay safe: There's no good replacement for email just yet, so we all need to keep using it for now. But you can be more careful by never clicking links in emails and never opening unsolicited attachments. If you didn't request it, don't bother with it. And as with other scams, be wary of any email that sounds alarming, urgent, or scary, especially if it seems to want you to act within a time limit.

THREAT 12: PHYSICAL ATTACKS IN PERSON

YELLOW

WHERE IT HAPPENS:
eBay, Craigslist, Facebook Marketplace, Vinted, Mercari, any used

marketplace with local pickup options

As the cost-of-living crisis chomps down on victims across the world, secondhand marketplaces have boomed in popularity. They're great for scoring deals and for limiting your environmental impact as a consumer. But they have their risks. You can be scammed, of course, but you can also be attacked if you pick up your purchases in person. Just a few months ago, a woman in Pennsylvania (fave.co/3ZxAeb8) was robbed while test-driving a used car she planned to buy.

How to stay safe: This problem isn't common enough to avoid secondhand marketplaces altogether, and you don't have to avoid local pickups either. But *always* meet in a well-lit, public space. Ideally, take a friend with you to the meet; if you have to go alone, *always* let someone know where you'll be, who you're meeting, and when you'll be

home. And if possible, skip the cash and pay for your purchase digitally—after inspecting the product's condition, of course.

THREAT 13: LIES AND HALLUCINATIONS**GREEN****WHERE IT HAPPENS:****AI chatbots, search engines**

The rapid growth of AI is both exciting yet terrifying. One of the scariest aspects of modern AI chatbots and assistants is how easily they make things up and confidently present them as fact. At best, you ask a simple question and get the wrong answer; at worst, you get a complex answer that *sounds* right but is full of falsehoods and nonexistent entities. The danger is when you don't know enough yourself to fact-check the AI's response. These "hallucinations" appear in everything from ChatGPT to

Copilot to Google's AI Overviews and more—and as more sketchy websites use AI to create their content, the entire web is barreling toward a future where it becomes one giant hallucination.



Be very wary of the results provided by AI search.

How to stay safe: Never take AI entirely at its word. Ask for citations. Use other non-AI sources to double-check its statements. If you really want to be safe, avoid using AI for anything that hinges on factual accuracy and only use AI for fun or creative tasks. Once you start assuming that everything AI tells you is suspect, you'll be ahead of curve.

THREAT 14: CRIMINAL CONTENT

RED

WHERE IT HAPPENS:
Onion sites, porn sites

The clear-text (nonencrypted) internet that we all use every day is much cleaner than it once was, but illegal content is still always one click away. Some unsafe porn sites have illegal content hiding in their video libraries, and it gets even worse once you start dabbling with the Tor Browser and "onion sites" (that is, the dark web). On the dark web, you can encounter all kinds of dubious, dangerous, and detestable things—hitmen for hire, illicit drug sales, outlawed pornography, other stuff that will scar your mind and can never be unseen, yhe kind of stuff you can actually be arrested and charged with real crimes for.

How to stay safe: Using the Tor Browser to hide your identity online is a good start, as is using a VPN to further obfuscate your online activity. But your best bet is to steer clear of the dark web altogether. A strong antivirus might help protect you against malware, but it won't do

anything for the illegal content you might come across. If you *must* use the dark web, be extremely careful. But seriously, don't.

THREAT 15: COPYRIGHT INFRINGEMENT

ORANGE

WHERE IT HAPPENS:
Torrent sites, illegal

download sites

Any time you download something illegally, you put yourself at risk. If you aren't careful, you can be caught by law enforcement and copyright holders. That popular torrent might seem innocent enough, but it could be a honeypot set up to trap unsuspecting downloaders. On top of that, ISPs like Comcast and Verizon monitor internet activity and can easily tell when you're pirating digital content. All that to say, you could get slapped with a copyright infringement notice—and if that happens, you could lose your internet access and/or face legal consequences.

How to stay safe: Always use a reputable VPN (fave.co/43k8IzX) to mask your identity when you download torrents and visit illegal download sites. A VPN covers up your tracks, so to speak, by preventing ISPs from spying on your traffic and making your internet activity impossible to trace back to you. But again, you need a *reputable* VPN that doesn't store your internet activity. Look for one with a no-logs policy (fave.co/4e0dab3). 🔌



BEST OF COMPUT

THE MOST INTRIGU INNOVATIVE PC HA



EX 2025

ING & ARDWARE

THIS IS THE BEST PC
GEAR FROM THE
BEST PC SHOW.
BY BRAD CHACOS

This year's Computex—the premiere PC industry event of the year, where manufacturers reveal the hardware you'll be able to buy during this year's back to school and holiday shopping seasons—felt more muted than any in recent memory. It's no surprise. US tariffs on Chinese goods have frozen the PC industry (fave.co/4ieSHQe), and vendors are hesitant to announce (much less release) new hardware in such an unstable economic situation.

But still, the show went on—and it's a good thing it did, because while we saw fewer PC announcements at Computex this year, we also saw some certified *bangers*. Which reveals got us deeply, personally excited? This is the best hardware of Computex 2025. Giddy up.

AMD RYZEN THREADRIPPER 9000

In a Computex curiously devoid of chip announcements (well, aside from the new RTX 5060 that Nvidia tried to bury, fave.co/443ZSWH), leave it to AMD to whip out the big guns. The Ryzen Threadripper 9000 series (fave.co/4e1JHNF) focuses on the same overwhelming CPU power as its predecessors, but now comes infused with key power and performance improvements within AMD's new 5nm "Zen 5" architecture.

Threadripper Pro models top out at 96 (!!!) cores, but the standard Threadripper 9000 chips intended for high-end desktops stick to the usual 64, 32, and 24 cores. (How will we ever survive with just 64 cores??!!) Better yet, Threadripper 9000 bumps up



AMD's new Ryzen Threadripper 9000 chips are built for heavy work.

maximum boost clock speeds, and memory speed support improves from DDR5-5200 up to 8-channel DDR5-6400. These monstrous chips are built for *heavy* work.

The only thing missing? We know Threadripper will ship in July, but AMD hasn't revealed pricing. Sigh. Thanks, tariffs.—*Brad Chacos*

ACER SWIFT EDGE 14 AI

I've admired OLED displays for years: first as a generic replacement for a traditional 60Hz laptop display, then as potential gaming displays as refresh rates climbed. Now I've found something new to covet: a matte OLED display without the glare and reflections that trouble most laptops.

So far, I've only seen this on the Acer Swift Edge 14 AI (fave.co/3ZS4Rbx), one of the stars of Computex. But there's more: This 14-inch laptop weighs a feather-light 2.18 pounds while packing an Intel Core Ultra 200 (Lunar Lake) chip inside and offering MIL-STD 810H resilience. That's a true on-the-go productivity machine, with 21 hours of battery life to boot.

While I was also taken with the Swift X creator-class notebook (fave.co/4kLDUyC), I'd still give the, um, edge, to the Edge. It feels like Acer is delivering something other notebooks do not.—*Mark Hachman*



Acer's Swift Edge 14 AI was one of the stars of Computex.

INWIN CHRONOMANCY

Turning 40 is cause for celebration—and boy, did InWin bring a party to Computex. In honor of its milestone anniversary, the company unveiled a jaw-dropping, awe-inspiring bit of case design wizardry: the ChronoMancy.

You could glance at this three-foot-tall (yes) chassis and think, "Who could ever want this?" Me. I want this. I don't build E-ATX systems, sure. But look at that contrast between the transparent blue panel and the gleaming gray body. The way the light looks when shining through the top. The metal vibes when you slide the case open, gray aluminum curving around, and the components sit exposed.



InWin's ChronoMancy is an awe-inspiring bit of design.

Also, you can open it with the wave of a wand. (Or by pressing a button, but there's no fun in that.)

It's perfectly cyberpunk while simultaneously festive. I'll never invest hours into games with that flavor, but I'm definitely tempted to sink money into this likely astronomically expensive case.—*Alaina Yee*

ASUS ROG FALCATA KEYBOARD

Aside from some cool cases, the only thing I saw at Computex that really got my nerdy attention was the ROG

Falcata, a split gaming keyboard from Asus (fave.co/4n2b66o). This is the sort of very niche, targeted keyboard that's extremely rare to see from gaming manufacturers—in fact, I don't think I've ever seen a split gaming board from a big brand, never mind one that's also wireless.

Little touches like the many different angle and tenting options and the removable wrist rest give me hope that this has been made with both gamers and ergonomic users in mind, and I appreciate that it doesn't need a driver package installed to access its advanced adjustable features. Also, I really hope you can use the left side on its own...but that might just be me (fave.co/4l8dwyE). I couldn't get confirmation on that this far out from a late 2025 release date.—*Michael Crider*



The ROG Falcata is the sort of niche, targeted keyboard that's rare from gaming manufacturers.



SilverStone's case may look old-school, but inside it's built for modern PC demands.

SILVERSTONE FLP-02

Look, man, I'm old. My beard hair is more white than black these days, I make weird little grunts when I stand up, all that jazz. But age comes with a perk: SilverStone's new retro-style FLP-02 case is pure catnip for an old dude like me whose first computer was an Intel 486 system in, yes, a beige box.

The case may look old-school—it even has an honest-to-goodness-actually working *Turbo button* on its custom control panel—but inside, it's built for modern PC demands. It's a fully standard ATX case even if it looks like it fell out of a time machine, and it's the first one I've seen in a long time that has real 5.25-inch drive bays. Now get off my lawn.
—Brad Chacos

MSI PRESTIGE 13 AI+ UKIYO-E EDITION

I usually don't get excited about laptop designs—they're all just gray rectangles to me. But the MSI Prestige 13 AI+ Ukiyo-e Edition stopped me in my tracks. Is that Hokusai's iconic Great Wave Off Kanagawa painting on the lid? Yes. Yes, it is. The handcrafted rendition of the famous painting was achieved by applying multiple layers of translucent ink and lacquer by hand. It's designed to

inspire a sense of calm, but it just leaves me feeling awestruck.

While the artwork is definitely the star of the show here, the MSI Prestige 13 AI+ is no slouch in the performance department. It's got up to an Intel Core Ultra 9 185H processor, up to 32GB of DDR5 RAM, and a 13-inch 2880×1800 OLED display.

The internals are impressive, sure, but with only



The MSI Prestige 13 AI+ Ukiyo-e Editions design stopped me in my tracks.

a limited run of 1,000 units, you'll be lucky to snag one for yourself.—Ash Biancuzzo

G.SKILL'S SPARKLY NEW TRIDENT Z5 NEOX RGB RAM

I won't lie, I've been a fan of G.Skill RAM for a long time—and not because their DIMMs perform well. (That's just table stakes.)

No, they understand perfectly what my inner crow loves. They first had me with their now perennial-favorite Trident Z RGB line, then captured me with the ultra shiny Trident Z Royal in gold and silver.

And this week at Computex 2025, I got my true heart's desire—almost. G.Skill's display of its new Trident Z5 NeoX RGB lineup, which I first spotted in this awesome Paul's Hardware video (fave.co/4jLBwX1) full of rad modded PCs, includes a concept finish that I badly want to be real. The sparkly silver is a more elegant take than the Trident Z Royal's high-shine silver. I like my builds blingy, but



The Trident Z5 NeoX RGB sparkly silver is a concept finish that I badly want to be real.

sometimes a bit of understatement hits harder.

G.Skill is taking feedback, so if you also dig the finish, I recommend you also let them know you want that sparkly version. Prefer a louder take? Neon yellow and orange are color options as well, and sport beautifully shiny clear coats. Oh, and there's white too, I guess. But c'mon. *Sparkly silver.*—Alaina Yee

CHERRY'S WILD NEW KEYBOARD SWITCHES

This year at Computex, Cherry unveiled that it's releasing not one, not two, but *four* new keyboard switches (fave.co/402sZlc). Three of the new switches will be added to Cherry's existing line of MX mechanical switches: The MX Honey is its first silent tactile switch, the MX Blossom is a low actuation switch for light typing, and the MX Falcon is a strong tactile switch for that clacky typewriter experience.

The fourth switch is the one that has me most excited, though. Cherry also debuted the brand new next-gen analog IK switch. Built with inductive sensing technology, the IK switch promises "consistent performance with no mechanical wear." The switch also consumes 50% less power than magnetic switches, so it'll be great for wireless keyboards as well. If that wasn't enough, the IK switches will feature RGB lighting and



Cherry unveiled four new keyboard switches.

customizable actuation—the keyboard geek in me is itching to get ahold of these bad boys. All of the new switches are due out this year, with the MX switches set for June and the IK switch to follow in the fall.—*Sam Singleton*

sitting in your shame, you can rely on your PC to put out a nice smell to sweeten the room. First Yeston makes a scented GPU, and now ID-Cooling makes scented thermal paste. I'm in love.—*Adam Patrick Murray*. 

ID-COOLING'S SCENTED THERMAL PASTE

I have been on the hunt for scented thermal paste for years, and at Computex 2025 I finally found it at the ID-Cooling booth! Yes, I said *scented* thermal paste. Why would someone want that, you ask? Well, not only does it smell good while you are building your PC, I'm hoping it also gives off a scent when your gaming PC is on and under load.

Listen, we've all been on hourlong marathon sessions, eating loads of Taco Bell, so rather than



ID-Cooling's scented thermal paste.

Your buzz could kill.

Buzzed driving is drunk driving.





Make your Windows 11 taskbar transparent for a cool vibe

This simple change makes a huge difference! **BY DOMINIC BAYLEY**

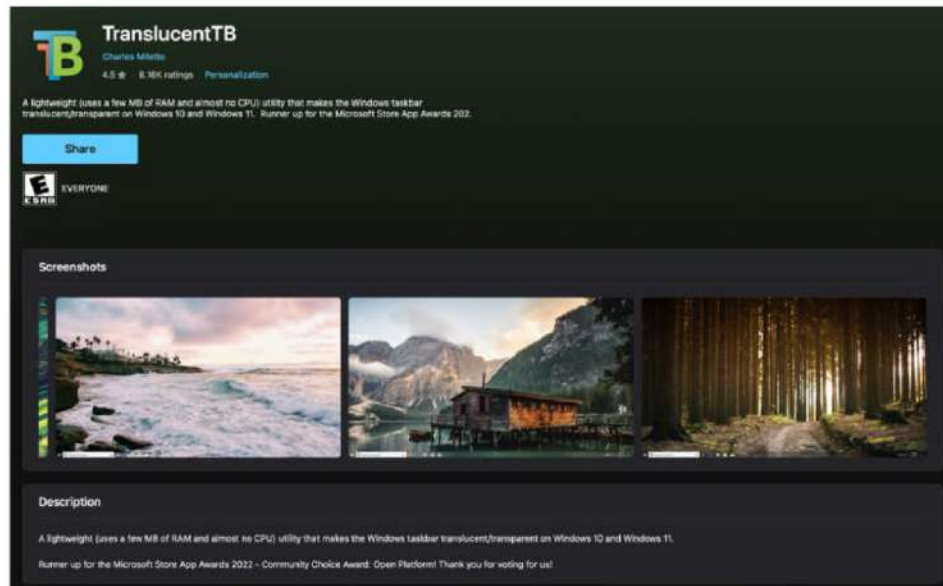
Having a full Windows 11 taskbar at the bottom of my display seems like a waste of space to me, seeing as I tend to pin just a few icons to it—my browser, Word, Teams, and Zoom.

In fact, the taskbar just obscures part of my wallpaper, takes my focus off the apps I'm using, and makes my desktop look banal—like everyone else's. That's why I've now made

it transparent, and I'm loving the minimalist vibes I get.

Windows 11 offers a native transparency in Settings > Personalization > Colors, but it's more of a frosted glass effect that doesn't really give me what I'm looking for.

To make the taskbar fully transparent and achieve a cleaner aesthetic, I use the TranslucentTB app (fave.co/3Hype7g), which you can download for free from the Microsoft



TranslucentTB is available from Microsoft's App Store.

Store. It's an open-source tool developed for Windows that lets you adjust the opacity and color of your taskbar.

WHAT TO DO:

- Download and install the TranslucentTB app (fave.co/3Hype7g).

- Click the System Tray Arrow next to the OneDrive icon on the Windows taskbar. Now find the TranslucentTB icon (TB) and click on it to open it.

- In the menu, navigate to Visible Window and select "clear" from the drop-down menu to make the taskbar transparent.

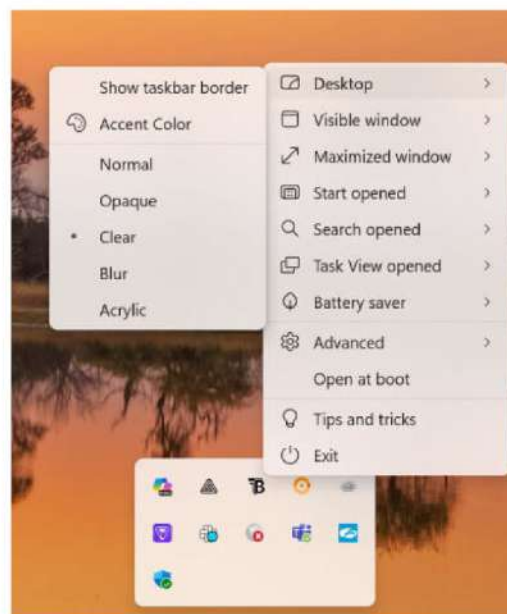
- You can choose to apply other effects in Visible Window, like make the taskbar blurry or change its color.

If you find the above doesn't

work, you might need to tweak your Security and Privacy settings in Windows to allow the app to run properly. You can do that by typing **Win + I**, then navigating to Privacy and Security > Windows Security > App and Browser control, and allowing permissions.

TranslucentTB also lets you select the

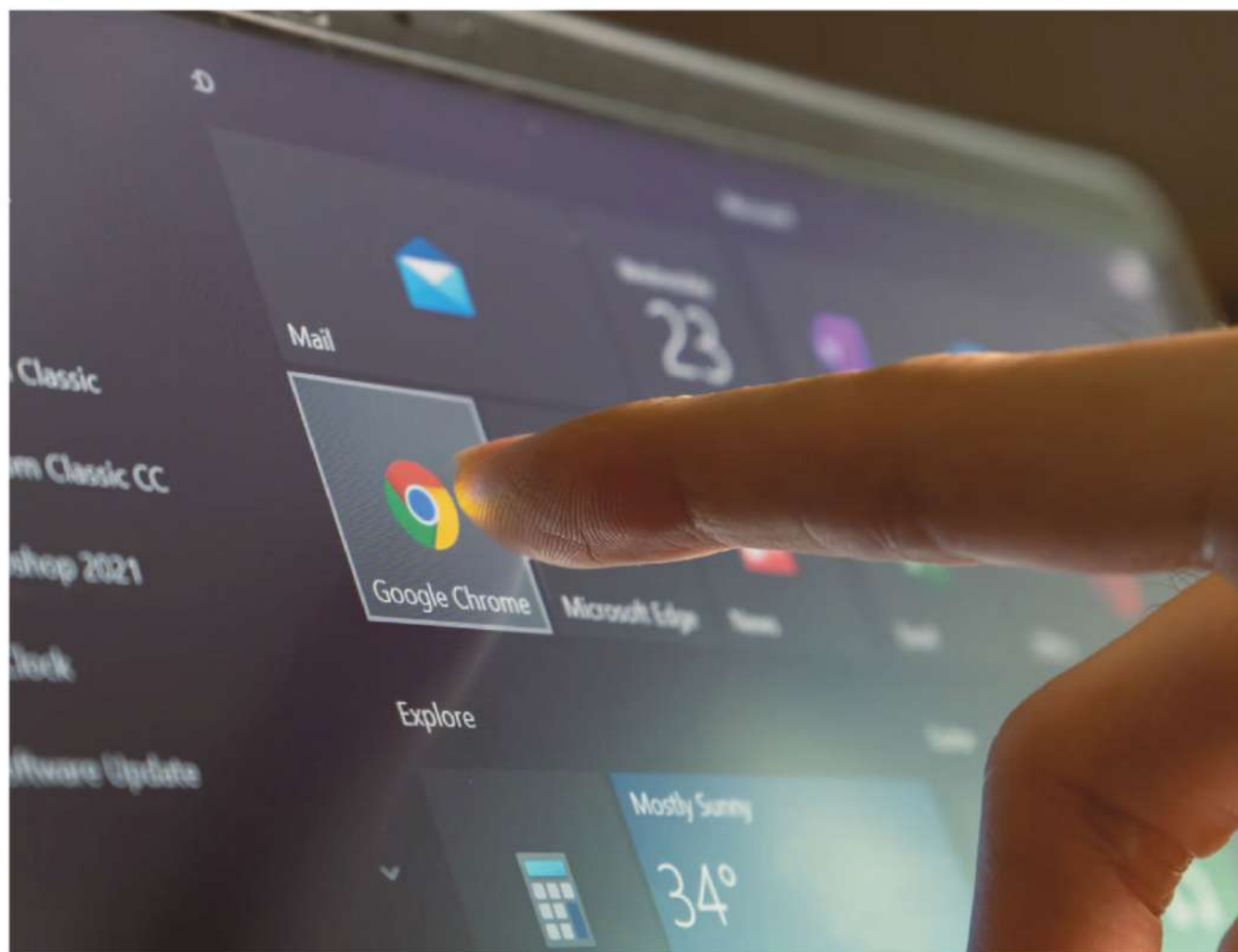
dynamic behavior of the taskbar so that it changes depending on what you're doing. For example, you can make it so that the taskbar becomes transparent only when a window is maximized, so be sure to play around with the many options you get to personalize it. 



Navigating the settings menu in TranslucentTB.

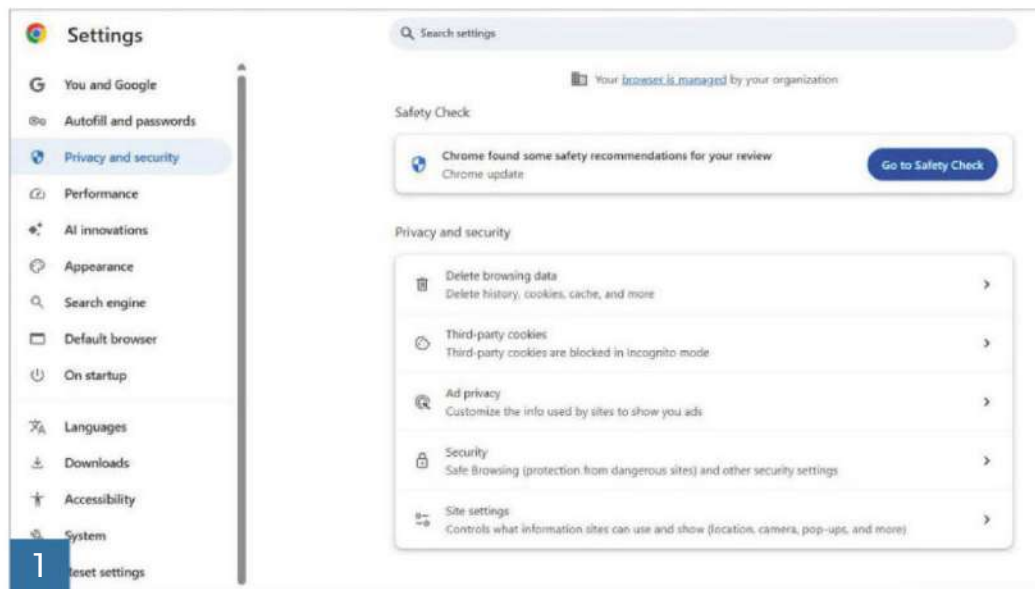
Use this tucked-away Chrome feature to surf the web more safely

Safety has always been paramount when surfing the web. Fortunately, Chrome has a nifty feature that keeps you safe with minimal effort. **BY MARTIN APPEL AND JOEL LEE**



Google Chrome has a built-in feature called Safety Check, first introduced in 2020 and regularly improved ever since, with its most recent revamp happening back in September 2024.

Safety Check runs in the background and proactively keeps tabs on your passwords, your Safe Browsing settings, your Chrome version, your site permissions, your extensions, and potentially unwanted and/or abusive notifications. When Safety Check spots issues



“Safety at a glance,” along with some alerts. (2). For example, you can see if Chrome is up to date, if you have any compromised passwords, and whether Safe Browsing is on. Anything with a green tick is

or areas with room for improvement, it’ll let you know along with instructions.

Here’s how to use Safety Check:

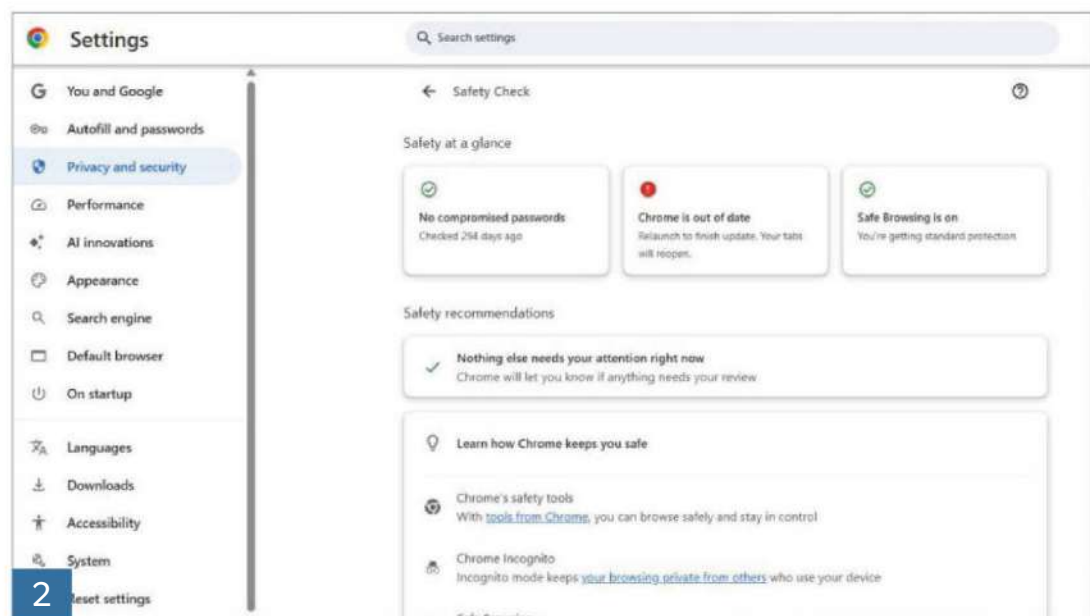
Navigate to Chrome’s Settings page by clicking on the **three-dot menu** at the top right and selecting **Settings**.

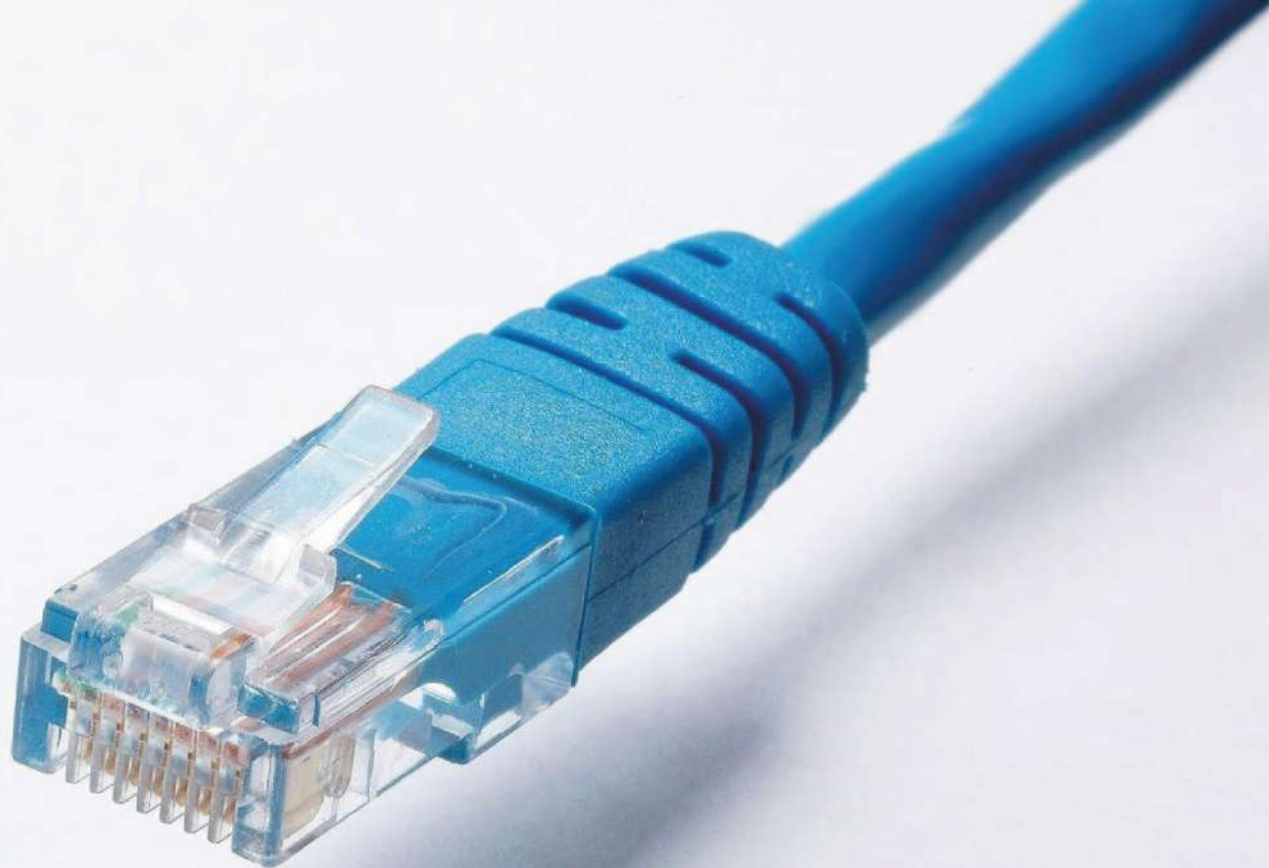
In the left-side panel, navigate to **Privacy and security**. Then, in the right-side main area, look for the Safety Check section and click on the button labeled **Go to Safety Check (1)**.

At the top of the Safety Check page, you’ll see a section called

good; anything with a red exclamation mark warrants your attention.

Below that, in the section labeled “Safety recommendations,” you might see other security issues Chrome wants to raise. For example, it might tell you about some websites you haven’t visited in a long time that have thus lost their authorizations. 🔴





I thought Ethernet cables were all the same. I was very, very wrong

The different Ethernet standards explained! **BY DOMINIC BAYLEY**

If you've been browsing Ethernet cables online, you may have seen they come with names like CAT 5, CAT 6, CAT 7, and CAT 8. And no, we're not talking about the feline kind of CAT...meow! So what does all that mean, and is there any difference between these various Ethernet cables?

DEFINING CAT IN ETHERNET CABLES

The CAT label in Ethernet cables stands for "category," which denotes its standard and specification. You can tell which category the

cables belong to by the number suffix each one has.

The main difference between the different categories is the rated performance of each. They also have different wire configurations and other variations in how they are made, like how tightly they are wound, and some have inner plastic tubing.

Just like USB cables, Ethernet cables get faster and more efficient with each successive generation released. That's great news for gamers looking for faster and more reliable cables for lag-free network gaming.

CAT AND DATA TRANSFER SPEEDS

CAT 5 and CAT 5e (fave.co/444vtav) cables are an early generation of Ethernet cable dating back to the early noughties. CAT 5 cables provide data transmission speeds up to 100Mbps at 100MHz, whereas CAT 5e cables are slightly superior, providing speeds up to 1,000Mbps at 100MHz. That means CAT 5e cables tend to be a little more stable and less prone to lag than CAT 5 cables.

Both CAT 5 and CAT 5e cable types are quick enough for most household or work-related network needs, whether that be to hook up multiple PCs or external devices like printers. They're widely used by small offices, schools, and colleges for things like hubs, switches, and routers.

That said, since the newer CAT 6 cables (fave.co/44qTLvB) have come out, gamers and users needing higher data transfer speeds have homed in on these instead. That's because CAT 6 cables are 10 times quicker. They provide data transfer speeds up to 10Gbps at frequencies up to 250MHz.

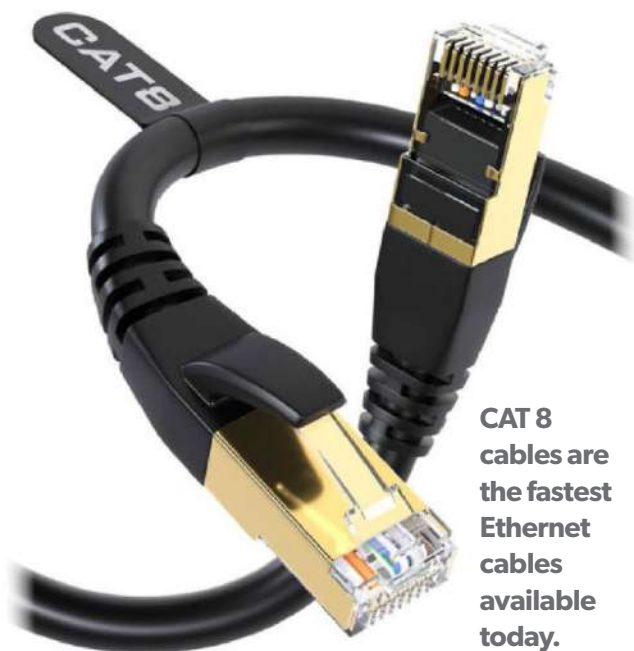
These cables also have better shielding to prevent electromagnetic interference, so they are less susceptible to cross-talk and noise. That makes them even more stable and very suitable for users that do a lot of videoconferencing or that work in the cloud—so they're ideal for professional workplaces and educational facilities like hospitals or government agencies.

In the CAT 6 category, there's also CAT 6a cables, fave.co/4kM0qr0 (uncertified CATe cables, fave.co/3HCthPZ), which are a step up again in functionality. CAT 6e cables are capable of transferring data at the same 10Gbps as their CAT 6 counterparts, but they support higher frequencies still (up to 500MHz)—so if you're looking to build a very stable 10Gbps network, these cables will provide even more surety against interference and lag during heavy data loads.

After CAT 6e comes CAT 7 cables. These Ethernet cables again provide quick transfer speeds of up to 10Gbps, but they support even faster frequencies up to 600MHz.

The problem with CAT 7 cables, however, is that they were originally made to support GG45 or TERA connectors instead of the more common RJ45 connectors (used in CAT 5, CAT 6, and CAT 6e cables). GG45 and TERA standards were never widely adopted by hardware manufacturers. CAT 7 cables can be used with RJ45 connectors, but doing so relegates their bandwidth back to that of a CAT 6 or CAT 6e cable, so you won't get the extra bandwidth benefit.

In case you were wondering, there are also CAT 8 Ethernet cables (fave.co/4jVIRDr), which are the fastest Ethernet cables available today. These cables break the 10Gbps data transfer limit of previous generations by using a 2GHz signal to move data up to 20Gbps or 40Gbps. Because of their very high data transfer speeds and



bandwidth, these cables are frequently installed by big businesses like data centers, financial institutions, research institutions, and broadcasting studios that require the very fastest Ethernet connections available.

That said, I have also found a few operators offering installation purely for gamers, so their use in gaming is becoming more popular.

It's worth noting that the CAT rating isn't the only factor in your network speed: Cables *can handle* a given data transmission speed, not *provide* it. You can plug a CAT6 cable into any router, but if the router's port only delivers 100Mbps versus 1Gbps, the speed at which data is sent over the cable is only going to be 100Mbps—regardless of what the cable is rated to handle. The ultimate hardwired speed of your network is going to be only as fast as its slowest component.

WHAT ETHERNET CABLE IS BEST FOR PC GAMING?

The theoretical answer to that question is, of course, a CAT 8 cable. Then again, using a CAT 8 cable isn't necessarily a practical option for most gamers. It's speed and bandwidth overkill. You can have a perfectly lag-free gaming experience with an Ethernet cable from a previous generation.

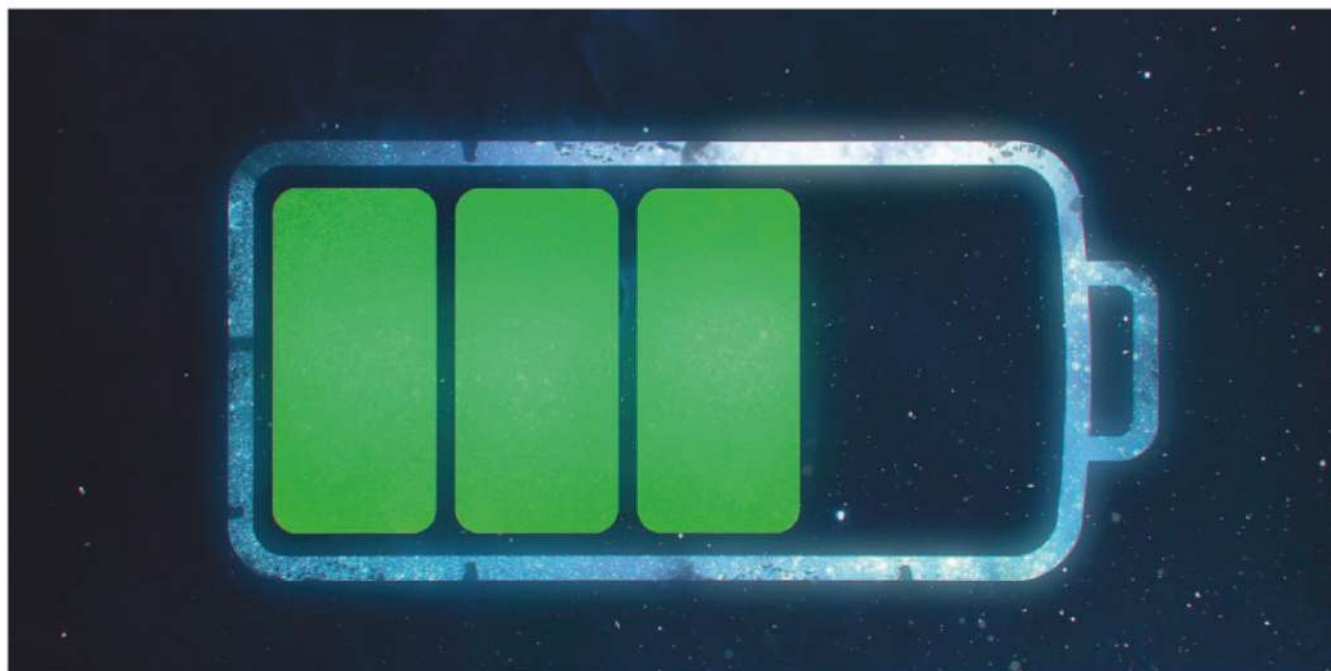
Most gamers won't be able to utilize the quick speeds of a CAT 8 cable because of limiting factors, like the speed of their primary router or modem. The main reason to get one, though, is if you want to future-proof your Ethernet performance. These cables used to be very expensive, but they're a lot more affordable now, so getting one won't break the budget.

That said, gamers can get away with a CAT 6 or CAT 6e cable just fine, since the fastest PC desktop Ethernet cards only currently support up to a maximum 10Gbps transfer speed (cards like the Asus XG-C100C, fave.co/4n4gyWd). In fact, even 1Gbps transfer speeds are quick enough for gaming. CAT 6 and CAT 6e cables are fast enough and provide an excellent balance between performance, reliability, and price.

I hope that clears up any confusion around the different types of Ethernet cables. Also be sure to decide on the length of the cable you need before you buy, because the different CAT standards have their own maximum cable lengths. Happy cable hunting! 🔌

This neat trick instantly reveals if a battery is charged or dead

Try this simple trick at home! **BY DOMINIC BAYLEY**



Hey, PCWorlders! Today I want to show you a neat trick. As you no doubt understand, discovering you have dead batteries in any device can be a real drag. To stop that happening, I frequently swap my batteries out with fresh ones before they go totally flat.

As to the old ones, I usually store them in a bag to recycle later—or to use in a pinch. But on the odd occasion when I forget to swap out my battery, get a flat in my device, and have no spares left, I have to rifle through that bag and test out each battery to find one with enough charge left in it.

Correction: That's what I used to do. Now I have a method that saves me a bunch of time.

WHAT TO DO

- Find a flat, firm surface, like a table or a book—this will be your test surface.
- Drop the battery vertically onto that surface from a height of roughly 8 inches (20cm). Watch what the battery does.
- A fully charged battery will tend to tip over and stay put. A flat battery, however, often bounces back up a few centimeters, so you know it's not worth using. 



It's always been
easier for me to
help others
than to
help myself

As a Veteran, when someone raises their hand for help, you're often one of the first ones to respond. But it's also okay to get help for yourself. Maybe you want or need assistance with employment, stress, finances, mental health or finding the right resources. No matter what it is, you earned it. And there's no better time than right now to ask for it. **Don't wait. Reach out.**



VA



U.S. Department
of Veterans Affairs

Find resources at [VA.GOV/REACH](https://www.va.gov/reach)

Tech Spotlight

A video showcase of the latest trends



Exploring Micro Center on opening day!

➡ On May 30, 2025, Micro Center opened its long-awaited Santa Clara, California, store. The PCWorld crew headed over to the new nerd mecca to check out the festivities.